



ARGENE
LUPIN

VS



SHERLOCK
HOLMES

MAURICE
LEBLANC

Arsène Lupin
vs
Sherlock Holmes

Maurice Leblanc

Translated by David Carter

Illustrations by Thomas Müller

ALMA CLASSICS



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Translator's Introduction

The very title of Maurice Leblanc's book arouses the reader's curiosity and expectations. Any established fan of Arsène Lupin will be immediately attracted of course, but even someone coming for the first time upon tales about this suave, French gentleman thief cannot fail to be intrigued by the coupling of his name with that of the world-renowned fictional English private detective. For the Englishman's name is so thinly disguised that the real identity of Lupin's opponent is unmistakable. In the French original he appears as "Herlock Sholmès", which the first English translator reinterpreted imaginatively as "Holmlock Shears". Why bother with such a transparent ruse? The answer is to be found in the historical context of the original publication of the stories.

The author, Maurice Leblanc (1864–1941), might have been condemned to literary obscurity if it had not been for the runaway success of his Arsène Lupin stories. He was born in Rouen, Normandy, and was educated in a local lycée. He studied in various countries, went to law school but dropped out, and finally settled down in Paris to become a writer of short fiction and novels. For a long time his works were admired but did not meet with much commercial success. Then, in 1905, the editor of a new periodical approached him with a request to write a story in the manner of the Sherlock Holmes stories by Sir Arthur Conan Doyle. The new magazine itself, *Je Sais Tout*, was closely modelled on the English *Strand* magazine, in which the original Sherlock Holmes stories were published. The Holmes stories were already popular in France, so that there was a ready market. It is clear therefore that there is a close relationship between the Lupin adventures and those of Holmes, although the majority of those about Lupin do not also feature Holmes as a character. Altogether Leblanc wrote twenty-one works, some of them novels and others collections of short stories, which feature the gentleman thief.

The first collection of short stories about Arsène Lupin to be published together in book form was *Arsène Lupin, Gentleman Burglar*, in 1907. The stories had originally appeared separately in *Je Sais Tout*. It is in one of these stories that Sherlock Holmes makes his first appearance alongside

Arsène Lupin. When he heard of it, Conan Doyle objected to the use of his fictional character and the name which he had invented. Thus it came about that in the book edition the name was changed to “Herlock Sholmès”. Under this name the character reappeared in two more stories published in the second volume of stories, *Arsène Lupin contre Herlock Sholmès*, 1908, which is the basis of the present volume. The first story, ‘The Blonde Woman’, appeared originally in the magazine between November 1906 and April 1907, and the second story, ‘The Jewish Lamp’, appeared there in September and October , 1907. The first English translations were available in 1910.

Thus Leblanc clearly exploited the popularity of the Sherlock Holmes stories while staying within the law and only parodying the creations of the English writer. He was also careful to modify names in other allusions in his stories, but not so much that any intelligent reader could not easily identify them. Thus Watson becomes Wilson, “221b Baker Street” becomes “219 Parker Street” and, rather oddly perhaps, the car brand Peugeot becomes “Peugeon”.

Fans of Conan Doyle’s stories will soon realize that his two famous characters are affectionately parodied in Leblanc’s treatment of them. The following exchange is typical of them as represented in Leblanc’s stories:

“Wilson, give me your opinion: Why was Lupin in that restaurant?”

Wilson did not hesitate.

“To eat.”

“Wilson, the more we work together, the more I perceive how you continue to progress. My word, you are becoming amazing.”

Sholmes appears so obsessed with his own genius that he is completely insensitive to his friend’s injuries and subsequent sufferings. And Wilson is lost in wide-eyed admiration of Sholmes to the point of unquestioning obedience to his instructions.

Leblanc was not the only writer tempted to keep Sherlock Holmes alive by incorporating him in his own fiction. In fact, it became a popular sport in many countries, including not only France, but also Germany, Spain and Russia. A detailed account, with examples, of the most successful of these resuscitations can be found in *The Further Adventures of Sherlock Holmes*, collected and introduced by Richard Lancelot Green (1983), and

the extensive influence of Conan Doyle's creations is explored in *Shadows of Sherlock Holmes*, selected and introduced by David Stuart Davis (1998).

Arsène Lupin himself has had a considerable afterlife. A remarkable reincarnation occurred in a Japanese manga comic in 1967. A certain Arsène Lupin III appears, claiming to be the grandson of the original gentleman thief. The Leblanc estate gave no permission for this metamorphosis of the character and a lawsuit ensued. When the animé version of this (*Rupan sansei*, 1971–72) was finally released in France, the character was renamed “*Edgar, le détective cambrioleur*” (“Edgar, the burglar detective”).

There have also been various attempts to adapt the adventures of Arsène Lupin as films. Amongst others, there was an early silent version made in America in 1917, entitled *Arsene Lupin* (and lacking the accent), starring Earle Williams and directed by Paul Scardon, for the Vitagraph company. It was based on a play by Francis le Croisset. John Barrymore played Lupin in the MGM version of the same play in 1932, with Barrymore's brother Lionel as Chief Inspector Ganimard. And in *Arsène Lupin Returns*, also by MGM, in 1938, Lupin was played by Melvyn Douglas. Then in 1944 Charles Korvin played Lupin in *Enter Arsène Lupin*, made by Universal under the direction of Ford Beebe. There was a French film directed by Jacques Becker, in 1957, called *Les Aventures d'Arsène Lupin*, starring Robert Lamoureux. Then in 1971 there was a French TV series, directed by Jean-Pierre Decourt, with Georges Déscrières as Lupin, broadcast between 1971 and 1972. One episode broadcast in 1971 was in fact based on Lupin's encounters with the great English sleuth, and starred Henri Virlojeux as “Herlock Sholmès”. Most recently there has been *Les Aventures d'Arsène Lupin* (2004), directed by Jean-Paul Salomé and starring Romain Duris. The consensus of critical opinion would seem to be that this film failed to capture the irony, wit and charm of Leblanc's character.

Finally it should be mentioned that a computer game was released in October, 2007 with the title *Sherlock Holmes versus Arsène Lupin*, but its plotline bears little resemblance to Leblanc's stories.

CONVENTIONS IN THE PRESENT TRANSLATION

As already indicated, Leblanc modified the names and other details borrowed from the works of Conan Doyle. These modifications have been retained in the present translation, with the exception of the spelling of the name “Herlock Sholmès”. It has been decided to drop the *accent grave* and render it thus as “Herlock Sholmes”, as this is more natural for an English reader to pronounce. Leblanc also utilizes many ellipses in his writing. These have been retained where they clearly indicate uncertainty or omission, etc. Many which have no clear expressive purpose have been omitted. The names of French streets and places have been left in the original language.

– David Carter, 2015

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Arsène Lupin vs Sherlock Holmes

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First Episode

THE BLONDE WOMAN

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ON 8TH OF DECEMBER LAST YEAR, M. Gerbois, a teacher of mathematics at the Versailles secondary school, discovered among the jumble of things in an old curiosity shop a small mahogany writing desk which he liked on account of its large number of drawers.

“That’s just what I need for Suzanne’s birthday,” he thought.

And as he did his best – as far as his modest means would allow – to please his daughter, he negotiated a price and paid the sum of sixty-five francs.

Just as he was giving his address, a young man with an elegant figure, and who was already rummaging around left and right, noticed the item of furniture and asked:

“How much?”

“It’s sold,” replied the shopkeeper.

“Ah!... to this gentleman, perhaps?”

M. Gerbois nodded and, all the happier to have acquired the piece of furniture now that one of his fellow men was coveting it, he left.

But he had not gone ten paces along the street before he was joined by the young man, who, with his hat in his hand and in an extremely courteous tone, said to him:

“I beg your pardon most humbly, sir... I wish to ask you an indiscreet question... Were you looking for that writing desk more particularly than any other item?”

“No, I was looking for a second-hand pair of scales for certain experiments in physics.”

“So, you don’t especially like it?”

“I just like it. That’s all.”

“Because it’s an antique, perhaps?”

“Because it’s a handy thing.”

“In that case, would you agree to exchange it for a writing desk that is just as handy but in a better condition?”

“This one is in a good condition, so there seems to me to be no point in

exchanging it.”

“Yet—”

M. Gerbois was a man who was easily irritated and of a tetchy nature. He replied curtly:

“I must ask you, sir, not to insist.”

The stranger placed himself in front of him.

“I don’t know what price you paid for it, sir... I offer you double.

“No.”

“Treble?”

“Just stop right there,” exclaimed the teacher, irritated. “It belongs to me and it’s not for sale.”

The young man looked at him fixedly, in a manner which M. Gerbois was not to forget, and then, without a word, turned on his heels and went away.

An hour later the piece of furniture was brought to the small house on the Viroflay road in which the teacher lived. He summoned his daughter.

“This is for you, Suzanne, if you find it suitable of course.”

Suzanne was a pretty creature, outgoing and of a happy disposition. She flung herself round her father’s neck and embraced him with as much joy as if he had offered her a gift fit for a queen.

The same evening, after having put it in her room with the help of the maid, Hortense, she cleaned the drawers and carefully arranged in them her papers, her boxes of letters, her correspondence, her collection of postcards and some secret mementoes of her cousin Philippe.

The next day, at half-past seven, M. Gerbois went to the secondary school. At ten o’clock, Suzanne, following her daily routine, was waiting for him at the exit, and it was a great pleasure for him to catch sight of her on the pavement opposite the gate, with her graceful figure and her childlike smile.

They went back home together.

“And how do you like your writing desk?”

“It’s absolutely marvellous! Hortense and I polished the brass fittings. You’d think they were made of gold.”

“So you’re pleased with it?”

“Yes, I’m pleased with it! I mean, I don’t know how I managed without it before.”

They went across the garden in front of the house.

M. Gerbois made a suggestion:

“How about going to look at it before dinner?”

“Oh, yes! That’s a good idea.”

She went up first, but as she reached the doorway of her room, she uttered a cry of alarm.

“What’s wrong?” mumbled M. Gerbois.

He followed her into the room. *The writing desk was no longer there.*

What amazed the examining magistrate was the admirable simplicity of the methods used. While Suzanne was out and the maid was doing her shopping, a delivery man, displaying his identity badge – which was seen by the neighbours – had stopped his cart in front of the garden and rung twice. The neighbours, unaware that the maid was out, were not at all suspicious, so that the individual could carry out his task completely undisturbed.

It should be pointed out here that no cabinet was broken open, and no clock disturbed. What is more, Suzanne’s purse, which she had left on the marble top of the writing desk, was found on the nearby table with the few gold coins that it contained. The motive for the theft could therefore be clearly ascertained, which made the theft that much more inexplicable, for why so many risks for such a negligible gain?

The only clue which the teacher could provide was the incident of the previous day:

“When I refused, the young man immediately appeared extremely vexed, and I had the very distinct impression that he left me with an air of menace.

This was very vague. The shopkeeper was questioned. He did not know either of the two gentlemen. As for the object itself, he had bought it for forty francs in Chevreuse, in a post-mortem sale, and believed that he had sold it again at its true value. The inquiries that were conducted could discover nothing more.

But M. Gerbois remained convinced that he had endured a great wrong. A fortune must have been concealed in the false bottom of a drawer, and that was the reason why the young man, who knew its hiding place, had acted in such a decisive way.

“Poor father, what would we have done with such a fortune?” Suzanne said to him several times.

“What do you mean? With such a dowry, you could aspire to a match of the highest order.”

Suzanne, who had been limiting her aspirations to her cousin Philippe, who was a pathetic match, sighed bitterly. And in the little house in Versailles, life continued, less cheerfully, less carefree, clouded with regret and disappointment.

Two months passed. And suddenly there occurred a succession of the most serious events, an unforeseen sequence of good luck and catastrophes!

On the 1st of February, at five thirty, M. Gerbois, who had just returned home, with the evening paper in his hand, sat down, put on his glasses and started to read. As he was not interested in politics, he turned over the page. His attention was immediately drawn to an article entitled : ‘Third Draw of the Press Association Lottery’.

The newspaper slipped from his fingers. The walls swayed before his eyes, and his heart stopped beating. Number 514 – series 23. That was his number! He had bought it by chance, as a favour to one of his friends, as he did not really believe in fate. And now he had won!

He quickly pulled out his notebook. There it was, clearly written down as a memo on the endpaper: number 514 – series 23. But where was the ticket?

He dashed off to his study to look for the box of envelopes among which he had slipped the precious ticket, and as soon as he entered the room he stopped dead, feeling staggered again as his heart contracted: the box of envelopes was not there! And the terrifying thing was that he suddenly realized that it had not been there for several weeks. For weeks he had not seen it in front of him at those times when he was correcting his pupils’ homework!

There was the sound of footsteps on the gravel in the garden. He called out: “Suzanne! Suzanne!” She came running and hurried upstairs. He stammered in a choked voice:

“Suzanne... the box... the box of envelopes?”

“Which one?”

“The one from the Louvre... which I brought once on a Thursday... and which was on the end of this table.”

“But you remember, Father... we put them away together...”

“When?”

“In the evening... you know... the day before...”

“But where? Tell me... You’ll be the death of me...”

“Where?... In the writing desk.”

“In the writing desk that was stolen?”

“Yes.”

“In the writing desk that was stolen!”

He repeated the words in a very low voice in a kind of horror. Then he grasped her hand and in an even lower voice said:

“My dear daughter, it contained a million francs...”

“Oh, Father, why didn’t you tell me?” she murmured naively.

“A million!” he continued. “It was the Press Association lottery ticket for the winning number.”

The enormity of the disaster overwhelmed them, and for a long time they stood in silence, which they did not have the courage to break.

Finally Suzanne spoke:

“But Father, they’ll pay you out for it in any case.”

“Why would they? What proof do they have?”

“You need to have proof?”

“For God’s sake!”

“You don’t have any?”

“I have one piece of proof.”

“So?...”

“It’s in the box.”

“In the box that disappeared?”

“Yes. The other person will get it.”

“But that would be terrible! Look, Father, can’t you make some kind of complaint?”

“Who knows? Who knows? The man must be very powerful! He has such resources at his disposal!... Remember... that business with the piece of furniture...”

He got up with a sudden burst of energy, and stamping his foot, said:

“Right! No, no, he won’t get the million, he won’t get it! Why should he?”

After all, as clever as he is, even he can't do anything about it. If he presents himself to cash it in, they'll put him away. Oh yes, we shall see, my good man!"

"So, you have an idea, Father?"

"To defend our rights, all the way, whatever happens! And we will succeed!... The million francs is mine, and I'll get it!"

A few minutes later he sent off the following dispatch:

To the Director of the Crédit Foncier, Rue Capucines, Paris. I am the owner of number 514 – series 23. I oppose by all legal means all outside claims. Gerbois.

Almost at the same time another telegram arrived at the Crédit Foncier:

Number 514 – series 23 is in my possession. Arsène Lupin.

Every time I undertake to relate one of the countless adventures which constitute the life of Arsène Lupin, I become really confused, because it seems to me so clear that the most commonplace of his adventures is known to all those people who will read my account. Indeed there is not one act performed by our "national thief", as he has been so nicely called, that has not been reported in the most sensational way, not an exploit of his that has not been studied in all its aspects, not an action that has not been commented on in such an abundance of detail that is usually reserved for reports on the actions of heroes.

Who, for example, does not know this strange story of 'The Blonde Woman', with its strange episodes which the reporters entitled in large print: Number 514 – Series 23!... The Crime on Avenue Henri-Martin!... The Blue Diamond!... What a fuss there was about the intervention of the famous detective Herlock Sholmes! ^{*} What a turmoil after each of the twists and turns which marked the conflict between these two great artistes. And what a racket there was on the boulevards on the day when the newspaper sellers were loudly proclaiming "The Arrest of Arsène Lupin"!

My excuse is that I am providing something new: I am providing the answer to the enigma. There is still some shadowy quality surrounding these adventures and I shall dissipate it. I shall reproduce articles which have been read and reread, and I shall make new copies of old interviews. But all of these I shall coordinate, classify and test for their validity. My

collaborator is Arsène Lupin, whose readiness to help me is inexhaustible. And it is also, in this case, the ineffable Wilson, the friend and confidant of Sholmes.

One remembers the tremendous burst of laughter which greeted the publication of the double telegram. The very name of Arsène Lupin is a guarantee of something unexpected, a promise of entertainment for the gallery. And the gallery in this case is the whole world.

From the investigations conducted immediately by the Crédit Foncier, it was concluded that number 514 – series 23 had been issued by the Crédit Lyonnais, at their Versailles branch, to the artillery major Bessy. Well, this major had died by falling off his horse. It was discovered from his comrades, to whom he had confided the fact, that he must have given his ticket to a friend.

“That friend was me,” confirmed M. Gerbois.

“Then prove it!” objected the director of the Crédit Foncier.

“You want me to prove it? That’s quite easy. There are at least twenty people who will tell you that I had a steady acquaintanceship with the major and that we used to meet in the café on the Place d’Armes. That’s where, one day, to oblige him when he was momentarily embarrassed, I took possession of his ticket for the sum of twenty francs.”

“Do you have witnesses to this exchange?”

“No.”

“In that case, on what do you base your claim?”

“On the letter he wrote to me on this matter.”

“Which letter?”

“A letter that was pinned to the ticket.”

“Show it to me.”

“But it was in the stolen writing desk!”

“Then find it!”

It was Arsène Lupin himself who made the announcement. A message was put in *L’Écho de France* – which has the honour of being his official organ and of which he is, it seems, one of the principal shareholders. The message announced that he was putting into the hands of Maître Detinan, his legal advisor, the letter which Major Bessy had written to him personally.

There was an outburst of merriment: Arsène Lupin was consulting a

lawyer! Arsène Lupin, playing by the established rules, had designated a member of the bar to represent him!

All the journalists rushed to see Maître Detinan, who was an influential radical deputy, a man of high integrity, who at the same time had a fine mind and was something of a sceptic and inclined to be paradoxical.

Maître Detinan had never had the pleasure of meeting Arsène Lupin – and he regretted it deeply – but he had indeed just received his instructions and, very touched at the honour of being thus chosen, he intended to defend the rights of his client vigorously. He opened the newly created file and, straight away, showed the major's letter. It certainly proved the transfer of the ticket, but did not mention the name of the receiver. It simply said, "My Dear Friend..."

"'My Dear Friend' – that's me," added Arsène Lupin in a note attached to the major's letter. "And the best proof is that I possess the letter."

The horde of reporters swooped down immediately on M. Gerbois, who could only repeat:

"'My Dear Friend' is no one else but me. Arsène Lupin stole the major's letter together with the lottery ticket."

"Let him prove it!" retorted Lupin to the journalists.

"But it was he who stole the writing desk!" exclaimed M. Gerbois in front of the same journalists.

And Lupin retorted:

"Let him prove it!"

And this public duel between the two owners of number 514 – series 23 was a delightfully fantastic sight, as were the comings and goings of the reporters and the calmness of Arsène Lupin in the face of M. Gerbois's panic.

The poor man! The press was full of his lamentations! He revealed his misfortune with a touching innocence:

"You see, gentlemen, it's Suzanne's dowry that this scoundrel is robbing me of. For myself, personally, I couldn't care less, but for Suzanne! Just think, one million! Ten times a hundred thousand francs! Oh, I knew very well that the writing desk contained treasure."

It was in vain that people objected that, when his opponent took away the piece of furniture, he was unaware of the presence of the lottery ticket and could not in any case have foreseen that the ticket would win the big

prize. He moaned:

“Come now, he knew!... Otherwise why would he have bothered to take that wretched-looking piece of furniture?”

“For unknown reasons, but certainly not to acquire a scrap of paper which after all was only worth the modest sum of twenty francs.”

“The sum of one million! He knew... he knows everything! Oh, you don’t know him, that crook!... He hasn’t cheated you out of a million!”

This dialogue could have gone on for a long time, but on the twelfth day M. Gerbois received a communication from Arsène Dubois with a note marking it “confidential” attached. He read it with growing anxiety:

Sir, the gallery are enjoying themselves at our expense. Don’t you think the moment has come to be serious? I, for my part, am determined to be so.

The situation is quite clear: I possess a ticket which I do not have the right to cash, and you have the right to cash a ticket that you do not possess. So neither of us can do anything without the other.

Now, neither you would agree to yield up YOUR right, nor would I agree to give up MY ticket.

So, what shall we do?

I can see only one means. Let’s divide it. Half a million for you and half a million for me. Isn’t that fair? And doesn’t this judgement of Solomon satisfy the need for justice that we both share?

It’s a just solution, but it’s also an immediate one. It is not an offer that you have the leisure to discuss, but a necessity to which circumstances force you to submit. I give you three days to think it over. On Friday morning I’d like to be able to read, in the small ads of L’Écho de France, a discreet message addressed to M. Ars. Lupin, and containing in veiled terms your support, pure and simple, for the pact that I am proposing to you. In return for this, you will regain immediate possession of the ticket and can cash it for the million francs – though it will mean handing over five hundred thousand francs through the channel which I shall indicate subsequently.

Should you refuse, I shall take steps to ensure that the outcome will be the same. But, in addition to the very serious problems that such obstinacy will cause you, you would be subjected to a deduction of

twenty-five thousand francs for additional expenses.

Yours very sincerely,

Arsène Lupin

Exasperated, M. Gerbois committed the great mistake of showing this letter to others and of allowing a copy to be made. His indignation drove him to do all kinds of foolish things.

“Nothing! He’ll get nothing!” he cried in front of the gathering of reporters. “Share what belongs to me? Never! Let him tear the ticket up if he wants!”

“But five hundred thousand francs are better than nothing.”

“That’s not the point. It’s a question of my right, and I’ll have this right upheld in court.”

“You mean: bring a lawsuit against Arsène Lupin? That would be amusing.”

“No, but against the Crédit Foncier. They should hand over one million francs to me.”

“On submission of the ticket, or at least with proof that you bought it.”

“There is proof, since Arsène Lupin admits that he stole the writing desk.”

“Will the word of Arsène Lupin be sufficient for the courts?”

“It does not matter. I’ll sue him.”

The gallery was jumping with joy. Bets were laid, some claiming that Lupin would crush M. Gerbois, and others that he would be crushed for the threats he had made. And people felt a sort of apprehension, as the strengths of the two adversaries were so uneven, one of them so formidable in his mode of attack and the other in such a state of alarm, like an animal that is being tracked down.

On Friday they fought over copies of *L’Écho de France*, and they feverishly scanned the classifieds section on the fifth page. Not a line was addressed to *M. Ars. Lupin*. To Arsène Lupin’s injunctions M. Gerbois was replying with silence. It was a declaration of war.

That evening the world learnt via the newspapers of the abduction of Mlle Gerbois.

What we find most amusing in what one could call the entertainments provided by Arsène Lupin is the eminently comic role played by the police.

Everything takes place without their involvement. It is he who speaks, writes, makes predictions, gives orders, makes threats, as if no one existed, neither a chief of the Sûreté, nor officers, nor superintendents – nobody, in fact, who could hinder him in his intentions. All that is considered null and void. Obstacles do not matter.

Yet the police thrash about. As soon as it is something involving Arsène Lupin, everyone, from top to bottom of the scale, becomes incensed, and boiling and fuming with rage. He is the enemy, and one who taunts you, provokes you, despises you and, even worse, ignores you.

And what can be done against such an enemy? At twenty to ten, according to the evidence of the maid, Suzanne left home. At five past ten, as he was coming out of the secondary school, he noticed that she was not on the pavement, where she used to wait for him. But it all happened in the course of the short five-minute walk which took Suzanne from her home to the secondary school, or at least to the area around the school.

Two neighbours confirmed that they had passed her coming the other way at about three hundred paces from the house. A lady had seen a young woman walking along the avenue, and her description matched that of the missing woman. And after that? What happened after that nobody knew.

They searched everywhere. The employees at the stations and the customs offices were questioned. They had noticed nothing on that day which could be related to the abduction of a young woman. However, at Ville-d'Avray a grocer reported that he had supplied oil to a closed vehicle which came from Paris. In the driving seat was a driver and inside was a blonde woman – an extremely blonde woman, as the witness made clear. One hour later the vehicle returned from Versailles. Road congestion obliged him to slow down, which allowed the grocer to notice the presence, beside the blonde woman he had already glimpsed, of another woman, wrapped up in shawls and veils. This was no doubt Suzanne Gerbois.

So they had to assume that the abduction had taken place in full daylight, on a frequently used road and in the very centre of the town!

But how could this have happened? And where? No cry had been heard, and no suspicious movement had been noticed.

The grocer provided a description of the car, which was a twenty-four

horsepower limousine made by the Peugeot company, with dark-blue bodywork. On the off chance, enquiries were made of the woman in charge of the Grand-Garage, a Mme Bob-Walthour, who had made abductions by car her speciality. And indeed, on the Friday morning, she had rented out for the day a Peugeot limousine to a blonde woman, whom she had also not seen again.

“And what about the driver?”

“It was a man called Ernest, who had been employed the day before on the basis of excellent references.”

“Is he here now?”

“No, he brought back the car and didn’t come back again.”

“Can’t we track him down?”

“Certainly, through the persons he gave as referees. Here are their names.”

“They went to see these persons. Not one of them knew the name Ernest.”

And so, whatever track they pursued to throw light on the situation, they end up more in the dark, more mystified, than before.

M. Gerbois did not have the strength to keep up a fight which began for him in such a disastrous way. Inconsolable since the disappearance of his daughter, and racked by remorse, he gave up.

A small announcement which appeared in *L’Écho de France*, and which everyone commented on, confirmed the fact that he was giving up outright and without reservation.

It meant victory. The battle was over within four days.

Two days later, M. Gerbois crossed the courtyard of the Crédit Foncier building. On being introduced into the presence of the director, he held out ticket number 514 – series 23. The director started.

“Oh, you’ve got it? He gave it back to you?”

“It was mislaid. Here it is,” replied M. Gerbois.

“But you claimed... There was the matter of—”

“All that’s idle gossip and lies.”

“But we still need some sort of document to support it.”

“Will the major’s letter be sufficient?”

“Certainly.”

“Here it is.”

“Perfect. Please deposit the documents here with us. We need a fortnight to verify them. I shall inform you as soon as you can present yourself at our cashier’s desk. Until then, sir, I believe that it is in your best interest to say nothing and to bring this matter to a close in complete silence.”

“That is my intention.”

M. Gerbois did not say anything else, and neither did the director. But there are secrets which are revealed without any indiscretion being committed whatsoever, and it suddenly became known that Arsène Lupin had had the audacity to return ticket number 514 – series 23 to M. Gerbois! The news was received with admiration mixed with astonishment. Only a truly good gambler could throw onto the table such an important trump card as that precious ticket! Surely it had only been relinquished deliberately and as a card which would restore the balance. But what if the young woman escaped? What if they managed to get back the hostage he was holding?

The police were aware of their enemy’s weak spot and redoubled its efforts. With Arsène Lupin disarmed, himself the cause of his being robbed, and caught in the convolutions of his own schemes and not able to touch a single sou of his coveted million, it was as a result of this, the other side who were laughing.

However, they had to find Suzanne. But she could not be found and, what was more, she had not escaped.

Very well, it was agreed, the point had been established: Arsène Lupin had won the first round. But the most difficult thing was still to be achieved! He has Mlle Gerbois in his hands, it’s true, and he will only return her for five hundred thousand francs. But where and how will the exchange take place? In order for the exchange to take place, a meeting place must be arranged, and so what is preventing M. Gerbois from informing the police and in this way getting his daughter back while keeping his money?

The teacher was interviewed. Demoralized and anxious to be left in peace, he remained inscrutable.

“I have nothing to say. I’m just waiting.”

“What about Mlle Gerbois?”

“The search continues.”

“But didn’t Arsène Lupin write to you?”

“No.”

“Can you confirm that?”

“No.”

“That means yes. What instructions has he given you?”

“I have nothing to say.”

Maître Detinan was besieged. They met with the same discretion.

“M. Lupin is my client,” he replied with an affected solemnity, “so you will understand that I am held to the utmost secrecy.”

All these mysteries annoyed the gallery. Obviously shadowy plans were being hatched in the shadows. Arsène Lupin was arranging and drawing together the meshes of his nets, while the police were organizing round-the-clock surveillance around M. Gerbois. And the three possible outcomes were being considered: arrest, triumph or pathetic and pitiful abortion of the plan.

But it turned out that public curiosity was only partially satisfied, and it is here in these pages, that, for the first time, the precise truth will be revealed.

On Tuesday 12th March, M. Gerbois received, in an ordinary-looking envelope, some information from the Crédit Foncier.

On Thursday, at one o’clock, he took the train to Paris. At two o’clock the one thousand thousand-franc notes were handed over to him.

While he was leafing through them one by one, trembling as he did so – wasn’t this money the ransom for Suzanne? – two men were talking together in a car which had stopped at some distance from the doorway. One of the men had greying hair and a resolute expression which contrasted with his clothes and his appearance of being some lowly employee. It was Chief Inspector Ganimard, old Ganimard, the implacable enemy of Lupin. And Ganimard was saying to Sergeant Folenfant:

“It won’t take long... in less than five minutes we’ll be seeing our man again. Is everything ready?”

“Completely.”

“How many of us are there?”

“Eight, two of them with bikes.”

“And me who’s worth three men. It’s enough but not one too many.

Under no circumstances must Gerbois be allowed to escape... Otherwise it's goodnight! And he'll rejoin Lupin at the rendezvous that they must have arranged. He'll swap the young woman for half a million, and that'll be it."

"But why doesn't the good fellow work with us? It would be so easy. If he let us get involved, he would be able to keep the entire million francs."

"Yes, but he's afraid. If he tries to drop the other chap in it he won't get his daughter back."

"What other chap?"

"*Him.*"

Ganimard uttered the word in a serious and somewhat timid tone, as if he were talking about a supernatural being which he could feel already had him in his clutches.

"It's rather amusing," commented Sergeant Folenfant astutely, "that we are reduced to protecting this gentleman from himself."

"With Lupin, everything's topsy-turvy," sighed Ganimard.

A minute went by.

"Look out!" he cried.

M. Gerbois was coming out. At the end of the Rue des Capucines he turned towards the boulevards, keeping to the left-hand side. He moved slowly along the shops and looked at the window displays.

"He's too calm, our man," said Ganimard. "A person who's got a million in his pocket isn't so calm."

"What can he do?"

"Oh, obviously nothing... It doesn't matter. I don't trust him. Lupin is Lupin."

At that moment M. Gerbois went towards a kiosk, selected some newspapers, took his change, opened out one of the pages and, with his arms stretched out, taking a few steps forward, he started to read. And suddenly, with one bound he leapt into a car which was parked by the kerb. The engine must have been running because it set off quickly, passed the Madeleine church and disappeared.

"Good God!" exclaimed Ganimard. "Another one of his tricks, and typical of *him.*"

He dashed off, and other men ran off at the same time round the Madeleine.

But then he burst out laughing. At the entrance to the Boulevard Malesherbes the car had broken down and stopped, and M. Gerbois was getting out of it.

“Quick, Folenfant... the driver... perhaps he’s the man called Ernest.”

Folenfant dealt with the driver. He was a man called Gaston, employed by the Taxicab Company. Ten minutes earlier, a gentleman had stopped him and told him to wait at the ready near the kiosk, until another man arrived.

“And what address did he give?” asked Folenfant.

“No address... he just said, ‘Boulevard Malesherbes... Avenue de Messine... double tip...’ That’s all.”

But during that time, without wasting a moment, M. Gerbois had jumped into the first car that went by.

“Cabbie! To the Concorde metro.”

The teacher got off the metro at Place du Palais-Royal, ran towards another car and asked to be taken to Place de la Bourse. There was a second metro journey, and then he went to Avenue de Villiers and took a third car.

“Cabbie! 25 Rue Clapeyron.”

Number 25 on Rue Clapeyron is separated from Boulevard des Batignolles by a house on the corner. He went up to the first floor and rang the bell. A man opened the door.

“I believe this is where Maître Detinan lives?”

“I am that very man, M. Gerbois.”

“Perfect!”

“I was expecting you, sir. Please be so kind as to come in.”

When M. Gerbois went into the lawyer’s office, the clock struck three, and he at once said:

“This is the time he specified for me. Isn’t he here yet?”

“Not yet.”

M. Gerbois sat down and mopped his brow. He looked at his watch as if he did not know what time it was, and continued anxiously:

“Is he coming?”

The lawyer replied:

“You question me, sir, about the one thing in the world that I am most

curious to know. I have never felt such impatience. In any case, if he comes, he will be taking a great risk, as this house has been under close surveillance for a fortnight... They don't trust me."

"They trust me even less. And I cannot guarantee that the officers tailing me have lost track of me."

"Oh well—"

"That's through no fault of mine," the teacher exclaimed sharply, "and I can't be reproached for anything. What did I promise to do? Obey *his* orders. Well, I obeyed *his* orders blindly. I picked up the money at the time specified by him, and I have come to you in the way he stipulated. Being responsible for my daughter's misfortune, I was completely loyal in keeping to my commitments. It's up to him to keep to his."

And he added in the same anxious voice:

"He will give me back my daughter, won't he?"

"I hope so."

"But... have you seen him?"

"No, I haven't! He simply asked me by letter to allow you both to meet here... to dismiss my servants before three o'clock and not to allow anyone into my apartment between your arrival and his departure. If I did not agree to this proposal, he requested me to warn him by putting two lines in *L'Écho de France*. But I was only too happy to be of service to Arsène Lupin and agreed to everything."

M. Gerbois moaned:

"Oh dear! How's it all going to end?"

He drew the banknotes out of his pocket and spread them on the table. He divided them into two equal bundles. And then neither of them spoke. From time to time M. Gerbois listened out... Hadn't someone rung?

His anxiety grew as the minutes passed, and Maître Detinan was also almost in a state of distress.

At one moment the lawyer lost his composure completely and stood up abruptly:

"We won't be seeing him... What do you expect?... It would be madness on his part! It may well be that he trusts us. We are honest men and incapable of betraying him. But it's not only here that there's danger."

And M. Gerbois, overwhelmed, with both hands on the banknotes, mumbled:

“Oh, my God, please let him come, please let him come! I would give up all this to get Suzanne back.”

The door opened.

“Half would be enough, Monsieur Gerbois.”

There was someone standing in the doorway, a young man, elegantly dressed, whom M. Gerbois recognized immediately as the individual who had approached him near the curiosity shop in Versailles. He leapt towards him.

“What about Suzanne? Where’s my daughter?”

Arsène Lupin closed the door carefully and, undoing his gloves with the calmest movement possible, he said to the lawyer:

“My dear Maître, I cannot thank you enough for the good grace with which you agreed to defend my rights. I shall never forget it.”

Maître Detinan murmured:

“But you didn’t ring... I didn’t hear the door...”

“Bells and doors are things which should function without ever being heard. Here I am anyway, that’s the main thing.”

“My daughter! Suzanne! What have you done with her?” the teacher repeated.

“My God, sir! What a hurry you are in! Now, be assured, in just a moment the young lady, your daughter, will be in your arms.”

He walked up and down, and then, like a great lord passing out praise, he said:

“M. Gerbois, I congratulate you on the skill with which you acted a little while ago. If the car had not had that absurd breakdown, we would simply have met at L’Étoile, and we would have spared Maître the inconvenience of this visit... Oh well, it was meant to be.”

He caught sight of the two bundles of banknotes and exclaimed: “Ah! Perfect! Here’s the million francs... We must not waste time. Will you allow me?”

“But,” Maître Detinan objected, placing himself in front of the table, “Mlle Gerbois has not arrived yet.”

“So?”

“So, isn’t her presence essential?”

“Oh, I understand! I understand. Arsène Lupin only inspires people to have relative trust in him. He’ll pocket the half a million and won’t give

back the hostage. Oh my dear Maître, I am greatly misunderstood. Because fate has led me to perform acts the nature of which is a little... special, my sincerity is doubted... me! A man of scruples and sensitivity! Besides, my dear Maître, if you are afraid, just open your window and call out. There must be a dozen officers in the street.”

“Do you think so?”

Arsène Lupin lifted up the curtain.

“I think that M. Gerbois is incapable of throwing Ganimard off the scent... What did I tell you? There he is, my good friend!”

“Is it possible?” exclaimed the teacher. “But I swear to you—”

“That you have not betrayed me?... And I don’t doubt it, but those fellows are clever. There you are! I can see Folenfant!...And Gréaume!... And Dieuzy! Hey, I can see all my old friends there!”

Maître Detinan looked at him in surprise. What calmness! He was laughing with real delight, as if he was amusing himself with some children’s game and no danger was threatening him.

This carefree manner reassured the lawyer more than the sight of the officers. He moved away from the table on which the banknotes were lying.

Arsène Lupin seized one wad and then the other, reduced the amount in each of them by twenty-five notes, and handed the fifty notes thus obtained to Maître Detinan:

“One part of your fees, my dear Maître, from M. Gerbois, and the other from Arsène Lupin. We owe that to you.”

“You owe me nothing,” replied Maître Detinan.

“What? And with all the trouble we are causing you?”

“And all the pleasure that I take in putting up with this trouble!”

“So that means, my dear Maître, that you do not want to accept anything from Arsène Lupin. That’s what comes,” he sighed, “of having a bad reputation.”

He held out the fifty thousand francs to the teacher.

“Sir, in memory of our pleasant meeting, please permit me to return this to you: it’s my wedding present for Mlle Gerbois.”

M. Gerbois took the notes briskly, but protested:

“My daughter’s not getting married.”

“She won’t marry if you refuse your consent. But she’s longing to get married.”

“What do you know about it?”

“I know that young girls often have dreams without Daddy’s permission. Luckily there exist good geniuses like those called Arsène Lupin, who discover in the bottom of writing desks the secret of their charming souls.”

“You didn’t find anything else there?” asked Maître Detinan. “I admit that I would be very keen to know why this item of furniture was the object of your concern.”

“For historical reasons, my dear Maître. Although, contrary to the opinion of M. Gerbois, it contained no other treasure than the lottery ticket – and that I knew nothing about – I was fond of it and I had been looking for it for a long time. That writing desk, made of yew and mahogany, and decorated with capitals with acanthus leaves, was found in the discreet little house in Boulogne where Marie Walewska* lived, and on one of the drawers it bears the inscription: *Dedicated to Napoleon 1st, Emperor of the French, by his very faithful servant, Mancion*. And, above is engraved, with the point of a knife: “To you, Marie.” Later Napoleon had it copied for the Empress Joséphine – so that the writing desk that was admired at Malmaison* was only an imperfect copy of the one which from now on forms part of my collection.”

The teacher moaned:

“Oh dear! If I had known when I was at the shop, I would have let you have it without delay!”

And laughing, Arsène Lupin said:

“And what is more, you would have had the considerable advantage of keeping entirely to yourself ticket number 514 – series 23.”

“And you would not have been led to abduct my daughter, which all of this must have really upset.”

“All of this?”

“The abduction.”

“But my dear sir, you are wrong. Mlle Gerbois hasn’t been abducted.”

“My daughter not abducted!”

“Not at all. When you talk of abduction that means using violence. Well, she served as hostage of her own free will.”

“Of her own free will?” repeated M. Gerbois, confused.

“And almost at her own request! What! A young intelligent girl like Mlle

Gerbois – who, what is more, cultivates deep in her heart an undeclared love – should refuse to acquire her dowry! Oh, I can swear to you that it was easy to make her understand that there was no other way to overcome your obstinacy.”

Maître was enjoying himself enormously. He objected:

“The most difficult thing is to get you and her to agree. It’s impossible that Mlle Gerbois could be approached in this way.”

“Oh, not by me! I don’t even have the honour of knowing her. It is one of my acquaintances who was willing to initiate negotiations.”

“The blonde woman in the car, no doubt,” interrupted Maître Detinan.

“Exactly. From the first meeting near the secondary school, everything was settled. Since then Mlle Gerbois and her new woman friend have gone on a trip, visiting Belgium and Holland, which has been arranged in the most pleasant and instructive way for a young girl. Anyway, she’ll explain it all to you—”

There was a ring at the hall door, three rapid rings, then a single one, and another single one.

“That’s her,” said Lupin. “My dear Maître, if you wouldn’t mind...”

The lawyer hurried off.

Two young women entered. One threw herself into the arms of M. Gerbois. The other approached Lupin. She had a high waist, with a graceful bust and a very pale face, and her hair, which was brilliant blond, was divided into two wavy and loose tresses. Although dressed in black, with no other ornament than a five-banded jet necklace, her appearance was sophisticatedly elegant.

Arsène Lupin said a few words to her, and then, greeting Mlle Gerbois, he said:

“I beg your pardon, Mademoiselle, for all these tribulations, but I hope nevertheless that you have not been too unhappy...”

“Unhappy! I would even have been very happy, if it had not been for my poor father.”

“So, all has worked out for the best. Embrace him once more, and take the advantage of the opportunity – it is an excellent one – to tell him about your cousin.”

“My cousin... What do you mean?... I don’t understand...”

“Yes you do, you understand... your cousin Philippe... that young man

whose letters you keep carefully.”

Suzanne blushed, lost her composure and, finally, as Lupin advised her, she threw herself into her father’s arms again.

Lupin looked at the two of them tenderly.

“How rewarding it is to do good! What a moving spectacle! A happy father and a happy daughter! Oh Lupin, to be able to say that this happiness is your work! These creatures will bless you later... Your name will be passed on to their grandchildren with a sense of devotion... Oh, what a marvellous thing a family is, a family!...”

He moved towards the window.

“Is good old Ganimard still there?... He would so much like to be present at these charming expressions of feeling!... But no, he’s not there any more... and nobody else... neither he nor the others... Damn! The situation is becoming serious. Nothing would surprise me more than to know that they were already at the coachman’s entrance... perhaps even at the concierge’s... or even on the staircase!”

M. Gerbois made an involuntary movement. Now that his daughter had been returned to him, his sense of reality returned to him. Getting his opponent arrested would mean half a million francs for him. He stepped forward instinctively. As though by chance, Lupin stood in his way.

“Where are you going, M. Gerbois? To defend me against them? Extremely kind of you! Please do not put yourself out. Besides, I can tell you that they’ll be more embarrassed than me.”

And he continued thoughtfully:

“Basically, what do they know? That you are here, and perhaps that Mlle Gerbois is also here, because they must have seen her arrive with an unknown woman. But me? They don’t suspect it at all. How could I have got into a house that they have searched this morning from cellar to attic? No, in all probability, they are waiting for me to catch me in the act, the poor dears! Unless they guess that the unknown woman was sent by me and they consider her to have been given the responsibility to conduct the exchange... In which case they are getting ready to arrest her when she leaves...”

A bell rang.

With a sudden movement, Lupin stopped M. Gerbois and, imperiously, in a curt tone, said:

“Stop a moment, sir. Think of your daughter and be reasonable, otherwise... As for you, Maître Detinan, I have your word.”

M. Gerbois was glued to the spot. And the lawyer did not move.

Without hurrying in the least, Lupin picked up his hat. There was a dusty smudge on it, and he brushed it off with the back of his sleeve.

“My dear Maître, if you ever have need of me... My best wishes, Mlle Suzanne, and my kindest regards to M. Philippe.”

He drew from his pocket a heavy watch with a double gold casing.

“Monsieur Gerbois, it’s 3.42. At 3.46, I allow you to leave this room... Not one minute earlier than 3.46, all right?”

“But they’ll force their way in,” the Maître could not help saying.

“Have you forgotten the law, my dear Maître?”

“Ganimard would never dare invade the privacy of the home of a French citizen. We would have time to play an excellent round of bridge. But forgive me, you seem a little nervous, all three of you, and I wouldn’t want to impose on...”

He put his watch on the table, opened the room door, and speaking to the blonde woman, he said:

“Are you ready, my dear?”

He stepped aside for her, made a last very respectful greeting to Mlle Gerbois, went out and closed the door behind him.

He could be heard speaking in the hallway in a loud voice:

“Hello Ganimard, how are you? Please remember me to Mme Ganimard. I must ask her to invite me to lunch one of these days... Goodbye, Ganimard.”

There was another ringing sound, a short aggressive one, and then repeated ringings, and the sound of voices on the landing.

“3.45,” mumbled M. Gerbois.

After a few seconds, he went out resolutely into the hallway. Lupin and the blonde woman were no longer there.

“Father!... You mustn’t!... Wait!” exclaimed Suzanne.

“Wait? You’re mad!... Show consideration for that rascal... What about the half a million?”

He opened the door.

Ganimard rushed in.

“That woman... where is she? And Lupin?”

“He was there... He is there.”

Ganimard uttered a cry of triumph:

“We’ve got him... the house is surrounded.”

Maître Detinan objected:

“What about the backstairs?”

“The backstairs end up in a yard, and there is only one way out, through the main entrance: two men are keeping an eye on it.”

“But he did not come in through the main entrance... and he won’t go out that way...”

“Which other way then?... ” retorted Ganimard “Through the air?”

He drew aside a curtain. A long corridor presented itself leading to the kitchen. Ganimard ran along it and confirmed that the door to the backstairs was double-locked.

From the window he called one of his officers:

“Nobody there?”

“Nobody.”

“So,” he exclaimed, “they must be in the apartment!... They’re hiding in one of the rooms!... It’s physically impossible for them to have escaped... Oh, young Lupin, you’ve made fun of me, but this time I’ll get my revenge.”

At seven o’clock in the evening, M. Dudouis, the head of the Sûreté, surprised at having received no news at all, arrived at Rue Clapeyron. He questioned the officers who were guarding the building, and then went up to the apartment of Maître Detinan, who led him into his office. There he caught sight of a man, or rather two legs fidgeting around on the carpet, while the torso to which they were attached was occupied in doing something in the dark recesses of the fireplace.

“Hey!...Hey!...” a muffled voice barked out.

And a voice farther away, which came from high up, replied:

“Hey!...Hey!...”

Laughing, M. Dudouis cried out: “So, Ganimard, what are you up to playing the chimney sweep like that?”

The chief inspector extracted himself from the depths of the fireplace. With his face blackened, his clothes covered in soot and his eyes shining with frenzy, he was unrecognizable.

"I'm looking for *him*," he groaned.

"Who?"

"Arsène Lupin... Arsène Lupin and his lady friend."

"Oh them! But do you imagine that they would be hiding in the flues of a fireplace?"

Ganimard got up, and placed five coal-black fingers on the sleeve of his boss. In a muffled voice he said furiously:

"So where do you expect them to be? They must be somewhere. They are creatures like you and me, made of flesh and blood. Such creatures don't just disappear in a puff of smoke."

"No, but they've disappeared all the same."

"But where? Where? The house is surrounded! And there are officers on the roof."

"What about the house next door?"

"There is no connection with it."

"And the apartments on the other floors?"

"I've met all the tenants: they've seen nobody... they've heard nobody."

"Are you sure you've seen all of them?"

"All of them. The concierge vouches for them. Besides, as an extra precaution, I've posted a man in each of the apartments."

"But we must get our hands on them."

"That's what I say, boss, that's what I say. We must, and we will, because both of them are here... There's no way they can't be here. Rest assured, boss, if not tonight then I'll have them tomorrow... I'll spend the night here!... I'll spend the night here!..."

And indeed he did spend the night there, and the next day, and the day after that as well. And, after three days and three nights had gone by, not only had he not discovered the elusive Lupin and his no less elusive companion, but he had not even picked up the faintest clue which would allow him to establish the slightest hypothesis.

And that is why the opinion he had at the very beginning never changed:

"Given that there's no sign of their having escaped, then they are still here!"

Perhaps in the depths of his mind he was less convinced. But he did not want to admit it. No, a thousand times no, a man and a woman don't just disappear like evil spirits in children's stories. And without losing heart he

continued his searches and investigations as if he hoped to find them, concealed in some undiscovered hiding place, built into the very stones of the house.

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Notes

[p. 18](#), Herlock Sholmes: For legal reasons, Leblanc had to change the names of Sherlock Holmes, Watson and Baker Street. This edition preserves the altered names.

[p. 31](#), Marie Walewska: Marie Walewska (1786–1817) was a Polish countess and the mistress of the French Emperor Napoleon.

[p. 31](#), *the writing desk that was admired at Malmaison*: This writing desk is currently in the Furniture Storage Warehouse. (AUTHOR'S NOTE)

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2

The Blue Diamond

ON THE EVENING OF 27TH MARCH, in the little house at 134 Avenue Henri-Martin, which his brother had left to him six months previously, the old general Baron d'Hautrec, ambassador to Berlin in the Second Empire, was sleeping in the depths of a comfortable armchair, while his female companion was reading to him, and Sister Auguste was warming his bed and preparing the night light.

At eleven o'clock the nun, who exceptionally that night had to go back to her community's convent and spend the night with the mother superior, informed the female companion:

"Mademoiselle Antoinette, my work is finished and I'm going."

"Very well, Sister."

"And above all don't forget that the cook is on leave and that you are alone in the house with the servant."

"Don't worry about the Baron. I shall be sleeping in the next room as agreed, and I'll leave my door open."

The nun went off. A moment later the servant, Charles, came to receive his instructions. The Baron had woken up and answered him in person.

"The same instructions as always, Charles: check if the electric bell is working in your room, and the first time it rings go down and run for the doctor."

"The general is always worrying."

"I'm not well... not at all well. Well now, Mademoiselle, where were we up to in our reading?"

"Wouldn't Monsieur le Baron rather lie down on his bed?"

"No, no, not at all. I shall go to bed very late, and besides I don't need anyone."

Twenty minutes later the old man dozed off again, and Antoinette crept off on tiptoe.

At that moment Charles was meticulously closing as usual all the shutters on the ground floor.

In the kitchen he closed the bolt on the door that opened onto the

garden, and in the hallway he also hooked the security chain from one wing of the door to the other. Then he went back to his attic room on the third floor, went to bed and fell asleep.

Perhaps about one hour had passed when suddenly he leapt from his bed in one bound: the bell was ringing. It rang for a long time, perhaps seven or eight seconds, in a calm, uninterrupted way...

"Fine," he murmured, pulling himself together, "a new whim of the Baron's."

He slipped on his clothes, went quickly down the stairs, stopped in front of the door and knocked, as he usually did. There was no reply. He went in.

"Well," he murmured, "so there's no light... why the devil did they put them out?"

And in a low voice, he called out:

"Mademoiselle?"

There was no reply.

"Are you there, Mademoiselle?... What's wrong? Is Monsieur le Baron ill?"

The same silence continued around him, which finally began to disturb him. He went two paces forward: his foot hit against a chair and, when he touched it, he realized that it had been knocked over. And suddenly his hand came across other objects on the floor, a pedestal table and a screen. Feeling anxious he went back towards the wall and, feeling his way, tried to find the electric switch. He reached it and turned it on.

In the middle of the room, between the table and the wardrobe with the mirror, lay the body of his master, Baron d'Hautrec.

"What!... is it possible?" he stammered.

He did not know what to do, and without moving, his eyes wide open, he looked at the way the things had been turned upside down, the fallen chairs, a large crystal candle-holder broken into a thousand pieces, the clock which was lying on the marble surface of the hearth, all of them signs revealing that some dreadful, fierce struggle had taken place. There was the gleaming handle of a steel stiletto not far from the corpse. The blade was dripping with blood. Across the mattress a handkerchief was hanging, stained with red marks.

Charles yelled in terror: the body had suddenly stretched itself out with

one final effort and had then curled up on itself... Two or three jerks and then it was over.

He leant over. Through a thin wound in the neck, blood was spurting out and causing the carpet to become speckled with black stains. An expression of wild terror remained on his face.

“He’s been killed,” he mumbled, “he’s been killed.”

He shuddered at the idea of another likely crime: was not the female companion sleeping in the next room? And would not the Baron’s murderer have killed her too?

He pushed open the door: the room was empty. He concluded that Antoinette had been abducted, or even that she had left before the crime.

He went back into the Baron’s room and, catching sight of the writing desk, he noticed that this piece of furniture had not been broken open.

What is more, he saw on the table, near the bunch of keys and wallet that the Baron placed there every evening, a handful of louis d’or. Charles seized the wallet and opened out its pockets. One of them contained some banknotes. He counted them: there were thirty hundred-franc notes.

Well, it was too much for him: instinctively, mechanically, without even his mind having any control over his hand, he took the thirty notes, concealed them in his jacket, raced down the staircase, pulled back the bolt, unhooked the chain, closed the door again and ran off through the garden.

Charles was an honest man. He had scarcely pushed back the gate, when, feeling the open air against his body, and his face refreshed by rain, he stopped. The act that had been committed now appeared to him in its true light, and he suddenly felt the horror of it.

A cab passed by. He hailed the driver.

“My friend, dash off to the police station and bring the superintendent... At the gallop! A man is dead.”

The driver whipped his horse. But when Charles wanted to go back inside, he could not. He had shut the gate himself, and the gate could not be opened from outside.

Besides, it was useless to ring, as no one was in the house.

So he walked along through the gardens, which form a pleasant border of well-trimmed green shrubs on the side of the avenue by the Château de la

Muette. And it was only after waiting for an hour that he was able finally to tell the superintendent the details of the crime and to hand over to him the thirty banknotes.

During this time the services of a locksmith were obtained, who with great difficulty managed to force open the garden gate and the door to the hallway.

The superintendent went upstairs, and immediately, taking a first look round, he said to the servant:

“Well now, you told me that that the room was in a complete mess.”

He turned round. Charles seemed to be stuck in the doorway, hypnotized: all the pieces of furniture were back in their usual places! The pedestal table was standing between the two windows, the chairs were upright and the clock was in the middle of the mantelpiece. The remains of the candle-holder had disappeared.

Gaping with astonishment he said:

“The corpse... the Baron...”

“Indeed,” exclaimed the superintendent, “where is the victim?”

He went towards the bed. Under a large sheet, which he drew back, lay General Baron d’Hautrec, former French ambassador in Berlin. His general’s greatcoat, decorated with his Croix d’Honneur, was covering him.

His face was calm. His eyes were closed.

The servant mumbled:

“Someone must have got in.”

“Which way?”

“I don’t know, but someone has got in while I was away... Look, there on the floor, there was a very thin dagger, made of steel... And then, on the table, there was a handkerchief with blood... It’s not there any more... They’ve taken it all away... They’ve tidied it all up...”

“But who?”

“The murderer!”

“We found all the doors closed.”

“So he stayed inside the house.”

“He must still be here, as you didn’t leave the pavement.”

The servant thought things over, and said slowly:

“Indeed... indeed... and I didn’t move away from the gate... yet...”

“Well now, who was the last person that you saw with the Baron?”

“Mademoiselle Antoinette, his female companion.”

“What’s happened to her?”

“In my opinion, as her bed has not even been slept in, she must have taken advantage of the absence of Sister Auguste to go out as well. That doesn’t surprise me much, as she’s pretty... and young...”

“But how would she have got out?”

“Through the door.”

“But you closed the bolt and put the chain on!”

“Very much later! She must have left the house at that moment.”

“And the crime would have taken place after she had left?”

“Of course.”

They searched the house from top to bottom, in the attics as well as in the cellars, but the murderer had fled. How? At what moment? Was it he or an accomplice who had judged that it was the right moment to return to the scene of the crime and to make everything that could have compromised him disappear? These were the questions which the law was faced with.

At seven o’clock the forensic scientist appeared, and at eight o’clock the head of the Sûreté. Then it was the turn of the public prosecutor and the examining magistrate. And also cluttering up the hotel were officers, inspectors, journalists, Baron d’Hautrec’s nephew and other members of the family.

They rummaged around, they studied the position of the corpse as Charles remembered it and they questioned Sister Auguste as soon as she arrived. Nothing at all was discovered. Most of all, Sister Auguste was surprised at the disappearance of Antoinette Bréhat. She had hired the young woman twelve days before, on the evidence of excellent references, and refused to believe that she could have abandoned the sick man who had been entrusted to her to run off alone during the night.

“All the more unlikely in this case,” the examining magistrate emphasized, “as she would have already returned. We come back to the same point: what has happened to her?”

“In my opinion,” said Charles, “she was abducted by the murderer.”

The theory was plausible and agreed with the way things seemed. The head of the Sûreté said:

“Abducted? Well, yes, that’s not at all unlikely.”

“Not only is it unlikely,” said a voice, “but it completely contradicts the facts, the results of the inquiries and, in short, the actual evidence.”

The voice was harsh, with a sharp accent, and no one was surprised to recognize it as that of Ganimard. Besides, only he could be forgiven this rather cavalier way of expressing himself.

“Oh, so it’s you, Ganimard?” exclaimed M. Dudouis, “I didn’t see you there.”

“I’ve been here for two hours.”

“So, you are interested in something else besides ticket number 514 – series 23, that business at Rue Clapeyron, the Blonde Woman and Arsène Lupin?”

“Ah well,” the old inspector sniggered, “I couldn’t confirm that Lupin has nothing to do with the present case we’re dealing with... But let’s leave aside, until further notice, that business with the lottery ticket, and see what this is all about.”

Ganimard is not one of those detectives of great stature, whose activities gain a following and whose name will go down in judicial annals. He lacks those brainwaves which inspire the likes of Dupin, Lecoq¹ and Sherlock Holmes. But he has excellent average qualities, in his observation abilities, his shrewdness, his perseverance and even in his intuition. His merit is his ability to work completely independently. Nothing, except perhaps for the kind of fascination that Arsène Lupin exerts over him, bothers or influences him. Be that as it may, his role, that morning, did not lack brilliance, and his collaboration was such that a judge could appreciate.

“First of all,” he began, “I wish to ask M. Charles to clarify this point: were all the objects which, on the first occasion, he had seen knocked over or disturbed, exactly in their usual place the second time you came?”

“Exactly.”

“It is therefore clear that they could have only been put back in their places by someone who was familiar with the positions of these objects.”

The remark amazed those present. Ganimard continued:

“Another question, M. Charles... You were woken by the sound of a bell... In your opinion, who was calling you?”

“Monsieur le Baron, for God’s sake!”

“Very well, but at what moment would he have rung?”

“After the struggle... as he was dying.”

“That’s impossible, since you found him lying down, lifeless, in a place more than four metres from the bellpush.”

“So he rang during the struggle.”

“That’s impossible, because you said the ringing was regular, uninterrupted, and lasted seven or eight seconds. Do you think that his attacker would have given him the time to ring in that way?”

“Then it must have been before, as he was about to be attacked.”

“That’s impossible, because you said that at the most three minutes passed between the bell signal and the moment when you went into the room. So that if the baron had rung before, then the struggle, the murder, his suffering and the escape all took place within this short space of three minutes. I repeat: it’s impossible.”

“And yet,” said the examining magistrate, “somebody rang. If it wasn’t the Baron, who was it?”

“The murderer.”

“For what purpose?”

“I don’t know what his purpose was. But at least the fact that he rang proves to us that he must have known that the bell communicated with the servant’s room. So, who could have known this detail, except someone who was part of the household?”

The circle of valid suppositions was being narrowed down. In a few prompt, clear-cut, logical phrases, Ganimard put the question in its true context. And as the ageing inspector’s thought was perfectly clear, it seemed quite natural for the examining magistrate to conclude:

“In short, in two words, you suspect Antoinette Bréhat.”

“I do not suspect her. I accuse her.”

“You accuse her of being the accomplice?”

“I accuse her of having killed General Baron d’Hautrec.”

“Come on! And what proof do you have?...”

“This handful of hair that I discovered in the right hand of the victim, in the very flesh into which the points of his nails had dug it.”

He showed this hair to them. It was brilliant blond, radiant like threads of gold, and Charles murmured:

“That is definitely the hair of Mlle Antoinette. There’s no mistake about

it.”

And he added:

“And then... there’s something else... I definitely think that the knife... the one I didn’t see the second time... belonged to her... She used it to cut the pages of books.”

The silence was long and painful, as if the crime acquired more horror for having been committed by a woman. The examining magistrate considered:

“Let us admit, until further details are available, that the Baron was killed by Antoinette Bréhat. We still have to explain what route she could have taken to get back in after M. Charles’s departure, and to get out again before the arrival of the superintendent. Do you have an opinion about that, Ganimard?”

“None.”

“So?”

Ganimard looked embarrassed. Finally he said, not without visible effort:

“All that I can say is, that I find in this case the same procedure as in the case of the ticket 514 – 23, the same phenomenon which one could call the ability to disappear. Antoinette Bréhat appeared and disappeared in this house, just as mysteriously as Arsène Lupin got into Maître Detinan’s apartment and escaped in the company of the Blonde Woman.”

“Which means?”

“Which means that I cannot help thinking about these two coincidences, which are, at the least, strange: Antoinette Bréhat was employed by Sister Auguste twelve days ago, that is the day before the day that the Blonde Woman slipped through my fingers. Secondly, the Blonde Woman’s hair has exactly the same harsh colour, that metallic sheen with golden highlights, that we find in this here.”

“So that, according to you, Antoinette Bréhat...”

“...is none other than the Blonde Woman.”

“And consequently it was Lupin who engineered both these cases?”

“I think so.”

There was a burst of laughter. It was the head of the Sûreté who was amused.

“Lupin! Always Lupin! Lupin is involved in everything. Lupin is everywhere.”

“He is wherever he may be,” said Ganimard, annoyed.

“He still has to have reasons for being somewhere,” M. Dudouis observed, “and in this case, the reasons seem to me obscure. The writing desk hasn’t been broken into, nor has the wallet been stolen. And even the gold on the table is still there.”

“Yes,” exclaimed Ganimard, “but what about the much talked about diamond?”

“What diamond?”

“The blue diamond! The famous diamond which formed part of the royal crown of France and which was given by the Duc d’A— to Léonide L— and, on the death of Léonide L— was bought back by Baron d’Hautrec in memory of the brilliant actress whom he had loved passionately. It’s one of those memories that an old Parisian like me never forgets.”

“It is clear,” said the examining magistrate, “that if the blue diamond cannot be found, everything is explained... But where should we look?”

“On the Baron’s own finger,” answered Charles. “It never left his left hand.”

“I’ve seen that hand,” asserted Ganimard, going towards the victim, “and, as you can confirm, there is only a simple gold ring.”

“Look inside the palm,” said the servant.

Ganimard unfolded the clenched fingers. The setting was turned inwards, and at the centre of this setting there gleamed the blue diamond.

“What the...” murmured Ganimard, completely dumbfounded. “I can’t understand it any more.”

“And you give up, I hope, your suspicion of the unfortunate Lupin?” sniggered M. Dudouis.

Ganimard took a few moments, thought things over, and then retorted in a sententious tone:

“Actually, it is precisely when I don’t understand any more that I suspect Arsène Lupin.”

These were the first findings conducted by the legal authorities on the day after the strange crime. Vague, incoherent findings, to which subsequent investigations contributed no coherence or certainty. The comings and goings of Antoinette Bréhat remained completely inexplicable, like those of the Blonde Woman, and what was more, they knew nothing about that

mysterious creature with the golden hair who had killed Baron d'Hautrec and had not taken from his finger the fabulous diamond of the royal crown of France.

And most of all, the curiosity that she inspired made it a high-profile crime that excited public opinion.

The Baron d'Hautrec's heirs could only benefit from such publicity. In the actual house, on Avenue Henri-Martin, they organized an exhibition of the pieces of furniture and objects which were to be sold at the Drouot auction rooms. There were modern pieces of furniture in mediocre taste, and objects without artistic value... but in the centre of the room, on a pedestal covered with dark-red velvet, protected by a glass globe and guarded by two officers, there sparkled the ring with the blue diamond.

It was a magnificent and enormous diamond, of incomparable purity, and of that indeterminate blue which clear water acquires from the sky it reflects, of that blue which can be discerned in the whiteness of linen. People admired it and went into raptures over it... and they also looked with dread at the victim's room, that place where the corpse had been lying, the parquet floor from which the blood-covered carpet had been removed, and above all at the walls, the impenetrable walls through which the woman criminal had passed. They made sure that the marble shelf of the fireplace would not topple over, that the moulding of the mirror did not conceal a spring designed to make it revolve. They imagined gaping holes, tunnel openings, connections with the sewers, with the catacombs...

The sale of the blue diamond took place in the Drouot building. It was stifling in the crowd, and the frenzy degenerated into madness.

The whole of the Paris smart set that gathers on such big occasions was there, all those who are buying and all those who want to make you think that they can buy: brokers, artists, women of all levels of society, two ministers, an Italian tenor, a king in exile, who, in order to improve his credit rating, allowed himself the luxury of pushing up the bids, with great confidence and in an impassioned voice, as far as a hundred thousand francs. A hundred thousand francs! He could make such an offer without compromising himself. The Italian tenor risked a hundred and fifty, and an actress of the Théâtre Français bid a hundred and seventy-five.

Nevertheless, at two hundred thousand francs the amateur buyers became discouraged. At two hundred and fifty thousand there were only two left: Herschmann, the famous financier and king of the gold mines, and the Countess of Crozon, the extremely rich American woman whose collection of diamonds and precious stones is well known.

“Two hundred and sixty thousand... two hundred and seventy thousand... seventy-five... eighty...” the auctioneer offered, giving successive questioning looks to the two competitors... “Two hundred and eighty thousand to Madame... Any more bids?...”

“Three hundred thousand,” murmured Herschmann.

There was a silence. Everyone looked at the Countess of Crozon.

Upright and smiling, but of a paleness which indicated that she was disconcerted, she was leaning on the back of the chair placed in front of her. In reality, she knew, and all those present knew as well, that the outcome of the duel was in no doubt: logically, inevitably, it had to finish to the advantage of the financier, whose whims were supported by a fortune of more than half a billion francs. However, she said:

“Three hundred and five thousand.”

There was a another silence. Everyone turned towards the king of the mines, in the expectation of an inevitable higher bid. It was certainly going to happen. It would be strong, brutal and definitive.

It didn't happen. Herschmann remained impassive, with his eyes fixed on a sheet of paper which he had in his right hand, while the other was holding some pieces of a torn envelope.

“Three hundred and five thousand...” repeated the auctioneer. “Once?... Twice?... There's still time... No more bids?... I repeat: Once?... Twice?...”

Herschmann did not turn a hair. There was a final pause. The hammer came down.

“Four hundred thousand,” proclaimed Herschmann, starting as if the noise of the hammer had dragged him from his torpor.

Too late. The outcome of the auction was irrevocable.

People fussed around him. What had happened? Why hadn't he spoken earlier?

He started to laugh.

“What happened? Well, I've no idea. I was distracted for a moment.”

“Is it possible?”

“Yes it is. A letter someone handed to me.”

“And this letter was enough to...”

“To disturb me, yes, at the time.”

Ganimard was there. He had been present at the sale of the ring. He went up to one of the stewards.

“It was you, wasn’t it, who gave M. Herschmann a letter?”

“Yes.”

“On behalf of whom?”

“On behalf of a lady.”

“Where is she?”

“Where is she?... Just a moment, sir, over there... that woman with a thick veil.”

“Who’s going out?”

“Yes.”

Ganimard dashed towards the door and noticed that the woman was going down the stairs. He ran after her. A stream of people blocked his way near the entrance. And outside he could not find her again.

He came back into the room and went up to Herschmann, identified himself and questioned him about the letter. Herschmann gave it to him. It contained, written hastily in pencil, and in handwriting unfamiliar to the financier, the simple words:

The blue diamond brings bad luck. Remember Baron d’Hautrec.

The tribulations concerning the blue diamond were not at an end. Already known in connection with the murder of the Baron d’Hautrec and with the incidents at the Drouot building, it was, six months later, to acquire great fame. Indeed, the following summer, the Countess of Crozon was robbed of the precious gem, which she had taken such pains to acquire.

Let us summarize this strange affair, the moving and dramatic twists and turns of which have been fascinating us all, and on which I am finally allowed to shed some light.

On the evening of 10th of August, the guests of M. and Mme de Crozon were gathered together in the drawing room of the chateau which towers above the Somme Bay. Music was being played. The countess sat down at the piano and, on a small piece of furniture, next to the instrument, she

put her jewels, among which was the Baron d'Hautrec's ring.

After an hour the count withdrew, together with his two cousins, the d'Andelles and Mme de Réal, an intimate friend of the Countess of Crozon. The latter stayed alone with M. Bleichen, the Austrian consul, and his wife.

They talked for a while, and then the countess switched off a large lamp standing on the drawing-room table. At the same moment M. Bleichen switched off the two lamps on the piano. There was a moment of darkness, and a little alarm, and then the consul lit a candle, and all three went back to their apartments. But the countess had scarcely reached her room when she remembered her jewels and enjoined her chambermaid to go and find them. The maid returned and placed them on the mantelpiece, without her mistress examining them first. The next day Mme de Crozon noticed that one ring was missing: the ring with the blue diamond.

She informed her husband. They concluded straight away that the chambermaid was above all suspicion, and that the culprit must be M. Bleichen. The count informed the police superintendent of Amiens, who initiated an inquiry and, discreetly, organized the most intensive surveillance to prevent the Austrian consul from either selling or dispatching the ring.

Officers surrounded the chateau day and night.

Two weeks then go by without the slightest incident. M. Bleichen announces his departure. And on that day a complaint is lodged against him. The superintendent intervenes officially and orders an inspection of his luggage. In a small bag, the key of which never leaves the consul, they find a small bottle of soap powder, and in the bottle is the ring!

Mme Bleichen faints, and her husband is put under arrest.

The defence strategy adopted by the culprit is well known. He said that he could only explain the presence of the ring as an act of revenge by M. de Crozon. "The count is a violent man and makes his wife unhappy. I had a long talk with her and strongly urged her to get a divorce. When he learnt about this, the count got his revenge by taking the ring and, at the time of my departure, slipping it in the toilet bag." The count and the countess maintained their accusation resolutely. Between the explanation that they gave and that of the consul, both of which were equally possible and probable, the public simply had to choose. There was no new fact to

tip the scales one way or the other. A whole month of gossip, speculations and investigations did not lead to a single definite fact.

Annoyed by all this fuss, and incapable of producing clear proof of guilt to justify their accusation, M. and Mme de Crozon demanded that an officer be sent from the Sûreté in Paris who was capable of sorting out the tangled threads. They sent Ganimard.

For four days the old chief inspector ferreted around, gossiped with people, walked in the park and conducted long conversations with the maid, with the chauffeur, the gardeners and the employees in the local post offices, and visited the apartments occupied by the Bleichen household, the d'Andelle cousins and Mme Réal. Then, one morning, he disappeared without taking leave of his hosts.

But one week later, they received this telegram:

Request you come tomorrow, Friday, five o'clock in the evening, to the Japanese Tearoom, Rue Boissy-d'Anglas.

Ganimard

On Friday, at five o'clock exactly, their car stopped in front of number 9 Rue Boissy-d'Anglas. Without a word of explanation, the old chief inspector, who was waiting for them on the pavement, led them to the first floor of the Japanese Tearoom.

In one of the rooms they met two people whom Ganimard introduced:

"M. Gerbois, teacher at the secondary school in Versailles, from whom, you will recall, Arsène Lupin stole half a million francs. And M. Léonce d'Hautrec, nephew and sole legatee of the Baron d'Hautrec."

The four people sat down. A few minutes later a fifth person came to join them. It was the head of the Sûreté.

M. Dudouis was in quite a bad mood. He greeted them and said:

"What is it then, Ganimard? At headquarters they gave me your phone message. Is it serious?"

"Very serious, boss. Within an hour, the recent affairs in which I was involved will be resolved here. It seemed to me that your presence was indispensable."

"And also the presence of Dieuzy and Folenfant, whom I noticed downstairs around the doorway?"

"Yes, boss."

“And for what reason? Is there going to be an arrest? What a *performance*! Go on, Ganimard, we’re listening to you.”

Ganimard hesitated for a few moments, and then spoke with the clear intention of amazing his listeners:

“First I can confirm that M. Bleichen had nothing to do with the theft of the ring.”

“Oh, oh!” said M. Dudouis. “That’s merely an assertion... and a very serious one.”

And the count asked:

“Are your efforts limited to this... discovery?”

“No, sir. Two days after the theft, it happened that during a car journey three of your guests came to the market town of Cr cy. While two of the persons were going to visit the famous battlefield, the third hurried off to the post office and dispatched a small box tied up with string, sealed in accordance with the regulations, and registered as having the value of a hundred francs.”

M. de Crozon objected:

“There’s nothing abnormal about all this.”

“Perhaps it will seem less normal to you that this person, instead of giving their real name, sent off the package under the name of Rousseau, and that the addressee, a M. Beloux, who was living in Paris, moved away the very evening of the day he received the box – that is to say, the ring.”

“Perhaps,” asked the count, “it was one of my cousins, the d’Andelles?”

“It wasn’t those gentlemen.”

“So, Mme de R al?”

“Yes.”

Astounded, the countess exclaimed:

“You are accusing my friend, Mme de R al?”

“One simple question, Madame,” Ganimard replied. “Was Madame de R al present at the sale of the blue diamond?”

“Yes, but independently. We weren’t together.”

“Did she urge you to buy the ring?”

The countess thought back over her memories.

“Yes... indeed... I even think she was the first person who told me about it.”

“I note what you have said, Madame. So it is firmly established that it

was Mme de Réal who was the first person to tell you about that ring, and it was she who urged you to buy it.”

“Yet my friend is incapable—”

“Excuse me, but Mme de Réal is only an occasional acquaintance of yours and not your intimate friend, as the newspapers have put it, which has removed any suspicions of her. You have only known her since this winter. Well, I claim that I can show you that everything she has told you about herself, about her past, about her relationships, is completely untrue, and that Mme Blanche de Réal did not exist before having told you about herself, nor does she exist at the present moment.”

“And so?”

“So?” said Ganimard.

“Yes, this whole story is very strange, but how is it related to our case? Even if Mme de Réal did take the ring, which is not at all proven, why did she hide it in M. Bleichen’s tooth powder? What the hell! If you go to the trouble to steal the blue diamond, then you keep it. What’s your reply to that?”

“Me? Nothing. But Mme de Réal will reply to that.”

“So she does exist?”

“She exists... but doesn’t exist at the same time. In a nutshell, it’s like this. Three days ago, while reading the paper which I read every day, I saw at the top of the list of strangers visiting Trouville: ‘Hôtel Beaurivage: Mme de Réal, etc.’ You will understand that I was in Trouville that very evening and I questioned the manager of the Beaurivage. According to his description and according to certain clues that I collected, this Mme de Réal was definitely the woman I was looking for, but she had left the hotel, leaving her address in Paris, at 3 Rue du Colisée. The day before yesterday I went to this address, and I learnt that there was no such person as Mme de Réal, but just simply a woman called Réal, who lived on the second floor, whose profession was that of diamond broker and who was often away. Just the previous day, she had returned from a trip. Yesterday I rang at her door and, under a false name, I offered Mme de Réal my services as intermediary with certain persons who were in a position to buy some valuable stones. Today we have an appointment here for our first business meeting.”

“What! You are expecting her?”

“At half-past five.”

“And you are sure?”

“That it is the Mme de Réal of the Château de Crozon? I have irrefutable proof. But... listen... Folenfant’s signal...”

There was the sound of a whistle. Ganimard got up swiftly.

“There’s no time to lose. Monsieur and Madame de Crozon, please go into the next room. And you too, Monsieur d’Hautrec... you too, Monsieur Gerbois... The door will be left open, and at the first signal I will ask you to intervene. I’d like you to stay here, boss, please.”

“And if some other people come?” commented M. Dudouis.

“They won’t. This establishment is new, and the manager, who is a friend of mine, won’t let a single soul come up here... except for the Blonde Woman.”

“The Blonde Woman? What’s that you say?”

“The Blonde Woman herself, boss, the accomplice of Arsène Lupin, the mysterious Blonde Woman, concerning whom I have definite proof. What is more, in front of us all, I want to bring together the testimonies against her of all those whom she ripped off.”

He leant out of the window.

“She’s coming... she’s coming in... There’s no other way for her to escape. Folenfant and Dieuzy are keeping watch on the door... the Blonde Woman is ours, boss!”

Almost immediately a woman stopped in the doorway. She was tall, slender, with a very pale face and golden hair of a dazzling shade.

Ganimard was overcome with such emotion that he remained silent, incapable of uttering a single word. She was there, in front of him, at his mercy!

What a victory over Arsène Lupin! And what a revenge! And at the same time this victory seemed to have been won with such ease that he wondered if the Blonde Woman would not slip through his fingers thanks to one of Arsène Lupin’s customary miracles.

She waited however, surprised by the silence, and looked around her without concealing her anxiety.

“She’ll leave! She’ll disappear!” Ganimard was thinking in alarm.

Swiftly he placed himself between her and the door. She turned round and tried to go out.

“No, no,” he said. “Why are you going away?”

“For Heaven’s sake, sir, I really don’t understand such behaviour. Let me —”

“There’s no reason at all for you to leave, Madame, and, on the contrary, good reason for you to stay.”

“But...”

“It’s no use. You are not leaving.”

Looking very pale, she collapsed onto a chair and mumbled:

“What do you want?”

Ganimard was victorious. He had got the Blonde Woman. Fully in control of himself, he said:

“I wish to introduce to you this friend of mine, whom I have told you about, and who is very keen to buy jewels... especially diamonds. Have you brought the one you promised?”

“No... no... I don’t know... I don’t remember.”

“Yes you do... Think back!... Someone of your acquaintance was to hand over to you a tinted diamond... ‘Something like the blue diamond,’ I said laughing, and you replied, ‘Exactly, I think I have what you want.’ Do you remember?”

She was silent. A small string bag that she was holding in her hand fell down. She picked it up swiftly and held it close to her. Her fingers were trembling a little.

“Well now, I can see that you do not trust us, Madame de Réal, so I’m going to set you a good example and show you what I have in my possession.”

He drew out a piece of paper from his wallet, which he unfolded, and he held out a lock of hair.

“First, here are some strands of Antoinette Bréhat’s hair, torn out by the Baron and collected from the dead man’s hand. I have seen Mlle Gerbois, and she has identified positively the colour of the Blonde Woman’s hair... it is the same colour as yours and, what is more, it is exactly the same colour.”

Mme Réal looked at him with a dazed expression, and as though she really could not grasp the meaning of what he was saying. He continued:

“And now here are two scent bottles, without labels, it is true, and empty. But still sufficiently impregnated with their scent to enable Mlle Gerbois,

this very morning, to identify the perfume of the Blonde Woman who was her travelling companion for two weeks. Well, one of these bottles comes from the room that Mme de Réal occupied at the Château de Crozon, and the other is from the room that you were occupying at the Hôtel Beaurivage.

“What are you saying?... The Blonde Woman... the Château de Crozon...”

Without replying, the inspector lined up four pieces of paper on the table.

“Finally,” he said, “Here, on these four sheets, are an example of the handwriting of Antoinette Bréhat, another of the woman who wrote a note to Baron Herschmann at the time of the sale of the blue diamond, another by Mme de Réal, during her stay at Crozon, and the fourth... is yours, Madame... it is your name and address, given by you to the porter of the Hôtel Beaurivage at Trouville. Well, compare the four pieces of handwriting. They are identical.”

“But you are mad, sir! You are mad! What does all this mean?”

“It means, Madame,” exclaimed Ganimard, with a grand gesture, “that the Blonde Woman, the woman friend and the accomplice of Arsène Lupin are none other than you.”

He pushed open the door of the next room, pounced on M. Gerbois, grabbed hold of him by the shoulders and, dragging him in front of Mme de Réal, said:

“M. Gerbois, do you recognize here the person who abducted your daughter, and whom you saw at the apartment of Maître Detinan?”

“No.”

There was a commotion which shocked everyone. Ganimard became insecure.

“No?... is it possible?... Look, think it over...”

“I’ve thought it all over... This lady is blonde just like the Blonde Woman... pale just like she is... but she does not resemble her at all.”

“I can’t believe it... Such a mistake would be unacceptable... Monsieur d’Hautrec, you recognize Antoinette Bréhat, don’t you?”

“I saw Antoinette Bréhat at my uncle’s... it’s not her.”

“Nor is the lady Mme de Réal,” declared Count de Crozon.

This was the death blow. Ganimard was stunned, didn’t say another word

and stood there with his head down and a shifty look. Nothing was left of all his schemes. The edifice had crumbled.

M. Dudouis stood up.

“You must excuse us, Madame, there has been a regrettable mix-up, and I must beg you to forget the matter. But what I do not understand is your distress... your strange attitude since your arrival here.”

“Good Heavens, sir, I was afraid... There is more than a hundred thousand francs’ worth of jewels in my bag, and your friend’s behaviour was scarcely reassuring.”

“But what about your constant absences?...”

“Doesn’t my profession require it?”

M. Dudouis had nothing to say in reply. He turned to his subordinate.

“You have acquired your information with deplorable thoughtlessness, Ganimard, and just now you behaved towards the lady in the most tactless way. You will have to explain yourself to me in my office.”

The interview was at end, and the head of the Sûreté was about to leave, when something really disconcerting occurred. Mme Réal went up to the inspector and said:

“I understand that your name is Monsieur Ganimard... if I’m not mistaken?”

“No, you’re not.”

“In that case, this letter must be for you. I received it this morning, addressed as you can read: ‘M. Justin Ganimard, care of Mme Réal.’ I thought it was a joke, as I do not know you by this name, but no doubt the unknown correspondent knew about our meeting.”

By some strange intuition, Justin Ganimard was about to seize the letter and destroy it. But in front of his superior he did not dare to, and he tore open the envelope. The letter contained the following words, which he uttered in a barely intelligible voice:

“‘There once was a Blonde Woman, a Lupin and a Ganimard. Well, the bad Ganimard wanted to hurt the pretty Blonde Woman, and the good Lupin did not want him to. Also the good Lupin, wanting the Blonde Woman to become intimate with the Countess de Crozon, had her take on the name of Mme de Réal, which is the name – more or less – of an honest woman retailer, with golden hair and a pale face. And the good Lupin said to himself: “If ever the bad Ganimard is on the track of the Blonde

Woman, how useful it would be to me to divert him onto the track of the honest retailer!" It was a wise precaution and a fruitful one. A short message sent to the newspaper read by the bad Ganimard, a bottle of scent forgotten intentionally by the real Blonde Woman in the Hôtel Beaurivage, the name and address of this real Blonde Woman in the register of the hotel, and that did the trick. What do you think of that, Ganimard? I wanted to recount this adventure to you in detail, because I know that, with your bright mind, you would be the first to laugh at it. It really does have an arresting quality, and I confess that I've found it all terribly amusing.

"So, thank you very much, my dear friend, and please remember me to that excellent man, M. Dudouis.

"Arsène Lupin."

"But he knows everything!" moaned Ganimard, who was in absolutely no mood to laugh. "He knows things that I didn't tell anyone! How could he have known that I would ask you to come, boss? How could he know about my discovery of the first bottle?... How could he know?..."

He stamped his feet and tore at his hair, wracked by the most tragic despair.

M. Dudouis took pity on him.

"Come along, Ganimard, console yourself, we'll try to do better next time."

And the head of the Sûreté went off, accompanied by Mme Réal.

Ten minutes went by. Ganimard read and reread the letter from Lupin. In a corner, M. and Mme de Crozon, M. d'Hautrec and M. Gerbois were engaged in an animated discussion. Finally the count went towards the inspector and said to him:

"From all this, my dear sir, the result is that we are no more advanced than before."

"I beg your pardon. My inquiry has established that the Blonde Woman is indisputably the main participant in these affairs, and that Lupin controls her. That is an enormous step."

"And a useless one. The mystery has probably become more obscure. The Blonde Woman kills in order to steal the blue diamond, but she does not steal it. She steals it, only to get rid of it for the benefit of someone else."

“I can’t do anything about it.”

“Admittedly, but perhaps someone could...”

“What are you trying to say?”

The count hesitated, but the countess spoke up clearly:

“There is a man, the only one apart from you, it seems to me, who would be capable of fighting against Lupin and of restraining him. Monsieur Ganimard, would it be disagreeable to you if we sought the aid of Herlock Sholmes?”

He was disconcerted.

“Not at all... only... I don’t really understand...”

“It’s like this. All these mysteries annoy me. I want to see things clearly. M. Gerbois and M. d’Hautrec want the same thing, and we have come to an agreement that we should make contact with the famous English detective.”

“You are right, Madame,” the inspector said, with an honesty which was not without some merit, “you are right. Old Ganimard is not up to the task of fighting against Arsène Lupin. Will Herlock Sholmes be able to succeed? I hope he will, for I have the greatest admiration for him... Yet... it is not very likely...”

“It is not very likely that he’ll succeed?”

“That’s my opinion. I regard a duel between Herlock Sholmes and Arsène Lupin as a foregone conclusion. The Englishman will be beaten.”

“In any case, can he rely on you?”

“Completely, Madame. He may be assured of my unreserved support.”

“Do you know his address?”

“Yes, 219 Parker Street.”

That same evening, M. and Mme de Crozon withdrew their accusation against Consul Bleichen, and a collective letter was addressed to Herlock Sholmes.

Dupin, Lecoq: C. Auguste Dupin is a fictional detective who appears in several short stories by Edgar Allan Poe (1809–49). Monsieur Lecoq is a fictional detective who appears in the novels of Émile Gaboriau (1832–73).

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Herlock Sholmes Opens Hostilities

“**W**HAT WOULD the gentlemen like?”

“Whatever you like,” replied Arsène Lupin, as a man to whom such culinary details were of little interest. “Whatever you like, but no meat or alcohol.”

The waiter went away in disdain.

I exclaimed, “What, you’re still a vegetarian?”

“More and more,” asserted Lupin.

“For reasons of taste, belief, or just out of habit?”

“For health reasons.”

“And you never break the rule?”

“Oh, yes! When I am in society... so as not to draw attention to myself.”

We were dining together near the Gare du Nord, at the back of a small restaurant where Arsène Lupin had asked me to meet him. He liked from time to time to arrange a meeting with me by telephone in this way in some corner of Paris. He always proved to be inexhaustibly eloquent, full of the joys of life, unaffected and easy-going, and he always came out with an unexpected anecdote, a memory or an account of an adventure which I did not know.

That evening he seemed to me to be even more exuberant than usual. He laughed and chatted with a strange liveliness and that fine irony which is peculiar to him, a light and spontaneous irony with no trace of bitterness. It was a pleasure to see him like that, and I could not refrain from expressing my satisfaction.

“Ah, yes!” he exclaimed. “I’m enjoying some of those days on which everything seems to be delightful, and I feel that I am full of the joy of life, as though I have an infinite treasure within me which I shall never exhaust. Yet, God knows, I live without counting the cost.”

“Too much so, perhaps.”

“The treasure is infinite, I tell you! I can exert myself and waste my time, I can cast my strength and youth to the four winds, and I am making space for even livelier and more youthful strength... And my life is really so

beautiful! I only have to wish, don't I, to become, from one day to the next, I don't know!... a public speaker, a factory boss, a man of politics... Well, I swear to you, that such an idea would never occur to me! Arsène Lupin I am, and Arsène Lupin I shall remain. And I search through history in vain for a destiny comparable to mine, more fulfilled and more intense... Napoleon? Yes, perhaps... but Napoleon at the end of his career, during the French campaign, when Europe was crushing him, and when he asked himself, at every battle, if it would not be the last that he would fight."

Was he serious? Was he joking? The tone of his voice had become heated, and he continued:

"It's all there, you see: the danger, the continuous sensation of danger! To breathe it like the air we breathe, to discern it around you, blowing and roaring, watching out for you, approaching you... And to remain calm in the midst of the storm... without turning a hair!... Otherwise you are lost... There is only one feeling which is as good as it, that of a driver racing in a car! However a race lasts just one morning, but my race lasts for a lifetime!"

"What lyricism!" I exclaimed... "And you want me to believe that you don't have any special grounds for being excited?"

He smiled.

"Well," he said, "you're a shrewd psychologist. There is indeed something else."

He poured himself a large glass of fresh water, swallowed it and said to me:

"Did you read today's *Le Temps*?"

"Well, no."

"Herlock Sholmes was due to cross the English Channel this afternoon and arrive around six o'clock."

"What the devil for?"

"A little trip funded by the Crozons, the nephew of d'Hautrec, and Gerbois. They met at the Gare du Nord, and from there they went to meet Ganimard. All six of them are conferring at this moment."

Despite the enormous curiosity that he inspires in me, I have never allowed myself to ask Arsène Lupin about events in his private life, before he himself mentioned them to me. In such matters it is, for my part, a

question of reserve on which I will not compromise. Besides, at that moment, his name had not yet been mentioned, at least officially, in connection with the matter of the blue diamond. So I waited. He continued:

“*Le Temps* has also published an interview with that excellent man Ganimard, according to which a certain blonde woman, said to be my friend, is assumed to have murdered Baron d’Hautrec, and tried to steal Mme de Crozon’s famous ring. And naturally he accuses me of having instigated these infamies.”

A light shudder went through me. Was it true? Was I to believe that the habit of stealing, his mode of existence, the very logic of events, had led this man to such a grievous crime? I looked at him. He seemed so calm, and his eyes looked at you in such a frank way!

I examined his hands: their shape was infinitely delicate. His hands were truly harmless, the hands of an artist...

“Ganimard is a crank,” I murmured.

He protested:

“No, no he isn’t. Ganimard is perceptive, sometimes even brilliant.”

“Brilliant?”

“Oh yes. This interview is a masterpiece. First he announces the arrival of his English rival, to put me on my guard and make the task more difficult for him. Then he specifies the precise stage to which he has brought the case, so that Sholmes only has the benefit of these discoveries. It’s only fair.”

“Be that as it may, you now have to deal with two opponents, and what opponents they are!”

“Oh, one of them doesn’t count.”

“And the other?”

“Sholmes? Oh, I confess that he’s a worthy opponent. But that’s just what fascinates me and why you see me in such a cheerful mood. First, it’s a question of pride: they consider that it’s not too much to expect the famous Englishman to get the better of me. Secondly, think of the pleasure which a combatant like me must experience at the idea of a duel with Herlock Sholmes. Finally, I shall be obliged to apply myself to the task wholeheartedly, for I know this gentleman: he will stick to my heels like glue.”

“He’s good.”

“Oh, very good. As a detective, I don’t think there has ever existed or ever will exist anyone like him. But I do have one advantage over him: it’s he who’s attacking and me who’s defending. My role is easier. What is more...”

He smiled imperceptibly and finished what he was saying:

“What is more, I know his way of fighting and he doesn’t know mine. And I’m keeping some secret weapons which will give him cause for thought...”

He made little taps on the table with his fingers, and uttered short phrases in delight:

“Arsène Lupin versus Herlock Sholmes... France versus England... At last Trafalgar will be revenged!... Oh, the poor man... he has no idea what I am preparing... and a Lupin forewarned—”

He interrupted himself suddenly, shaken by a coughing fit, and he hid his face in his napkin, like someone who has swallowed something the wrong way.

“A breadcrumb?” I asked him. “Drink a little water.”

“No, it’s not that,” he said, in a choked voice.

“Then what is it?”

“I need some air.”

“Do you want the window opened?”

“No, I’m going. Quick, give me my overcoat and my hat. I’m off...”

“Very well, but, what’s it all about?”

“Those two gentlemen who have just come in... you see the tallest one?... Well, as we go out, walk on my left so that he won’t catch sight of me.”

“The one who’s sitting down behind you?”

“Yes him... For personal reasons, I prefer... I’ll explain to you outside...”

“But who is it then?”

“Herlock Sholmes.”

He made a strenuous effort to control himself, as if he was ashamed of his agitation, put down his napkin, swallowed a glass of water and said to me with a smile, now completely recovered:

“It’s funny isn’t it? It’s true I’m not easily bothered, but that unexpected sight...”

“What are you afraid of, since no one can recognize you, due to all your

transformations? Even to me, each time I meet you again, it seems that I'm face to face with a new individual."

"*He* will recognize me. He only saw me once,¹ but I sensed that when he saw me it was for life, and that he saw not my always modifiable outward appearance but my innermost being... and then... and then... I wasn't expecting it in this place!... What a strange encounter!... This little restaurant."

"So," I said to him, "are we going?"

"No... no..."

"What are you going to do?"

"The best thing to do would be to act boldly, to go up to him."

"You're surely not thinking of doing that?"

"Yes indeed... What is more, I'd be better off questioning him, to find out what he knows... Ah, wait! I have the feeling that his gaze is fixed on the nape of my neck, on my shoulders... and that he is searching... that he is remembering..."

He thought it over. I noticed a malicious smile at the corner of his lips, then, obeying a whim of his impulsive nature rather than what was necessary in the situation, he got up suddenly, spun round and, leaning forward, said very cheerfully:

"What a coincidence! It's really a stroke of luck... Permit me to introduce you to one of my friends."

For a second or two, the Englishman was disconcerted, then he made an instinctive movement, ready to leap at Arsène Lupin, who just shook his head and said:

"That would be wrong... and what is more, the move would not be a dignified one... and so pointless!"

The Englishman turned right and left, as though seeking help.

"And that would be no better..." said Lupin. "Besides, are you sure that you have the authority to lay hands on me? Come on, show yourself to be a good sport."

To show himself to be a good sport was scarcely tempting on this occasion. Nevertheless, it is likely that it was this option which seemed the best to the Englishman, for he got up partly and coolly made an introduction:

“Mr Wilson, my friend and collaborator – Monsieur Arsène Lupin.”

Wilson’s bewilderment provoked hilarity. His wide-open eyes and large, gaping mouth were the two prominent features on his beaming face, with his shining skin, tight as that of an apple, around which his crew cut and short beard were planted like blades of thick, strong grass.

“Wilson, you are not hiding sufficiently your astonishment in face of the most natural events in the world,” chuckled Herlock Sholmes, with a touch of mockery.

Wilson mumbled:

“Why don’t you stop him?”

“You haven’t noticed, Wilson, that the gentleman has placed himself between the door and me, and is two feet away from the door. Before I had time to move my little finger he would already be outside.”

“It doesn’t matter,” said Lupin.

He moved round the table and sat down, so that the Englishman was between the door and himself. He was thereby leaving it up to the other man.

Wilson looked at Sholmes to find out if it was all right to admire this bold move. The Englishman remained inscrutable. But, after a moment, he called out:

“Waiter!”

The waiter ran to them. Sholmes ordered:

“Some soda waters, beer and whisky.”

Peace had been signed... until further notice. Soon after, all four of us were sitting at the same table, chatting away happily.

Herlock Sholmes is a man such as one might meet any day. About fifty years old, he resembles a decent middle-class person, who might have spent his life behind a desk, attending to his account books. Nothing distinguishes him from any honest citizen of London, neither his reddish-coloured sideburns, nor his shaven chin, nor his rather heavy-looking appearance, nothing if it were not for his extremely keen, lively and penetrating eyes.

And then of course he was Herlock Sholmes, that is to say a man of phenomenal intuition, observation, perception and ingenuity. One might well think that Nature had amused herself by taking the two most

extraordinary types of detective that the imagination has produced, Edgar Allan Poe's Dupin and Lecoq's Gaboriau, to create one which is, in his way, even more extraordinary and unreal. And one really does ask oneself, when one hears accounts of the exploits which have made him universally famous, if this Herlock Sholmes isn't a legendary figure, a hero who has emerged alive from the mind of a great novelist such as Conan Doyle, for example.

Straight away, when Arsène Lupin asked him how long he would be staying, he brought the conversation back to its true subject:

"My stay depends on you, Monsieur Lupin."

"Oh!" exclaimed the other, laughing. "If it really depended on me, then I would beg you to take the ship back tonight."

"This evening is a little early, but I hope that in about eight or ten days..."

"You're in such a hurry then?"

"I'm busy with so many things, the robbery at the Anglo-Chinese Bank, the kidnapping of Lady Eccleston... So, let me see now, Monsieur Lupin, do you think that one week will be long enough?"

"More than enough, if you restrict yourself to the double case of the blue diamond. And besides, it's the period of time I'll need to take my precautions, in case the resolution of this double case provides you with certain advantages which would be dangerous for my security."

"But," said the Englishman, "I'm counting on obtaining these advantages within eight to ten days."

"So that you can arrest me on the eleventh day, perhaps?"

"On the tenth, at the latest."

Lupin thought the matter over and shook his head:

"Difficult... difficult..."

"Difficult, yes, but possible, indeed certain..."

"Absolutely certain," said Wilson, as if he discerned clearly himself the long series of operations which would lead his collaborator to the outcome he had announced.

Herlock Sholmes smiled:

"Wilson, who knows all about such things, is here to testify to these facts."

And he continued:

“Of course, I haven’t got all the trumps in my hands, since it concerns cases which are already several months old. I lack certain components, clues, on which I usually base my inquiries.

“Such as mud stains and cigarette ash,” Wilson explained with an air of self-importance.

“But in addition to Ganimard’s remarkable conclusions, I have at my disposal all the articles written on the topic, all the observations gathered and, as a consequence of all this, a few ideas of my own on the case.”

“Several perspectives which have been suggested to us, either through analysis or through hypotheses,” said Wilson sententiously.

“Would it be indiscreet,” said Arsène Lupin, in the deferential tone he employed when talking to Sholmes, “to ask you about the general opinion that you have been able to form?”

It was truly the most fascinating thing to see, those two men in each other’s presence, their elbows on the table, discussing seriously and calmly, as if they were trying to resolve an arduous problem, or to come to an agreement on a controversial point. And it was all done with supreme irony, which they both enjoyed profoundly, as both amateurs and artistes. Wilson was swooning with pleasure.

Herlock slowly filled his pipe, lit it and spoke as follows:

“I estimate that this case is infinitely less complex than it appears at first sight.”

“Much less indeed,” said Wilson, his faithful echo.

“I say case, because for me there is only one. The death of Baron d’Hautrec, the story of the ring and, let us not forget, the mystery of ticket number 514 – series 23 are only different aspects of what one could call the enigma of the Blonde Woman. Well, in my opinion, it is just a question of discovering the link which joins the three episodes of the same story, the fact which proves the unity of the three methods. Ganimard, whose judgement is a little superficial, sees this unity in the ability to disappear, in the power of coming and going while remaining invisible. But this miraculous intervention does not satisfy me.”

“And so?”

“Well, in my view,” said Sholmes clearly, “the common characteristic of the three cases is your manifest and obvious intention, though not noticed

before, to bring the case to locations chosen by you in advance. On your part there is more than just a plan, indeed a necessity, a condition, a *sine qua non*, for success.”

“Could you go into it in more detail?”

“Easily. Thus, from the beginning of your conflict with M. Gerbois, isn’t it *obvious* that the apartment of Maître Detinan was the location chosen by you, the inevitable location where it was necessary to meet? There was no other one which seemed so secure to you, so much so that you arranged a meeting there, publicly one might say, with the Blonde Woman and Mlle Gerbois.”

“The teacher’s daughter,” added Wilson.

“Now, let’s discuss the blue diamond. Did you try to acquire it since it had been in Baron d’Hautrec’s possession? No. But the Baron takes over his brother’s house and, six months later, Antoinette Bréhat comes on the scene and the first attempt is made. The diamond eludes you, and the big noisy auction is organized at the Drouot Building. Will it be an open auction? Can the wealthiest amateur be sure of acquiring the jewel? Not at all. At the moment when the banker Herschmann is about to carry it off, a woman has a letter handed to him, and it is the Countess de Crozon, who has been coached and influenced by the same woman, who buys the diamond. Will it disappear immediately? No: you lack the means to arrange this. So there’s an interlude. But the countess settles down in her chateau, which is what you were waiting for. And the ring disappears.”

“Only to reappear in Consul Bleichen’s tooth powder, a strange anomaly,” Lupin objected.

“Come now,” exclaimed Herlock, striking the table with his fist, “you shouldn’t be telling such tall stories to me. Idiots may well be taken in by them, but not this old fox.”

“Which means?”

“Which means...”

Sholmes took his time, as if he wanted to be sure of his effect. Finally he spoke as follows:

“The blue diamond found in the tooth powder is a false diamond. The real one you kept for yourself.”

Arsène was silent for a moment, and said quite simply, with his gaze fixed on the Englishman:

“You are a formidable man, sir.”

“He’s a formidable man, isn’t he?” emphasized Wilson, gaping with admiration.

“Yes,” affirmed Lupin, “everything is becoming clear, everything is acquiring its true meaning. Not one of the investigating magistrates, and not one of the special journalists who have pursued these cases relentlessly, has progressed so far in the direction of the truth. It’s a miracle of intuition and logic.”

“Pah!” said the Englishman, flattered at the tribute by such an expert, “you just have to think it over.”

“You need to know *how* to think it over, and few know how to! But now the field of suppositions has been narrowed down, and ground has been cleared...”

“Well, now I only have to find out why the three adventures had their denouements at 25 Rue Clapeyron, 134 Avenue Henri-Martin and inside the walls of the Château de Crozon. That’s where the problem lies. The rest is only nonsense and a charade fit only for children. Don’t you think so?”

“I think so.”

“In that case, Monsieur Lupin, am I wrong to repeat my assertion that my chore will be accomplished in ten days?”

“In ten days, yes, the whole truth will be known to you.”

“And you will be arrested.”

“No.”

“No?”

“In order for me to be arrested, it is necessary for there to be a combination of circumstances so improbable, a sequence of such astonishing bad luck, that I cannot admit this eventuality.”

“What cannot be achieved by circumstances and adverse conditions can be achieved by the will and obstinacy of one man, Monsieur Lupin.”

“If the will and obstinacy of another man does not present an insurmountable obstacle to this plan, Mr Sholmes.”

“There is no such thing as an insurmountable obstacle, Monsieur Lupin.”

The look they exchanged was deep, and not at all provocative on either side, but calm and bold. It was the clashing of two swords engaging with

each other. It was a clear and honest signal.

“Splendid!” exclaimed Lupin. “Here’s a man to be reckoned with! An opponent, but a rare bird. This Herlock Sholmes! It’s going to be fun.”

“You’re not afraid?” asked Wilson.

“Almost, Mr Wilson, and to prove it,” said Lupin, getting up, “I’m going to hurry up and prepare my arrangements for a retreat... without which I shall risk being brought to heel. So we’ll say ten days then, Mr Sholmes?”

“Ten days. Today is Sunday. By a week on Wednesday it’ll all be over.”

“And I’ll be behind bars?”

“No doubt about it.”

“Oh dear! And here I was enjoying such a quiet life.”

“No problems, just getting on with my own affairs, to hell with the police and the comforting feeling of universal sympathy surrounding me... all that will have to be changed! Oh well, it’s just the flip side of the coin... After fair weather comes the rain... No more laughter. Farewell!”

“Then hurry,” said Wilson, full of concern for an individual whom Sholmes inspired with obvious respect. “Don’t waste a minute.”

“Not a minute, Mr Wilson, but just the time to tell you how pleased I was at meeting you, and how I envy the Maestro for having such a valuable collaborator as yourself.”

They said goodbye to each other courteously, like two opponents on the battlefield who are not divided by any hatred, but who are obliged by fate to fight each other mercilessly. And Lupin, seizing my arm, took me outside.

“What do you think of it all, my dear chap? Here’s a real feast, the incidents of which will look good in the memoirs which you are writing about me.”

He closed the door of the restaurant and, stopping a few feet away, said:

“Do you smoke?”

“No, neither do you, I think.”

“No, me neither.”

He lit up a cigarette with a wax match, which he shook several times to put out. But he immediately threw away the cigarette, and ran across the roadway and joined two men who had just appeared suddenly from the shadows, as though summoned by a signal. He conversed with them on the pavement opposite for several minutes, and then rejoined me.

“I beg your pardon. This damned Sholmes is going to give me a hard time. But I swear to you that he hasn’t finished with Lupin... Farewell... the ineffable Wilson is right, I haven’t got a minute to lose.”

And he went away quickly.

And that is how that strange evening ended, or at least the part of the evening in which I was present. For there took place in the following hours many other events, which the facts confided in me by the other guests at the dinner have fortunately allowed me to piece together in detail.

At the very moment when Lupin was leaving me, Herlock Sholmes drew out his watch and also got up.

“Twenty to nine. At nine o’clock I have to meet the count and countess at the station.”

“Off we go!” exclaimed Wilson, swallowing two glasses of whisky in succession.

They went out.

“Wilson, don’t turn your head... Perhaps we’re being followed, in which case act as if it does not matter to us at all if we are... Tell me, Wilson, give me your opinion: why was Lupin in that restaurant?”

Wilson did not hesitate.

“To eat.”

“Wilson, the more we work together, the more I perceive how you continue to make progress. My word, you are becoming amazing.”

In the shadow, Wilson blushed with pleasure, and Sholmes continued:

“To eat, exactly, and then, quite probably to make sure if I was going to Crozon as Ganimard announced in his interview. So I am leaving in order not to upset him. But as it’s a question of gaining time over him, I am not leaving.”

“Ah!” said Wilson, taken aback.

“You, my friend, dash off down this street, take a car, two or three cars. Come back later to look for the cases that we have left in the left-luggage office and, at full speed, off you go to the Élysée Palace hotel.”

“And what do I do at the Élysée Palace?”

“You ask for a room and you go to bed, where you will sleep soundly and wait for my instructions.”

Wilson, very proud of the important role that had been assigned to him,

went off. Herlock Sholmes took his ticket and boarded the express bound for Amiens, in which the Count and Countess de Crozon had already settled down.

He just greeted them and then lit a second pipe and smoked peacefully, standing in the corridor.

The train moved off. After six minutes, he came to sit down next to the countess:

“Do you have your ring with you, Madame?”

“Yes.”

“Please be kind enough to lend it to me.”

He took it and examined it.

“It’s just as I thought. It’s a reconstituted diamond.”

“A reconstituted diamond?”

“It’s a new process which consists of subjecting diamond dust to an enormously high temperature, so that it fuses together, and all that has to be done is to reconstitute it as a single stone.”

“What! But my diamond is genuine.”

“Yours, yes, but this one is not yours.”

“Then where is mine?”

“In the hands of Arsène Lupin.”

“So what about this one?”

“This one was substituted for yours and slipped into M. Bleichen’s bottle, where you found it again.”

“But is it really a fake?”

“It’s an absolute fake.”

Dumbfounded and shattered, the countess was speechless, while her husband turned the jewel over and over every way incredulously. Finally she mumbled:

“Is it possible? But why didn’t they simply steal it? And how did they take it?”

“That’s exactly what I am going to try and shed light on.”

“At the Château de Crozon?”

“No, I’m getting off at Creil, and returning to Paris. It’s there that the game between Arsène Lupin and me has to be played out. The moves are just as valid in one place as another, but I prefer Lupin to think that I am on a journey.”

“Yet...”

“What does it matter to you, Madame? The main thing is your diamond, isn’t it?”

“Yes.”

“Well, rest assured. A short while ago I undertook to do something which is much more difficult to accomplish. You have the word of Herlock Sholmes that I shall return to you the genuine diamond.”

The train slowed down. He put the false diamond in his pocket and opened the door. The count exclaimed:

“But you’re getting out on the wrong side!”

“By doing this, if Lupin is having me tailed, they will lose track of me. Farewell.”

An employee protested vainly. The Englishman made his way to the office of the stationmaster. Fifty minutes later he jumped into a train which got back to Paris just before midnight.

He ran across the station, came back in through the buffet, went out through another door and jumped into a cab.

“Driver, Rue Clapeyron.”

Having made certain that he had not been followed, he had the vehicle stopped at the entrance to the street, and engaged in a minute examination of Maître Detinan’s house, and the two neighbouring houses. By taking equal strides he measured certain distances, and wrote some notes and numbers in his notebook.

“Driver, Avenue Henri-Martin.”

At the corner of this avenue and the Rue de la Pompe, he paid for the cab, went along the pavement to number 134 and started doing the same calculations in front of Baron d’Hautrec’s house and the two residential properties flanking it, measuring the width of their respective façades and calculating the depth of the little gardens that lie in front of the row of façades.

The avenue was deserted and very dark under the rows of trees, between which, here and there, a gas lamp seemed to be struggling vainly against the depths of the darkness. One of them threw some pale light on a part of the house, and Sholmes could see a placard with the words “To let” hanging on the gate, the two uncultivated paths that encircled the small lawn and the huge empty windows of the uninhabited house.

“That’s right,” he said to himself, “since the Baron’s death there have been no tenants... Ah, if only I could get in and visit it for the first time!”

It was sufficient for this idea to cross his mind for him to want to put it into effect. But how? As the height of the gate made any attempt at climbing over it impossible, he took from his pocket an electric torch and a skeleton key, which he always had with him. To his great surprise, he realized that the wings of the gate were half open. So he could slip inside the garden, taking care not to close the gate again. But he had not taken three steps when he stopped. A faint light had passed across one of the windows on the second floor.

And the light passed a second and a third window, without him being able to see anything else but a silhouette which stood out against the walls of the rooms. And from the second floor the light descended to the first and, for a long time, wandered around from room to room.

“Who the devil can be walking around at one o’clock in the morning in the house where Baron d’Hautrec was killed?” Herlock asked himself, his interest greatly aroused.

There was only one way to find out, and that was to slip inside himself. He had no hesitation in doing so. But at that moment, when, in order to reach the flight of stairs, he passed through the strip of light thrown by the gas lamp, the man must have noticed him, for the faint light suddenly went out and Herlock could no longer see it.

He leant gently on the door at the top of the stairs. It was also half open. As he could not hear any sound, he ventured into the darkness, found the knob of the banister and went up to the next floor. There was still the same silence, the same darkness.

When he reached the landing he entered a room and went towards the window, which was made a little bright by the faint light from the night outside. Then he could see a man outside, who had no doubt descended via another staircase and gone out by another door, and was slipping away off to the right, along by the shrubs which border the wall separating the two gardens.

“Damn!” exclaimed Sholmes. “He’s going to get away!”

He raced across the floor and dashed down the stairs to cut off his retreat completely. But he could not see anyone, and he needed a few seconds to make out in the jumble of shrubs a darker mass which was not completely

still.

The Englishman thought the matter over. Why had the individual not tried to flee while he could have done so easily? Was he staying there so that he, in his turn, could observe the intruder who had disturbed him in his mysterious activity?

“In any case,” he thought, “it isn’t Lupin. Lupin would have been cleverer. It’s one of his gang.”

A long period of several minutes went by. Herlock did not move, but kept his eyes fixed on his opponent, who was also watching him. But as this opponent was not moving any more, and the Englishman was not the man to mope around doing nothing, he checked if the cylinder of his gun was working, removed his dagger from its sheath, and marched straight up to his enemy with that cool boldness and contempt for danger which makes him so formidable.

There was a sharp noise: the individual was arming his revolver. Herlock threw himself suddenly into the clump of shrubs. The other man did not have the time to respond, for the Englishman was already on top of him. There was a violent and desperate struggle, during which Herlock sensed that the man was trying to pull out his knife. But Sholmes, who was fired by the idea of his imminent victory and by the furious desire from the first moment to get hold of this accomplice of Arsène Lupin, felt within him some irresistible force. He turned his opponent over and pressed his whole weight on him, and immobilized him by planting the fingers of one hand onto the poor man’s throat like the points of a bird’s talons, and with his free hand he sought for his electric torch, pressed the button and pointed the light at the face of his prisoner.

“Wilson!” he yelled, horrified.

“Herlock Sholmes!” mumbled a choked and hollow voice.

They stayed for a long time next to each other without exchanging a word, both of them shattered, their minds a blank. A car’s horn rent the air. A slight breeze ruffled the leaves. And Sholmes did not move, his fingers still grasping the neck of Wilson, who let out a groan that was becoming weaker and weaker.

And suddenly Herlock, overcome with anger, let go of his friend, but only to grab hold of him by the shoulders and shake him frantically.

“What are you doing here? Tell me... What?... Did I tell you to stick yourself in these clumps of shrubs and spy on me?”

“Spy on you?” moaned Wilson. “But I didn’t know it was you.”

“So, what are you up to? What are you doing? You’re supposed to have gone to bed.”

“I went to bed.”

“You should have gone to sleep!”

“I did go to sleep.”

“You shouldn’t have woken up again!”

“Your letter...”

“My letter?...”

“Yes, the one that a messenger brought to me on your behalf at the hotel.”

“On my behalf? Are you mad?”

“I swear to you.”

“Where is this letter?”

His friend handed to him a sheet of paper. By the light of his torch he read in astonishment:

Wilson, get out of bed and dash off to Avenue Henri-Martin. The house is empty. Go in, inspect it, draw up a precise plan of it and go back to bed again. – Herlock Sholmes.

“I was in the middle of measuring the rooms,” said Wilson, “when I saw a shadow in the garden. Only one thought occurred to me—”

“And that was to take advantage of the darkness... The idea was excellent... Only, you see,” said Sholmes as he helped his companion to get up again and led him away, “next time, Wilson, when you receive a letter from me, make sure first that someone hasn’t been imitating my writing.”

“Good Heavens,” said Wilson, starting to glimpse the truth, “so the letter wasn’t from you?”

“Alas, no.”

“From whom then?”

“From Arsène Lupin.”

“But what motive could he have had to write it?”

“Ah, now that I do not know, and that’s just what worries me. Why the

devil has he taken the trouble to disturb you? If it was something to do with me, I would understand it, but it only concerns you. And I wonder what interest...”

“I can’t wait to get back to the hotel.”

“Neither can I, Wilson.”

They arrived at the gate. Wilson, who was in front, grasped one of the bars and pulled.

“I say,” he said, “did you close it?”

“Not at all, I left the wing completely open.”

“But...”

Herlock also pulled at it, and hurriedly grasped the lock. A curse escaped him.

“God blast it!... It’s closed! Locked with a key!”

He shook the gate with all his strength, and then, realizing that his efforts were in vain, he dropped his arms and, disheartened, he said in a clipped voice:

“Now I understand it all. It’s him! He foresaw that I would get off at Creil, and he set a nice little trap for me here in case I should come and start my investigation the same evening. What is more, he was kind enough to send me a companion in my captivity. All of this to make me waste a day, and also, no doubt, to prove to me that it would be better for me to mind my own business...”

“That means we are his prisoners.”

“You’ve said it. Herlock Sholmes and Wilson are Arsène Lupin’s prisoners. This adventure is taking a remarkable turn... But no, no, it is not acceptable...”

A hand clasped his shoulder. It was Wilson’s.

“Up there... Look up there... a light...”

Indeed, in one of the windows of the first floor there was a light.

They both dashed off at a run, each taking a different staircase, and met together at the same time at the entrance to the room with a light on. In the middle of the room there was burning the stump of a candle. Beside it was a basket, and from this basket there emerged the neck of a bottle, some chicken thighs and half a loaf of bread.

Sholmes burst out laughing.

“Wonderful, we’re invited to supper. It’s an enchanted world. A real fairy-tale world! Come on, Wilson, don’t look so gloomy. It’s all very amusing.”

“You really think it’s very amusing?” moaned Wilson, gloomily.

“Yes, I’m sure,” exclaimed Sholmes, with a cheerfulness which was a little too loud to be natural, “that is to say that I have never seen anything so amusing. It’s really funny... What a master of irony this Arsène Lupin is! He cheats you, but with what grace! I would not give up my seat at this feast for all the gold in the world... Wilson, my old friend, you worry me. Could I be mistaken, and could it be that you do not possess that nobility of character which helps a man to endure misfortune? At this time you could have had my dagger in your throat, or I could have had yours in mine... because that’s what you were trying to do, my poor old friend.”

He managed, by dint of humour and sarcastic remarks, to revive poor Wilson, and to make him swallow a chicken thigh and a glass of wine. But when the candle had gone out, and they had to lie down to sleep on the parquet floor, and put up with the wall as a pillow, the difficult and ridiculous aspect of their situation became apparent to them. And they slept miserably.

In the morning Wilson woke up stiff and chilled to the bone. A faint noise attracted his attention: Herlock Sholmes was on his knees, bent in half, and studying some grains of dust with a magnifying glass. He noticed some white chalk marks, almost rubbed out, which were in the shape of numbers, and he was writing these numbers in his notebook.

Accompanied by Wilson, who took a particular interest in what he was doing, he studied each room, and in two others he could confirm the presence of the same chalk marks. And he made a note also of two circles on the oak panels, an arrow on some mouldings and four numbers on four steps of the staircase.

After an hour Wilson said to him:

“The numbers are accurate, are they?”

“I don’t know if they’re accurate,” replied Herlock, whom these discoveries had put in a good mood, “but in any case they mean something.”

“One thing is quite clear,” said Wilson, “they represent the number of blocks in the parquet floor.”

“Ah!”

“Yes. As for the circles, they indicate that the panels are false, as you can confirm for yourself, and the arrow points in the direction of the ascent of the dumb waiter.”

Herlock Sholmes looked at him, full of wonder.

“So that’s what it is! But, my friend, how do you know all that? Your perceptiveness puts me almost to shame.”

“Oh, it’s quite simple,” said Wilson, swollen with joy, “it was me who drew those marks yesterday evening, following your instructions... or rather following those of Lupin, as the letter that you addressed to me was from him.”

Perhaps at that moment Wilson was in more terrible danger than during the fight in the shrubbery with Sholmes. The latter had a violent desire to strangle him. Controlling himself, he gave a hint of a grimace trying to pass itself off as smile and said:

“Perfect, perfect, what an excellent job, and it helps us to make great progress. And did you employ your admirable powers of analysis and observation to other matters? I would greatly benefit from any results you obtained.”

“Good Heavens no. That’s as far as I got.”

“What a pity! And it was such a promising start. But since that’s the way it is, there’s nothing more for us to do than to leave.”

“Leave! But how?”

“By the usual way in which honest people leave: through the door.

“But it’s closed.”

“Then someone must open it.”

“Who?”

“Please call those two policemen wandering about on the avenue.”

“But...”

“But what?”

“It’s extremely humiliating... What will they say when they realize that you, Herlock Sholmes, and I, Wilson, have been the prisoners of Arsène Lupin?”

“What do you think, my friend? They’ll split their sides laughing,” replied Herlock, in a curt tone, and with a tense expression on his face. “But we can’t just take up residence in this house.”

“And you’re not going to try anything?”

“Nothing.”

“But the man who brought us the basket of provisions did not cross the garden, either when he arrived or when he left. So there must be another exit. Let’s look for it, and we won’t have to resort to the police officers.”

“Powerfully argued. Only you forget that all the police in Paris have been looking for this exit for six months and that I myself searched the house from top to bottom, while you were asleep. Ah, Wilson, my good fellow, Arsène Lupin is a prey with which we are not familiar. He leaves no trace behind him, that one.”

At eleven o’clock, Herlock Sholmes and Wilson were set free, and taken to the nearest police station, where the superintendent, after having interrogated them severely, let them go with an affectation of respect that was completely infuriating.

“I’m very sorry, gentlemen, about what happened to you. You will have a poor opinion of French hospitality. God, what a night you had to spend. Oh, this Lupin really shows a lack of respect.”

A car took them to the Élysée Palace. In the office Wilson asked for the key to his room. After checking a few things, the employee replied, very surprised:

“But, sir, you checked out of that room.”

“I did? But how?”

“By your letter this morning, which your friend sent us.”

“What friend?”

“The gentleman who sent us your letter... Look, your business card is still fixed to it. Here they are.”

Wilson took them. It was indeed one of his business cards, and on the letter was indeed his handwriting.

“Good Lord,” he murmured, “this is another nasty trick.”

“And the luggage?”

“But your friend took it.”

“Oh!... And you gave it to him?”

“Certainly, as your card authorized us to.”

“Indeed... indeed...”

They both went off slowly and in silence, with no particular goal in mind, along the Champs-Élysées. A nice autumn sun lit up the avenue.

The air was soft and gentle.

At the roundabout, Herlock Sholmes lit his pipe and continued to walk. Wilson exclaimed:

“I don’t understand you, Sholmes, you are so calm! They make fun of you and play with you like a cat plays with a mouse... And you don’t breathe a word.”

Sholmes stopped and said to him:

“Wilson, I am thinking about your business card.”

“Well?”

“Well, here we have a man who, in anticipation of a possible fight with us, has acquired for himself some specimens of your handwriting and mine, and who keeps one of your business cards at hand in his wallet. Have you considered what precautions that implies, what a perceptive will, what method and organization?”

“Which means?”

“Which means, Wilson, that in order to fight an enemy armed in such a formidable way, and so marvellously prepared – and to beat him – one has to be... one has to be me. And what is more, as you see, Wilson,” he added, laughing, “one doesn’t succeed the first time.”

At six o’clock, *L’Écho de France*, in its evening edition, published this brief article:

This morning, M. Thénard, superintendent of police in the 16th Arrondissement, released the gentlemen named Herlock Sholmes and Wilson, who had been locked up, by courtesy of Arsène Lupin, in the house of the late Baron d’Hautrec, where they spent an excellent night.

As, in addition to this, they had been relieved of their suitcases, they have lodged a complaint against Arsène Lupin.

Arsène Lupin, who on this occasion is content to inflict a little lesson on them, beseeches them not to compel him to adopt more serious measures.

“Bah!” said Herlock Sholmes, crumpling the newspaper. “Such childish pranks! That’s the only reproach I make against Lupin... too much childishness... He’s too concerned to please the gallery... There’s something of the street urchin about the man!”

“And so, Herlock, still the same calmness?”

“Always the same calmness,” replied Sholmes in a tone which revealed that the most dreadful anger was brewing. “Why should I be annoyed?... *when I’m going to have the last word!*”

1 He only saw me once: Arsène Lupin, Gentleman Burglar (Chapter 9, ‘Herlock Sholmes Arrived Too Late’). (AUTHOR’S NOTE)



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A Few Gleams in the Darkness

HOWEVER WELL TEMPERED the character of a man may be – and Sholmes is one of those beings over which bad fortune scarcely has any hold – there are however certain circumstances in which the most intrepid person feels the need to summon up his strength before chancing his luck in battle.

“I’m taking a little break today,” he said.

“And me?”

“You, Wilson, are going to buy some clothes and linen to restock our wardrobe. During that time I shall take a rest.”

“Take a rest, Sholmes. I’ll keep watch.”

Wilson spoke these words with all the self-importance of a sentry placed in an outpost where he is consequently exposed to the worst dangers. He thrust out his chest. His muscles tensed. With a keen eye he scanned the space in the little hotel room where they had taken up residence.

“Yes, keep watch, Wilson. I shall take advantage of the time to prepare a plan of campaign better suited to the opponent whom we have to combat. You see, we were mistaken about Lupin. We must take things from the beginning again.”

“Even from before then, if possible. But do we have time?”

“Nine days, old friend! That’s five too many.”

All afternoon the Englishman spent smoking and sleeping. It was not till the following day that he started operations.

“Wilson, I’m ready. Now let’s get going.”

“Let’s get going,” exclaimed Wilson, full of martial fervour. “I confess that for my part I’m itching to get off.”

Sholmes conducted three long meetings – first with Maître Detinan, whose apartment he studied in the minutest detail; then with Suzanne Gerbois, whom he summoned by telegram and questioned about the Blonde Woman; and finally with Sister Auguste, who had withdrawn into the convent of the Visitandines since the murder of Baron d’Hautrec.

At each visit, Wilson waited outside, and each time he asked:

“Happy?”

“Very happy.”

“I was certain we were on the right track. Let’s go!”

And they did go around a lot. They visited the two buildings which flank the house on Avenue Henri-Martin, and then they went to the Rue Clapeyron. And while he was examining the façade of number 25, Sholmes continued to explain:

“It is clear that there are secret passages between all these houses... but what I don’t understand...”

Deep down inside and for the first time, Wilson doubted his brilliant collaborator’s omniscience. Why did he talk so much and do so little?

“Why?” exclaimed Sholmes, in reply to the intimate reflections of Wilson. “Because with this devil Lupin we are working in unknown territory, without any clear direction, and instead of extracting the truth from precise facts we have to drag it out of our own minds to check if it fits the events.”

“What about the secret passages though?”

“And then what? Even if I knew where they were, if I knew the one which allowed Lupin to gain entry to the lawyer’s apartment, or the one which the Blonde Woman went through after the murder of Baron d’Hautrec, would I be that much further forward? Would it provide me with weapons with which to attack him?”

“Let’s attack anyway,” exclaimed Wilson.

He had barely uttered these words when he moved back, with a cry. Something had just fallen at their feet, a sack half-full of sand, which could have seriously injured them.

Sholmes raised his head: above them some labourers were working on scaffolding hanging from the balcony on the fifth floor.

“Well, we’re lucky, a foot closer and we would have had the sack of one of those clumsy oafs on our skulls. One could really almost think...”

He interrupted himself and leapt off towards the house, ascended the five floors, rang the bell, burst into the apartment, to the great terror of the *valet de chambre*, and went out onto the balcony. There was no one there.

“Where are the labourers who were here?” he asked the *valet de chambre*.

“They’ve just gone.”

“Which way?”

“Down the backstairs.”

Sholmes leant out. He saw two men leaving the house, pushing their bicycles as they went. They got onto the saddles and disappeared.

“Have they been working on this scaffolding for long?”

“Those men? Only since this morning. They were new workers.”

Sholmes rejoined Wilson.

They went back in a melancholy mood, and this second day ended in gloomy silence.

The next day their programme was the same. They sat on the same bench in the Avenue Henri-Martin and, to the great despair of Wilson, they sat there facing the three buildings interminably.

“What do you hope will happen, Sholmes? That Lupin will come out of one of these houses?”

“No.”

“That the Blonde Woman will appear?”

“No.”

“Well, what?”

“Well, I hope that some small fact will materialize, some ordinary little fact, which will serve me as a point of departure.”

“And it hasn’t materialized?”

“In this case something has materialized in me, a spark which will bring things to a head.”

One incident disrupted the monotony of that morning, but in a way which was rather disagreeable.

A gentleman’s horse, which was following the bridle path situated between the avenue’s dual carriageway, shied and hit the bench where they were sitting, so that its hindquarters brushed against Sholmes’s shoulder.

“Hey! Hey!” he chuckled. “A little closer and you would have smashed my shoulder.”

The gentleman was struggling with his horse. The Englishman drew out his revolver and aimed. But Wilson swiftly seized his arm.

“Are you mad, Herlock! Look... what are you doing? You’re going to kill that gentleman?”

“Let go, Wilson... let go.”

They struggled with each other, and while that was happening, the gentleman brought his mount under control and set off away from them.

“Now you can shoot at him,” exclaimed Wilson triumphantly, when the horse-rider was some distance away.

“You absolute imbecile, don’t you realize that he was an accomplice of Arsène Lupin?”

Sholmes was shaking with anger. Wilson was crestfallen and mumbled:

“What’s that you say? That gentleman?...”

“...is an accomplice of Lupin, like the two labourers who threw the sack on our heads.”

“Is it credible?”

“Credible or not, we had the means there of getting some proof.”

“By killing that gentleman?”

“By simply shooting down his horse. But for you I would have got one of Lupin’s accomplices. Now do you understand how stupid you were?”

It was a gloomy afternoon. They did not address a single word to each other. At five o’clock, while they were pacing up and down the Rue Clapeyron, taking care to keep their distance from the houses, three young labourers who were singing with their arms around each other bumped into them and were going to continue on their way without separating. Sholmes, who was in a bad mood, stood in their way. They jostled each other for a short time. Sholmes took up the pose of a boxer, and shot a blow with his fist into the chest of one of them, and a blow into the face of another. He beat up two of the three young men who, unable to keep it up any longer, went off as their companion had already done.

“Ah!” he exclaimed. “That did me good!... My nerves were tense... That was an excellent bit of work.”

But noticing Wilson against the wall, he said to him:

“What is it? What’s the matter, old friend. You’re quite pale.”

The old friend showed him his arm, which was hanging down inert, and he mumbled:

“I don’t know what I... there’s some pain in my arm.”

“Some pain in the arm? Is it serious?”

“Yes... yes... it’s the right arm...”

In spite of all his efforts he could not manage to move it. Herlock felt it, softly at first, then more roughly, “to determine,” he said, “the precise degree of pain.” The precise degree of pain was so high that he went into a nearby chemist’s, where Wilson came over faint.

The chemist and his assistants fussed around him. They established that the arm was broken, and it was a question of finding a surgeon straight away, undergoing an operation and getting him to a clinic. In the meantime, they undressed the patient who, shaking with pain, started to yell.

“Good... good... perfect,” said Sholmes, who had been given the job of holding the arm, “just a little patience, old friend... in five or six weeks, there’ll be no more sign of it... but I’ll see that they pay for it, those scoundrels! Do you hear... him above all... for it’s that miserable Lupin again who’s behind it... Oh, I swear that if ever...”

He interrupted himself suddenly, let go of the arm, which caused Wilson to have such a burst of pain that the poor man fainted again and, striking himself on the forehead, he said:

“Wilson, I’ve got an idea... Can it be by chance...”

He did not move, but gazed fixedly, and muttered short, broken phrases.

“Yes, that’s it... that would explain it all... We’ve been seeking afar what is actually right next to us... My God, I knew I only had to think about it... Oh, Wilson, my good friend, I think you’ll be pleased!”

And leaving his old friend in the lurch, he leapt out into the street and went to number 25. Above and to the right of the door there was an inscription on one of the stones: *Destange, architect, 1875*.

At number 23 there was the same inscription.

So far, it was quite natural. But over on Avenue Henri-Martin, what would he read there?

A carriage passed.

“Driver, Avenue Henri-Martin, number 134, at the double.”

Standing up in the carriage he urged on the horse and offered tips to the driver. ‘Faster!... Much faster!’

He became very anxious at the bend in the Rue de la Pompe. Had he caught a glimpse of the truth?

On one of the stones of the house the following words were engraved: *Destange, architect, 1874*.

On the neighbouring houses, there was the same inscription: *Destange, architect, 1874*.

The after-effect of these feelings were such that he collapsed on the

bottom of the carriage for a few minutes, trembling with delight. Finally, there was a faint light flickering in the midst of the darkness! In the great dark forest where a thousand paths crossed each other, he had found the first sign of a track followed by the enemy.

In a post office he asked to be connected by telephone with the Château of Crozon. The countess herself answered.

“Hello!... Is that you, Madame?”

“Mr Sholmes, is it? Is everything all right?”

“Perfectly all right, but please tell me, as quickly as possible... Hello?... Just briefly please...”

“I’m listening.”

“In what period was the Château of Crozon built?”

“It burned down thirty years ago, and was reconstructed.”

“By whom? And in what year?”

“The inscription over the steps to the front door reads: *Lucien Destange, architect, 1877.*”

“Thank you, Madame, and goodbye.”

He went off murmuring:

“Destange... Lucien Destange... I’m not unfamiliar with this name.”

Having noticed a reading room nearby, he went to consult a dictionary of modern biography and copied out the note devoted to “Lucien Destanges, born in 1840, Grand Prix of Rome,¹ officer of the Légion d’Honneur, author of highly valued works on architecture... etc.”

Then he went back to the chemist’s and from there to the hospital where Wilson had been taken. Lying on his bed and tortured with pain, his arm trapped in a cradling splint and shivering with fever, his old friend was delirious.

“Victory! Victory!” exclaimed Sholmes. “I’ve got one end of the thread.”

“What thread?”

“The one that will lead us to our goal! I shall be walking on solid ground, on which there will be footprints, clues...”

“Some cigarette ash?” asked Wilson, who was revived by the interesting situation.

“And many other things! Just think, Wilson, I have worked out the mysterious link which joined the various adventures of the Blonde Woman

together. Why were these three abodes, in which these three adventures were conducted, chosen by Lupin?”

“Yes, why?”

“Because, Wilson, these three abodes were built by the same architect. It was easy to work out, wouldn’t you say? Certainly... But nobody thought of it.”

“Nobody except you.”

“Except me, who now knows that the same architect, by combining three similar plans, has made it possible to accomplish three deeds which are in appearance miraculous, but in reality are simple and easy.”

“What good luck!”

“And it was high time, my old friend. I was beginning to lose patience. We are already on the fourth day.”

“Out of ten.”

“Oh! From now on...”

He could not keep still, and was exuberant and happy, which was not usual with him.

“But when I think that earlier, in the street, those rogues could have broken my arm as well as yours. What do you think, Wilson?”

Wilson contented himself with just shuddering at this horrible idea.

And Sholmes continued:

“Let this be a lesson to us! You see, Wilson, our big mistake has been to fight Lupin openly, and present ourselves obligingly to his blows. But it’s not as bad as all that, since he only managed to get at you—”

“And I got off with a broken arm,” moaned Wilson.

“—when it could have been both of us. But enough of all this boasting. I was beaten in broad daylight while we were being watched. In the shadows and free to move as I want, I have the advantage, whatever my enemy’s strengths.”

“Ganimard could help you.”

“Never! The day when I am able to say where Arsène Lupin is, this is where he’s hiding and here’s how to get hold of him, then I’ll pack Ganimard off to one of the two addresses he gave me: his home on Rue Pergolèse or the Swiss tavern on the Place du Châtelet. Until then, I work alone.”

He approached the bed, put his hand on Wilson’s shoulder – on the

injured shoulder of course – and said to him with great affection:

“Take care, my old friend. Your role from now on consists in keeping two or three of Arsène Lupin’s men occupied. They will wait vainly for me to come and get news of you, in order to get on my track again. It’s a role that requires trust.”

“A role that requires trust, and I thank you for it,” replied Wilson, deeply grateful. “I shall make every effort to fulfill it conscientiously. But, the way I see it, you won’t be coming back again?”

“For what reason?” Sholmes asked coldly.

“Indeed... indeed... I’ll be leaving as soon as possible. Then there’s one more thing you can do for me, Herlock: could you give me something to drink?”

“To drink?”

“Yes. I’m dying of thirst, and with this fever—”

“But of course! Immediately...”

He fiddled with two or three bottles, caught sight of a packet of tobacco, lit his pipe and suddenly, as if he had not even heard his friend’s request, he went off, with his old friend giving him a begging look for an inaccessible glass of water.

“M. Destange!”

The servant looked the individual up and down to whom he had just opened the door of the mansion – the magnificent mansion which forms the corner of the Place Malesherbes and the Rue Montchanin. And at the sight of this little man, grey-haired, unshaven, and whose long black frock coat, of doubtful cleanliness, matched the odd qualities of a body rendered strangely ugly by nature, he replied with suitable disdain:

“M. Destange is in, or he is not in. That depends. Does the gentleman have a visiting card?”

The gentleman did not have a card, but he had a letter of introduction, and the servant was obliged to take this letter to M. Destange. M. Destange ordered him to bring the new arrival into his presence.

He was introduced into an immense round room, which occupied one of the wings of the mansion and the walls of which were covered with books. The architect said to him:

“You are M. Stickmann?”

“Yes, sir.”

“My secretary has informed me that he is ill and sends you to continue the general catalogue of books that he started under my direction, more specifically the catalogue of German books. Are you familiar with this sort of work?”

“Yes, I’ve had much experience of it,” replied M. Stickmann with a strong Teutonic accent.

This being the case the agreement was quickly concluded. And M. Destange, without further delay, got down to work with his new secretary.

Herlock Sholmes had got himself inside the house.

In order to avoid detection by Lupin and to get into the mansion where Lucien Destange lived with his daughter Clotilde, the illustrious detective had had to make a leap in the dark, come up with a series of stratagems, gain, under all kinds of names, the favours of a host of people and, in short, lead the most complicated existence for forty-eight hours.

He had found out the following information: M. Destange, in poor health and desirous of a peaceful existence, had retired from work and was living among the collections of books on architecture that he had put together. No other pleasure interested him except looking at and handling dusty old volumes.

As for his daughter Clotilde, she was regarded as eccentric. Shut away from the world, like her father, but in another part of the mansion, she never went out.

“All that,” he said to himself, as he inscribed in a register the titles which M. Destange dictated to him, “all that is not yet decisive, but what a step forward! It is impossible for me not to discover the solution to one of these fascinating problems: is M. Destange associated with Arsène Lupin? Does he continue to see him? Do documents relating to the construction of the three buildings exist? And won’t such documents provide me with the addresses of other buildings that have been similarly tampered with, and which Lupin has kept for himself and his gang?”

M. Destange as an accomplice of Arsène Lupin! This venerable man, an officer of the Légion d’Honneur, together with a burglar! It was an idea that was difficult to accept. Besides, if such complicity is admitted, how could M. Destange have foreseen, thirty years beforehand, the escapes planned by Arsène Lupin, who would still have been a babe in arms at the

time.

It doesn't matter! The Englishman persevered. With his marvellous flair, and that instinct which is uniquely his, he sensed a mystery lurking around somewhere. It could be discerned by little things that he could not specify, but which impressed themselves on him since his arrival in the mansion.

On the morning of the second day he had not yet made any interesting discovery. At two o'clock he had his first sight of Clotilde Destange, who came to find a book in the library. She was a woman of about thirty, brunette, who moved slowly and silently, and whose face retained that indifferent expression of those people who keep themselves very much to themselves. She exchanged a few words with M. Destange, and then left without even looking at Sholmes.

The afternoon dragged on monotonously. At five o'clock, M. Destange announced that he was going out. Sholmes was left alone in the circular gallery which was fixed halfway up inside the rotunda. The daylight was fading. He too was about to leave, when a cracking sound was heard, and at the same time he had the feeling that there was someone in the room. The minutes dragged on, one after the other. Suddenly he shuddered: a shadow emerged from the semi-darkness, very close to him, on the balcony. Was it credible? For how long had this invisible person been keeping him company? And where had he come from?

The man went down the steps and moved towards a large oak cabinet. Concealed behind the drapes which hung from the handrail of the gallery and down on his knees, Sholmes was watching, and saw the man rummaging through the papers with which the cabinet was cluttered. What was he looking for?

And then suddenly the door opened and Mlle Destange entered swiftly, saying to someone who was following her:

"So you're really not going out, Father? In that case I'll put the lights on... Just a second... Don't move..."

The man pushed back the two wings of the cabinet door and hid himself in the frame of a large window, pulling the curtains across in front of him. How could Mlle Destange not see him? How could she not hear him? Calmly she switched on the lights and made way for her father. They sat down next to each other. She picked up a volume that she had brought

with her and started to read.

“So your secretary is no longer here?” she said after a few moments.

“No... as you can see.”

“Are you still satisfied with him?” she continued, as if she did not know about the illness of the real secretary and his replacement by Stickmann.

“Still... still...”

M. Destange’s head rolled from right to left. He was falling asleep. A few moments went by. The young woman went on reading. But one of the curtains on the window was pulled aside, and the man slid along the wall towards the door, a movement which caused him to pass behind M. Destange, but facing Clotilde, and in such a way that Sholmes could see him clearly. It was Arsène Lupin.

The Englishman trembled with pleasure. His calculations had been correct, he had got to the very heart of the mysterious affair, and Lupin was at the anticipated place.

Clotilde did not move however, although it was impossible that a single movement of this man had escaped her. Lupin was almost in reach of the door, and he was already stretching out his arm towards the handle, when an object fell from a table, brushed against by his clothes. M. Destange woke up with a start. Arsène Lupin was already standing in front of him, with his hat in his hand, and smiling.

“Maxime Bermond,” exclaimed M. Destange joyfully, “my dear Maxime!... What favourable wind has brought you here?”

“The wish to see you, as well as Mlle Destange.”

“So you’ve just come back from your trip?”

“Yesterday.”

“You’ll stay and have dinner with us?”

“No, I’m dining at a restaurant with my friends.”

“So, tomorrow then? Clotilde, you must insist that he come tomorrow. Oh, Maxime, my good chap... I’ve been thinking about you just these past few days.”

“Really?”

“Yes. I was putting some papers in order from the old days, in this cabinet, and I found our last account.”

“What account?”

“The one for the Avenue Henri-Martin.”

“What! You keep such paperwork? What for?”

All three of them sat down in a small room which was joined to the rotunda by a large bay.

“Is it really Lupin?” wondered Sholmes, suddenly overcome with doubt.

Yes, to all appearances it was him, but at the same time he was another man, who resembled Arsène Lupin in certain respects, but who nevertheless retained his own distinct individuality, his personal traits, his facial expression, his own hair colour...

Dressed in a suit, wearing a white tie and a soft shirt hugging his chest, he talked in a joyful way, telling some stories which M. Destange laughed at heartily and brought a smile to Clotilde’s lips. And each of these smiles seemed to be a reward which Arsène Lupin was seeking and which he was delighted to have obtained. It intensified his own wit and cheerful mood, and imperceptibly, at the sound of this happy, clear voice, Clotilde’s face became animated and lost that expression of coldness which made it not very likeable.

“They’re in love with each other,” thought Sholmes, “but what the devil can Clotilde, Destange and Maxim Bermond have in common? Does she know that Maxime is none other than Arsène Lupin?”

Until seven o’clock he listened anxiously, learning as much as he could from their slightest word. Then, with precautions, he climbed down and went across the side of the room where he did not risk being seen from the salon.

Once outside, Sholmes made sure that there was neither car nor cab parked nearby, and went off limping slightly along the Boulevard Malesherbes. But in a road adjacent to it, he put on the overcoat which he was carrying on his arm, bent his hat back out of its shape, stood up straight and, having thus transformed himself, he returned to the square, where he waited, with eyes fixed on the Destange mansion.

Arsène Lupin came out almost immediately and, via Rue de Constantinople and Rue de Londres, made his way towards the centre of Paris. Herlock was walking a hundred paces behind him.

These were really delicious moments for the Englishman. He sniffed the air avidly, like a good dog scenting a completely fresh track. It really gave him infinite delight to follow his adversary. And it was no longer him

under surveillance, but Arsène Lupin, the invisible Arsène Lupin. He held him, as it were, just within his sights, as though attached by strings which were impossible to break. And it gave him great pleasure to consider that among the passers-by there was this prey which belonged to him.

But it was not long before he was struck by a strange phenomenon: in the middle of the space which separated him from Arsène Lupin some other persons were moving forward in the same direction, notably two large strapping men in round hats on the left-hand pavement, and two others on the right-hand pavement in caps and with cigarettes in their lips.

It was perhaps only a chance event. But Sholmes was very surprised when, after Lupin went into a tobacco kiosk, the four men stopped – and was even more surprised when they set off again at the same time as he did, but independently, each of them following the Chaussée d’Antin on his own.

“Curse it!” thought Sholmes. “He’s got away!”

The idea that others were on the track of Arsène Lupin, that others were robbing him, not of the glory – he was not worried about that so much – but the enormous pleasure, the burning desire to crush, by himself, the most formidable enemy that he had ever encountered, this was the thought which infuriated him. But he could not possibly be wrong: the men had that air of detachment, a too natural air of men who, adjusting their pace to the pace of another person, try not to attract attention.

“Does Ganimard know much more about it than he lets on?” murmured Sholmes. “Is he playing with me?”

He wanted to accost one of the four individuals, to consult with him. But as they got near to the boulevard, the crowd became denser, and he was afraid of losing Lupin and quickened his pace. He came to the corner of the Rue du Helder just as Lupin was climbing up the steps of the Hungarian restaurant. The door was open in such a way as to enable Sholmes, sitting on a bench on the other side of the boulevard, to see him sit down at a luxuriously set table decorated with flowers, where three gentlemen in suits and two very elegant women were already sitting. They welcomed him with great displays of affection.

Herlock looked around for the four individuals and caught sight of them, spread around among the groups who were listening to the gypsy orchestra in a nearby café. The strange thing was that they did not seem to

be concerned about Arsène Lupin, but more about the people he was with.

Suddenly one of the men drew a cigarette out of his pocket and approached a gentleman in a frock coat and a high hat. The gentleman held out his cigar, and Sholmes had the impression that they were having a conversation, and for a much longer time than was required for the act of lighting a cigarette. Finally the gentleman went up the steps and glanced around the dining room of the restaurant. Catching sight of Lupin he went towards him, talked with him for a few moments, and then chose a table nearby. Sholmes noted that it was none other than the horse-rider from the Avenue Henri-Martin.

Then he understood. Not only wasn't Arsène Lupin being tailed, but these men belonged to his gang, ensuring his own security! They were his bodyguards, his satellites, his attentive escort. Wherever the master was in danger, the accomplices were there, ready to ward it off, ready to defend him. The four individuals were his accomplices! And the man in the frock coat was also his accomplice!

A shudder ran through the Englishman. Would he ever be able to get hold of this inaccessible being? What limitless power such an organization represented, directed by such a boss!

He tore a page from his notebook, and wrote a few lines in pencil, which he then put in an envelope, and he spoke to a lad of fifteen years or so, who had been lying on the bench:

"Here, boy, get a cab and take this letter to the woman at the cashier's desk of the Swiss tavern, Place du Châtelet. Quickly..."

He gave him a five-franc coin and the lad disappeared.

Half an hour went by. The crowd had grown bigger, and Sholmes could only make out Lupin's henchmen from time to time. But then someone brushed against him and a voice said in his ear:

"So, what's happening Mr Sholmes?"

"Oh, it's you, Monsieur Ganimard."

"Yes, I got your note at the tavern. What's happening?"

"He's there."

"What's that you say?"

"Over there, at the back of the restaurant. Lean to the right... Can you see him?"

"No."

“He’s pouring out some champagne for the woman next to him.”

“But that’s not him.”

“It’s him.”

“But I tell you... And yet... indeed, it could be him... the scoundrel, *what a resemblance he has!*...” murmured Ganimard naively. “And the others, are they his accomplices?”

“No, the woman next to him is Lady Cliveden, the other is the Duchess of Cleath, and opposite them is the Spanish ambassador to London.”

Ganimard stepped forward, but Herlock held him back.

“Don’t be so rash! You are on your own.”

“But so is he.”

“No, he has some men on the boulevard who are mounting guard... not to mention that man inside the restaurant...”

“But if I collared Arsène Lupin and shouted out his name, I’d have the whole room on my side, and all the waiters.”

“I would prefer you to have some officers with you.”

“It’s for just such a move that Arsène Lupin’s friends are keeping a lookout... No, look. Mr Sholmes, we haven’t any choice.”

He was right, and Sholmes realized it. It was better to welcome the chance and take advantage of this exceptional opportunity. He just advised Ganimard:

“Try to ensure that you are recognized as late as possible...”

And he slipped behind a newspaper kiosk, without losing sight of Arsène Lupin, who over there was leaning towards the woman next to him and smiling.

The inspector crossed the road, with his hands in his pockets, like a man who is going to walk straight ahead. But scarcely had he got to the opposite pavement when he swiftly turned aside and with one bound climbed up the flight of steps.

There was a piercing whistle... Ganimard collided with the maître d’hôtel, who had suddenly placed himself across the doorway and pushed him back indignantly, as he would have done to an intruder whose questionable attire would have brought the luxurious nature of the restaurant into disrepute. Ganimard wavered. At the same moment the man in the frock coat came out. He took the inspector’s side, and both he and the maître d’hôtel argued furiously, while hanging on to Ganimard,

the one holding him back, the other pushing him forward, in such a way that, in spite of all his efforts, the poor fellow was pushed down to the bottom of the steps.

A crowd immediately gathered. Two police officers, attracted by the noise, tried to push their way through the crowd, but some incomprehensible resistance brought them to a standstill, without them being able to free themselves from the shoulders pressing against them and the backs which barred their way.

And suddenly, as if by magic, a way becomes free! The maître d'hôtel, realizing his mistake, apologizes profusely, and the man in the frock coat gives up defending the inspector, the crowd moves away, the officers get through and Ganimard rushes towards the table with the six guests... There are now only five! He looks around him... there is no other exit except the doorway.

"Where is the person who was sitting in this place?" he shouts out to the five astonished guests. "Yes, there were six of you... Where's the sixth person?"

"M. Destro?"

"No, Arsène Lupin!"

A waiter comes up to him:

"The gentleman in question has just gone up to the mezzanine."

Ganimard rushed off. The mezzanine consists of private rooms and has its own special exit onto the boulevard!

"Go and find him at once," moaned Ganimard. "He's got right away!"

He was not very far away, about two hundred metres at the very most, in the Madeleine-Bastille omnibus, which was rolling along peacefully at the gentle trotting pace of its three horses. It went across the Place de l'Opéra and off along the Boulevard des Capucines. On the platform two strapping young men in bowler hats were talking to each other. On the upper deck, at the top of the stairs, a little old gentleman was dozing: it was Herlock Sholmes. With his head nodding, and rocked by the movement of the vehicle, the Englishman was saying to himself:

"If good old Wilson could see me, he would be proud of his collaborator!... Bah!... It was easy to foretell, when someone whistled, that the game was lost, and that there was nothing better to do than keep

an eye on the surroundings of the restaurant. But there is certainly never a dull moment with this devil of a man!"

At the final stop, Herlock, leaning over, saw Arsène Lupin passing in front of his bodyguards, and he heard him say: "At Place de l'Étoile."

"At l'Étoile – perfect, they've arranged a meeting. I'll be there. Let them go off in their motorized cab, and we'll drive after the two companions."

The two companions went off on foot, and did indeed arrive at l'Étoile, and rang at the door of a narrow house at number 40 Rue Chalgrin. At the bend of this street, which was not very busy, Sholmes was able to hide himself in the shade of a recess. One of the windows on the ground floor opened and a man in a round hat closed the shutters. Above the shutters the fanlight lit up.

After ten minutes, a gentleman came and rang at the same door, and then, immediately afterwards, another person came. Finally a motorized cab stopped nearby, and Sholmes saw two people getting out of it: Arsène Lupin and a woman wrapped in a coat and a heavy veil.

"It's the Blonde Woman, no doubt about it," Sholmes said to himself, as the cab drove away.

He let a few moments go by and then approached the house, climbed up onto the window sill and, standing on tiptoe, he could see into the room via the fanlight.

Leaning on the mantelpiece, Arsène Lupin was talking animatedly. The others stood around him, listening attentively. Among them Sholmes could recognize the man in the frock coat and he also thought he could recognize the maître d'hôtel of the restaurant. As for the Blonde Woman, she was sitting in an armchair with her back turned towards him.

"They're holding a meeting," he thought. "The events of this evening have disturbed them and they feel the need to discuss things. Oh, if only I could catch them all at the same time, with one blow!"

As one of the accomplices had moved, he leapt down to the ground and concealed himself in the shadows. The gentleman in the frock coat and the maître d'hôtel left the house. Immediately the lights went on on the first floor, and someone closed the shutters on the windows. And all was dark both above and below.

"He and she have stayed on the ground floor," Herlock said to himself. "The two accomplices live on the second floor."

He waited for part of the night without moving, fearing that Arsène Lupin might go away if he wasn't there. At four o'clock, noticing two policemen at the end of the road, he went up to them, explained the situation and entrusted to them the surveillance of the house.

Then he went to Ganimard's home on the Rue Pergolèse and woke him up.

"I've got him again."

"Arsène Lupin?"

"Yes."

"If you've got him in the same way you had him a little while ago, then I might as well go back to bed. Anyway, let's go to the police station."

They went to Rue Mesnil, and from there to the home of the superintendent, M. Decointre. And then, accompanied by half a dozen men, they returned to Rue Chalgrin.

"Anything new?" Sholmes asked the two officers on duty.

"Nothing."

Daylight was slowly brightening the sky when, having made his arrangements, the superintendent rang the bell and went to the concierge's lodge. Alarmed by this invasion and trembling all over, the woman replied that there were no tenants on the ground floor.

"What, no tenants?" exclaimed Ganimard.

"No, it's the ones on the first floor. The two Leroux gentlemen. They have furnished the downstairs flat for some relatives from the provinces."

"A man and a woman?"

"Yes."

"Who came with them yesterday evening?"

"Quite possibly... I was asleep... though, I don't think... here is the key... they didn't ask for it."

With this key the superintendent opened the door on the other side of the hallway. The ground-floor flat had only two rooms, and they were empty.

"Impossible!" exclaimed Sholmes. "I saw them, her and him."

The superintendent chuckled:

"No doubt you did, but they're not there now."

"Let's go up to the first floor. They must be there."

"The first floor is inhabited by the two Leroux gentlemen."

"Then we shall question these Leroux gentlemen."

They all went up the stairs and the superintendent rang the bell. When he rang a second time an individual, who was none other than one of the bodyguards, appeared, in his shirtsleeves and in an angry mood.

“What’s going on? What an awful racket... Do you think it’s all right to wake people up...”

But he stopped, confused.

“God forgive me... but am I really not dreaming? It’s M. Decointre!... And you too, Monsieur Ganimard? So how may I help you?”

There was an enormous burst of laughter. Ganimard also burst out laughing, in a fit of hilarity which made him double up and made his face flushed.

“It’s you, Leroux,” he stammered. “Oh, how funny... Leroux, an accomplice of Arsène Lupin... Oh, I’ll die laughing... and the other Leroux, your brother, can I see him?”

“Edmond, where are you? Monsieur Ganimard’s paying us a visit.”

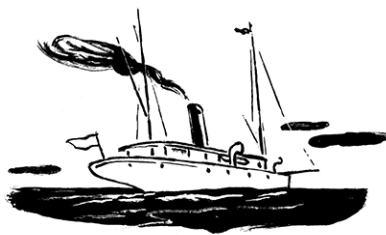
Another person came forward, the sight of whom intensified Ganimard’s good mood.

“Is it possible? We had no idea! Oh my friends, you’ve landed yourselves in a fine mess... Who would ever have believed it? It’s a good job that old Ganimard is on hand, and above all that he has friends to help him... friends who have come from a long way away!”

And turning towards Sholmes, he introduced them:

“Victor Leroux, inspector at the Sûreté, one of the best of the best in the iron brigade... and Edmond Leroux, head clerk in the anthropometric department...”

1 Grand Prix of Rome: A prestigious French scholarship which enabled young painters, sculptors, engravers, architects and musicians to live and study in Rome for up to five years.



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HERLOCK SHOLMES DID NOT TURN A HAIR. Should he protest? Or accuse these two men? It was useless. Unless there was some proof, of which he had none, and which he did not want to waste time looking for, no one would believe him.

Very tense, and with clenched fists, he was thinking only of how not to betray his rage and feeling of disappointment in front of a triumphant Ganimard. He said goodbye to those pillars of society, the Leroux brothers, and left.

In the hallway, he made a detour to a low door which was clearly the entrance to the cellar and picked up a small red-coloured stone. It was a garnet.

He went outside and, turning round, read this inscription, near the house number 40: *Lucien Destange, architect, 1877.*

And there was the same inscription at number 42.

"There's always a double exit," he thought. "Number 40 and number 42 are connected. Why didn't I think of it? I should have stayed with the two officers last night."

He spoke to these two men:

"Two men came out of that door while I was away, didn't they?"

And he pointed to the door of the house next door.

"Yes, a gentleman and a lady."

He took the arm of the chief inspector, leading him away:

"Monsieur Ganimard, you've had too good a laugh to regret the little inconvenience I caused you..."

"Oh, I don't hold it against you at all."

"Exactly. But the best jokes don't last for ever, and I think that we should bring it to an end."

"I share that view."

"Here we are on the seventh day already. In three days' time it is essential that I should be in London."

"Oh I see."

“And I will be there, Monsieur. I must ask you to keep yourself at the ready during the night of Tuesday to Wednesday.”

“For an expedition of the same kind?” asked Ganimard cheekily.

“Yes, Monsieur, of the same kind.”

“And which will end up with what?”

“With the capture of Lupin.”

“Do you think so?”

“I swear to you on my honour, Monsieur.”

Sholmes said goodbye and allowed himself to take a little rest in the nearest hotel, after which, cheered up and feeling self-confident, he returned to Rue Chalgrin, slipped two louis in the concierge’s hand, made sure that the Leroux brothers had left, learnt that the house belonged to a M. Harmingeat and, equipped with a candle, he went down into the cellar by the little door next to which he had picked up the garnet.

At the bottom of the stairs he found another of an identical shape.

“I was not mistaken,” he thought. “This is where the two properties are connected... Let me see, will my skeleton key open the vault reserved for the tenant on the ground floor? Yes, perfect... now let’s examine these wine racks... Ah, here are some spots where the dust has been removed... and on the ground there are some footprints...”

A faint noise made him prick up his ears. He quickly closed the door, put out the candle and hid himself behind a stack of empty crates. After a few seconds, he noticed that one of the iron racks was rocking gently, pulling away with it a whole piece of the wall to which it was attached. There was a gleam of light cast by a lantern. An arm appeared. And a man came in.

He was bent double like someone searching for something. He disturbed the dust with the ends of his fingers, and several times he got up and threw something into a cardboard box that he was holding in his left hand. Then he wiped out the traces of his footprints, as well as those prints left by Lupin and the Blonde Woman, and came towards the wine rack.

He uttered a husky cry and fell down. Sholmes had pounced on him. It was the matter of a moment, and carried out in the simplest way possible. The man found himself stretched out on the ground, his ankles bound and his wrists tied up.

The Englishman leant over him.

“How much do you want to make you speak? To say what you know?”

The man replied with such an ironic smile that Sholmes understood the pointlessness of his question.

He contented himself with exploring the pockets of his captive, but his investigations only produced a bunch of keys, a handkerchief and the small cardboard box which the person had been using, and which contained a dozen garnets identical to the ones that Sholmes had collected. These were meagre spoils!

What is more, what was he going to do with this man? Wait till his friends came to his aid and hand them all over to the police? What was the point? What advantage would he gain from this in his fight with Lupin?

He hesitated, when his examination of the box caused him to make up his mind. It bore the following address: "Léonard, jeweller, Rue de la Paix."

He decided simply to abandon the man. He pushed the wine rack back, closed the cellar and left the house. From a post office he wired a message to M. Destange, that he could not come till the following day. Then he went off to the jeweller's to return the garnets.

"Madame has sent me with these stones. They have become detached from a piece of jewellery which she bought here."

Sholmes got it right. The shopkeeper replied:

"Yes indeed... The lady in question telephoned me. She will be coming by herself this afternoon."

It was not till five o'clock that Sholmes, stationed on the pavement, caught sight of a woman wrapped up in a thick veil, the shape of which was suspicious. He could see her putting on the counter an antique piece of jewellery decorated with garnets.

She left again immediately, and went off on foot to do some shopping. She went up near Clichy and along some streets which the Englishman did not know. As night was falling, he followed her, without being noticed by the concierge, into a five-storey house that was split into two parts and therefore had countless tenants. He went as far as the second floor. Two minutes later the Englishman tried his luck, and very carefully tried, one after the other, the keys on the bunch which he had acquired. The fourth one opened the lock.

In the total darkness which filled them, he could make out some

completely empty rooms, like those of an uninhabited apartment, with all the doors left open. But at the end of a corridor, the gleam of a lamp was coming through and, approaching on tiptoe, he could see, in the one-way mirror which separated the sitting room from the room next to it, the veiled woman, who was taking off her coat and hat, before putting them on the only seat in the room and wrapping herself in a velvet dressing gown.

He also saw her go towards the fireplace and push an electric button. Half of the panel which extended to the right of the fireplace moved sideways, slid along in the same plane as the surface of the wall and fitted into the thick part of the panel next to it.

As soon as the gap became large enough the woman went through... and disappeared, taking the lamp with her.

The system was quite simple, and Sholmes operated it.

He walked along in the darkness, feeling his way, but immediately his face came up against something soft. By the light of a match, he could see that he was in a tiny room cluttered up with dresses and other clothes hanging on racks. He made his way through and stopped in front of a doorway enclosed by a tapestry or at least by the reverse side of a tapestry. As his match had gone out, he could see some light which was coming through the loose and worn weave of the old material.

So he looked through.

The Blonde Woman was there, right in front of his eyes and within reach.

She extinguished her lamp and put on the electric light. For the first time Sholmes could see her face fully illuminated. He started. The woman that he had finally caught up with after so many detours and manoeuvres was none other than Clotilde Destange.

Clotilde Destange, the murderer of Baron d'Hautrec and the thief who had taken the blue diamond! Clotilde Destanges, the mysterious lady friend of Arsène Lupin! The Blonde Woman in fact!

"For God's sake!" he thought. "What a stupid ass I am! Because Lupin's friend is blonde and Clotilde is brunette, I didn't dream of drawing a connection between the two women! As if the Blonde Woman could remain blonde after the murder of the baron and the theft of the diamond.

Sholmes looked at a part of the room, which was an elegant woman's

boudoir, decorated with light-coloured draperies and precious ornaments. A mahogany chaise longue was lying on a low step. Clotilde had sat down on it, and remained motionless with her head between her hands. And, after a few moments, he noticed that she was crying. Great tears ran down her pale cheeks, slipped towards her mouth and fell, drop after drop, onto her velvet bodice. Other tears followed them incessantly, as though arising from an inexhaustible spring. It was the saddest possible spectacle to see this dismal and resigned despair expressed by the slow rolling of those tears.

But then a door opened behind her. Arsène Lupin came in.

They looked at each other for a long time without uttering a word. Then he knelt down next to her, rested his head on her bosom and put his arms around her, and in the movement with which he embraced the young woman there was a profound tenderness and much pity. They did not move. A sweet silence united them, and the tears flowed less abundantly.

“I would very much like to make you happy!” he murmured.

“I am happy.”

“No you’re not. You’re crying... Your tears distress me, Clotilde.”

Despite everything, she let herself be taken in by his affectionate voice, and she listened, eager for hope and happiness. A smile softened her face, but it was a smile which still contained so much sadness! He begged her:

“Don’t be sad, Clotilde. You must not be; you don’t have the right to be.”

She displayed her slender and supple white hands to him, and said solemnly:

“As long as these hands remain my hands I shall be sad, Maxime.”

“But why?”

“They have killed.”

Maxime exclaimed:

“Be quiet! Don’t think of that... the past is dead; the past doesn’t matter.”

He kissed her long pale hands, and she looked at him with a brighter smile, as if each kiss were erasing a little the horrible memory.

“You must love me, Maxime. You must love me, because no other woman will love you as I do. I have done things to please you, and I am still doing them, not just because you order me to, but because it is what you secretly desire. I have carried out acts which all my instincts and conscience are

appalled by, but I cannot resist... everything I do, I do mechanically, because it is useful to you and you want me to... and I am ready to do it again and for ever.”

He said with bitterness:

“Oh, Clotilde, why did I get you mixed up in my adventurous life? I ought to have remained the Maxime Bermond that you loved five years ago, and not let you get to know... the other man that I am.”

She said in a very low voice:

“I also love this other man, and I don’t regret anything.”

“Yes you do – you regret your past life, your life in the open.”

“I regret nothing when you are here,” she said passionately. “Nothing is wrong any more, nothing is a crime any more when my eyes see you. What does it matter if I am miserable far away from you, if I suffer, weep and feel horror at everything I do! Your love erases it all... I accept everything... But you must love me.”

“I don’t love you because I have to, Clotilde, but for the sole reason that I do love you.”

“Are you sure?” she asked trustingly.

“I am as sure of myself as I am sure of you. But my existence is violent and frantic, and I cannot always devote to you the time that I should wish.”

She immediately panicked.

“What is it? A new danger? Tell me quickly.”

“Oh, nothing more serious. And yet...”

“Yet what?”

“Well, he’s on our track.”

“Sholmes?”

“Yes. It was he who got Ganimard involved in this business at the Hungarian restaurant. It was he who this very night stationed two officers on the Rue Chalgrin. I have proof of this, because Ganimard searched the house this morning, and Sholmes accompanied him. And another thing...”

“Another thing?”

“Well, there is something else: one of our men is missing, Jeanniot.”

“The concierge?”

“Yes.”

“But I’m the one who sent him this morning to Rue Chalgrin, to pick up the garnets which had fallen from my pocket.”

“There’s no doubt that Sholmes walked into the trap.”

“None at all. The garnets have been taken back to the jeweller’s on Rue de la Paix.”

“So, what’s happened to him since?”

“Oh, Maxime, I’m afraid!”

“There’s nothing to be frightened of. But I admit that the situation is very serious. What does he know? Where is he hiding? His strength consists in keeping himself apart. Nothing can betray what he’s doing.”

“So what have you decided?”

“To be extremely cautious, Clotilde. A long time ago I made up my mind to change my place of abode and change it to that other place, in that impregnable refuge which you know about. Sholmes’s intervention has made it necessary to hurry things up. When a man like him is on your track, it has to be said that inevitably he will reach the end of that track. So I have prepared everything. The day after tomorrow, Wednesday, I’ll be moving house. It will be finished by midday. At two o’clock I myself will be able to leave the place, after having removed the last traces of evidence that we were living there. Until then...”

“Until then?”

“We must not see each other, and no one must see you, Clotilde. Don’t go out. I’m not afraid for myself, but I am afraid of everything when it concerns you.”

“It’s impossible that the Englishman could manage to get to me.”

“Everything is possible with him. I don’t trust him. Yesterday, when I was almost surprised by your father, I had come to search through the cabinet that contains the very old records of M. Destange. There was danger present. And it’s everywhere. I sense the enemy prowling in the shadows and getting nearer and nearer. I sense that he is watching us... that he is spreading his nets around us. It is one of those intuitions which never mislead me.”

“In that case,” she said, “leave, Maxime, and don’t think of my tears any more. I will be strong and I will wait till the danger is averted. Goodbye Maxime.”

She embraced him for a long time. And it was she who pushed him

outside. Sholmes heard the sound of their voices going away.

Boldly, and highly excited by the same need to take action, in spite of everything, which had been stimulating him since the previous day, he went into an antechamber, at the far end of which there was a staircase. But just as he was going to go down, the sound of conversation came to him from the lower floor, and he thought it would be preferable to follow a corridor which curved round and led him to another staircase. At the bottom of this staircase he was surprised to see pieces of furniture, the shape and location of which he was already familiar with. There was a half-open door. He went into a large round room. It was M. Destange's library.

"Perfect! Admirable!" he murmured. "Now I understand it all. Clotilde's boudoir, that is to say that of the Blonde Woman, is connected to one of the apartments of the house next door, and the exit of the house next door is not onto the Place Malesherbes but onto the Rue Montchanin, as far as I can remember... Marvellous! And now I understand how Clotilde Destange can meet her beloved while maintaining her reputation as a person who never goes out. And I understand also how Arsène Lupin appeared suddenly near me, yesterday, in the gallery: there must be another connection between the apartment next door and this library..."

And concluded as follows:

"Another house that has been tampered with. And another case, no doubt, of the architect being Destange! It's now a matter of taking advantage of my getting in here to confirm the contents of the cabinet... and to do some research on other things which have been tampered with."

Sholmes went up into the gallery and hid himself behind the drapes on the handrail. He stayed there until late in the evening. A servant came to put out the electric lights. An hour later the Englishman operated the spring mechanism of his lamp and went towards the cabinet.

As he already knew, it contained very old papers on architecture, files, estimates and account books. On the second shelf there stood a set of registers, organized by date.

He took down in turn the volumes relating to recent years, and immediately studied the summary pages, and more especially items under the letter H. Finally, after discovering the name Harmingeat, accompanied by the number 63, he consulted page 63 and read there:

Hermingeat, 40 Rue Chalgrin.

There followed details of work carried out for this client with a view to installing a stove in his house. And in the margin there was this note:

See MB file.

“Ah! I know this MB file well,” he said to himself. “That’s the one I need. With that I shall be able to learn about the present home of M. Lupin.”

It was not until morning that he discovered, in the second half of a register, the special file in question.

It consisted of fifteen pages. One was a copy of the page devoted to M. Harmingeat on Rue Chalgrin. Another provided details of the work carried out for M. Vatinel, the owner of 25 Rue Clapeyron. And another was reserved for Baron d’Hautrec, at 134 Avenue Henri-Martin. There was also one for the Château de Crozon, and eleven others for various property owners in Paris.

Sholmes copied this list of eleven names and eleven addresses, and then he put things back in their places, opened a window and jumped down onto the deserted square, having taken care to push back the shutters.

In his hotel room he lit his pipe with the solemnity he usually devoted to this act, and, surrounded by clouds of smoke, he studied the conclusions that could be drawn from the MB file – or, in other words, the Maxime Bermond alias Arsène Lupin file.

At eight o’clock, he sent the following message to Ganimard by pneumatic post:

I shall probably be going this morning to Rue Pergolèse and shall entrust to you a person whose capture is of the highest importance. In any case, please stay at home tonight and tomorrow, Wednesday, until midday, and arrange to have thirty men at your disposal.

Then, on the boulevard, he selected a motorized cab whose driver pleased him with his nice, cheerful, but not very intelligent face, and had himself taken to place Malesherbes, about fifty feet away from the Destange mansion.

“My man, close your vehicle,” he said to the driver, “put up the collar of your fur coat and wait patiently. In an hour and a half, start your engine up. As soon as I’m back, set off for Rue Pergolèse.”

Just as he was crossing the threshold of the mansion, he had a final

moment of hesitation. Wasn't it wrong to be so concerned about the Blonde Woman while Lupin was finishing his preparations for his departure? And wouldn't it be better, with the help of the list of buildings, to look first for the home of his opponent?

"Bah!" he said to himself. "When the Blonde Woman is my prisoner I'll be in charge of the situation."

And he rang the bell.

M. Destange was already in the library. They worked for a while and Sholmes was looking for an excuse to go up to Clotilde's room, when the young woman came in, greeted her father and sat down in the small room and started to write.

From his seat, Sholmes could see her leaning on the table, and from time to time she sat meditating with her pen in the air and a pensive expression. He waited for a while, and then, taking a volume in his hand, said to M. Destange:

"This is the very book that Mlle Destange asked me to take to her as soon as I came upon it."

He went into the little room and placed himself in front of Clotilde in such a way that her father could not see him, and he said:

"I am M. Stickmann, M. Destange's new secretary."

"Oh," she said, without getting up. "So my father has changed his secretary?"

"Yes, Mademoiselle, and I would like to speak to you."

"Please sit down, Monsieur. I have finished."

She added a few words to her letter, signed it, sealed the envelope, pushed away her papers, pressed the button on a telephone, got her dressmaker on the line, asked her to hurry up and finish a travel coat which she needed urgently, and finally turned to Sholmes:

"I am at your disposal, Monsieur. But can't our conversation take place in front of my father?"

"No, Mademoiselle, and I must beg you to not even raise your voice. It is preferable that M. Destange should not hear us at all."

"For whose sake is it preferable?"

"For yours, Mademoiselle."

"I can't allow any conversation that my father cannot hear."

"It is however very necessary that you allow this one."

They both stood up, exchanging glances.

And she said:

“Speak, Monsieur.”

Still standing, he said as follows:

“You must excuse me if I am mistaken about certain secondary details. What I can guarantee is the general accuracy of what I shall reveal.”

“No empty words, please, just the facts.”

By this interruption, thrown in suddenly, he sensed that the young woman was on her guard. He continued:

“Very well, I shall come straight to the point. So, it was five years ago that your father happened to meet a certain M. Maxime Bermond, who introduced himself to him as a contractor... or architect – I can’t be more specific. The fact remains that M. Destange became fond of this young man, and as the state of his health no longer allowed him to attend to his business, he entrusted to M. Bermond the tasks of carrying out some of the orders he had accepted on behalf of some old clients, and which seemed to be suited to the skills of his collaborator.”

Sholmes stopped. It seems to him that the paleness of the young woman had become heightened. Yet it was with the greatest calm that she said:

“I don’t know the facts which you have imparted to me, Monsieur, and above all I do not know in what way they can be of interest to me.”

“In this respect, Mademoiselle, that the fact is that Maxime Bermond is, to call him by his right name – which you know as well as I do – Arsène Lupin.”

She burst out laughing.

“That’s not possible! Arsène Lupin? M. Maxime Bermond is really called Arsène Lupin?”

“As I have the honour of informing you, Mademoiselle, and since you refuse to understand what I’m telling you without my spelling it out, I will add that Arsène Lupin has found here, to accomplish his plans, a lady friend, in fact more than a friend, a blind accomplice and... passionately devoted to him.”

She stood up and, without showing any emotion, or at least with so little emotion that Sholmes was struck at such self-control, she said:

“I don’t know the point of your behaviour, Monsieur, and I don’t want to know it. I must ask you therefore not to add another word and to leave.”

“It was not my intention to impose my presence on you indefinitely,” replied Sholmes, as calm as she was. “Only I am determined not to leave this house alone.”

“And who will accompany you, Monsieur?”

“You!”

“Me?”

“Yes, Mademoiselle, we shall leave this house together, and you will follow me, without making any protest, without uttering a word.”

What was strange about this scene was the absolute calmness of the adversaries. Rather than it being an implacable duel between two powerful wills, one would have said, from their attitude and the tone of their voices, that it was a courteous debate between two people who do not share the same opinion.

In the rotunda, from the large open bay window, M. Destange could be seen handling his books with measured movements.

Clotilde sat down again, shrugging her shoulders lightly. Herlock pulled out his watch.

“It is half-past ten. In five minutes we shall leave.”

“Otherwise?”

“Otherwise, I shall go and find M. Destange, and I shall tell him...”

“What?”

“The truth. I shall tell him about the dishonest life of Maxime Bermond, and I shall tell him about the double life of his accomplice.”

“Of his accomplice?”

“Yes, of the person they call the Blonde Woman, or of the woman who used to be blonde.”

“And what proof will you supply him with?”

“I shall take him to Rue Chalgrin and show him the passage that Arsène Lupin, taking advantage of the work he was in charge of, had made by his men, between number 40 and number 42, the passage which you both used the night before last.”

“And then?”

“Then I shall take M. Destange to the apartment of Maître Detinan, and we shall go down the backstairs by which you descended with Arsène Lupin, to escape from Ganimard. And together we shall look for the connection, no doubt similar, with the house next door, the house whose

exit opens onto the Boulevard des Batignolles and not onto the Rue Clapeyron.”

“And after that?”

“After that I shall take M. Destange to the Château de Crozon, and it will be easy for him, knowing the type of work carried out by Arsène Lupin at the time of the restoration of the chateau, to discover the secret passages which Arsène Lupin had made by his men. He will confirm that these passages allowed the Blonde Woman to get in during the night, into the countess’s room, and to take the blue diamond from the mantelpiece, and allowed her two weeks later to get into Consul Bleichen’s room and hide this blue diamond at the bottom of a small bottle... quite a strange action, I admit, some small feminine form of revenge perhaps. I don’t know, and it’s not important.”

“And then?”

“Then,” Herlock said in a more serious voice, “I shall take M. Destange to 134 Avenue Henri-Martin, and we shall try to find out how the Baron d’Hautrec—”

“Be quiet! Be quiet!” the young girl mumbled, suddenly terrified... I forbid you to!... So you dare say that it was me... you accuse me...”

“I accuse you of having killed Baron d’Hautrec.”

“No, no, it’s slanderous.”

“You did kill Baron d’Hautrec, Mademoiselle. You entered his employment under the name of Antoinette Bréhat, with the aim of stealing the blue diamond from him, and you killed him.”

Again she murmured, shattered and reduced to begging:

“Please be quiet, Monsieur, I beg you. Since you know so many things, then you must know that I did not murder the baron.”

“I did not say that you murdered him, Mademoiselle. The Baron d’Hautrec was subject to bouts of madness that only Sister Auguste was able to bring under control. I learnt these details directly from her. In this person’s absence he must have pounced on you, and it was in the course of this struggle, to protect your own life, that you struck him. Horrified at such an act, you rang the bell and you ran away without even pulling from the finger of your victim the blue diamond which you had come to take. A moment later you brought back one of Lupin’s accomplices, a servant in the house next door, and together you carried the baron to his bed. Then

you tidied up the room again... but still without daring to take the blue diamond. That's what happened. So, I repeat, you did not murder the baron. But it was your hands which struck him."

She had put her long slender hands together over her forehead, and she kept them there for a long time, motionless. At last, unfolding her fingers, she uncovered her sorrowful face and said:

"And you intend to tell all this to my father?"

"Yes, and I shall tell him that my witnesses will be Mlle Gerbois, who will be able to recognize the Blonde Woman; Sister Auguste, who will recognize Antoinette Bréhat; and the Countess de Crozon, who will recognize Mme de Réal. That is what I shall tell him."

"You wouldn't dare," she said, recovering her composure when faced with the threat of immediate danger.

He got up and stepped towards the library. Clotilde stopped him:

"One moment, Monsieur."

She thought for a moment, having regained her self-control again, and, very calmly, she asked him:

"You are Herlock Sholmes, aren't you?"

"Yes."

"What do you want from me?"

"What I want? I have undertaken a duel with Arsène Lupin, from which I must emerge as victor. In expectation of an outcome which should occur without delay, I estimate that a hostage as valuable as you will give me a considerable advantage over my opponent. So, you will follow me, Mademoiselle, and I shall entrust you to one of my friends. As soon as I have achieved my goal, you will be free."

"And that is all?"

"That is all. I do not belong to the police force of your country, and consequently I do not feel I have any right... to dispense justice."

She seemed to be determined. But she required a moment of respite. She closed her eyes and Sholmes looked at her: she had suddenly become calm, almost indifferent to the dangers surrounding her.

"And yet," thought the Englishman, "does she still believe herself to be in danger? No, because Lupin is protecting her. With the help of Lupin nothing can touch you. Lupin is omnipotent, Lupin is infallible."

"Mademoiselle," he said. "I spoke of five minutes, but now more than

thirty have passed.”

“Will you allow me to go to my room, Monsieur, and pack my things?”

“If you wish, Mademoiselle. I shall go and wait for you on Rue Montchanin. I am a good friend of the concierge, Jeanniot.”

“Oh, then you know...” she said in obvious dread.

“I know many things.”

“Very well. Then I’ll ring.”

Her hat and coat were brought for her, and Sholmes said to her:

“You must give M. Destange a reason which explains our departure, and this reason must necessarily explain your absence for several days.”

“There’s no point. I shall be here again this afternoon.”

Again they stared defiantly at each other, both of them smiling and ironic.

“How sure you are of him!” said Sholmes.

“Blindly.”

“Everything he does is good, isn’t it? Everything that he wants comes true. And you approve of it all and are ready to do everything for him.”

“I love him,” she said, trembling with passion.

“And you believe that he will save you?”

She shrugged her shoulders and, moving towards her father, she said to him:

“I’m taking you with me, Monsieur Stickmann. We’re going to the Bibliothèque Nationale.”

“Will you be back for dinner?”

“Perhaps... or rather no... but don’t worry about it.”

And she said firmly to Sholmes:

“I shall follow you, Monsieur.”

“Without reservation?”

“With my eyes closed.”

“If you try to escape, I shall call out, shout, and you will be arrested, and that will mean prison. Do not forget that there is a warrant out for the Blonde Woman.”

“I swear to you that I shall make no attempt to escape.”

“I believe you, so let’s go.”

Together, as he said they would, they left the house.

In the square the car was parked, but facing in the opposite direction. They could see the driver's back and his cap, which almost covered the collar of his coat. As they approached, Sholmes could hear the purring of the engine. He opened the door, asked Clotilde to get in and then sat down beside her.

The vehicle abruptly drove off, reached the outer boulevards, the Avenue Hoche and the Avenue de la Grande-Armée.

Deep in thought, Herlock worked out his plans.

"Ganimard is at his home. I'll leave the young woman in his hands... Shall I tell him who this young woman is? No, he will take her straight to the police cells, which will spoil everything. Once alone I shall consult the MB file, and the chase is on! And tonight, or tomorrow morning at the latest, I'll go and find Ganimard as agreed, and I'll hand over Arsène Lupin and his gang..."

He rubbed his hands, happy to feel at last his goal within his reach and to perceive that there was no serious obstacle separating him from it. And yielding to a need to be more expansive, which contrasted with his usual nature, he exclaimed:

"Please excuse me, Mademoiselle, if I display so much satisfaction. The battle was hard, and success is especially enjoyable for me."

"Justifiable success, Monsieur, and which you have a right to delight in."

"Thank you. But what an odd route we are taking! Didn't the driver understand?"

At that moment they were leaving Paris via the Porte de Neuilly. What the devil! But the Rue Pergolèse wasn't outside the city limits!

Sholmes lowered the glass pane.

"Hey, driver, you've made a mistake... Rue Pergolèse!..."

The man did not reply. And he repeated in a raised voice:

"I told you to go to Rue Pergolèse."

The man still did not reply.

"Oh, you must be deaf, my friend. Or you're just ill-willed... We've no reason to come to this area... Rue Pergolèse! I order you to turn back, and as quickly as you can."

Still the same silence. The Englishman trembled with anxiety. He looked at Clotilde: an indefinable smile was creasing the young woman's lips.

"Why are you smiling?..." he grumbled. "This incident has nothing to do

with... it doesn't change anything."

"Absolutely nothing," she replied.

Suddenly an idea struck him. Raising himself up halfway, he examined more carefully the man who was in the driving seat. His shoulders were slimmer, his posture more casual... A cold sweat ran over him, he clenched his hands, as the dreadful conviction formed clearly in his mind: this man was Arsène Lupin.

"Well now, Mr Sholmes, how do you like our little excursion?"

"Delightful, my dear Monsieur, truly delightful," retorted Sholmes.

It had perhaps never been necessary for him to force himself to make such a tremendous effort to utter his words without his voice trembling, without any sign of the eruption in his whole being. But immediately, in a sort of enormous reaction, a flood of anger and hatred breached the dykes, overcame his will, and with a sudden movement he drew out his revolver and turned it on Mlle Destange.

"Stop, at this very minute, this second, or I'll fire at the young lady."

"I recommend you to aim at the cheek if you want to hit the temple," replied Lupin without turning his head.

Clotilde said:

"Maxime, don't go too fast, the cobblestones are slippery, and I am very scared."

She was still smiling, with her eyes fixed on the cobblestones, with which the road bristled in front of the car.

"Make him stop! Make him stop!" Sholmes said to her, mad with rage.

"You can see that I am capable of doing anything!"

The barrel of the revolver brushed against the curls of her hair.

She murmured:

"Maxime is so careless! At this rate we are sure to skid."

Sholmes put the weapon back in his pocket and seized the handle of the door, ready to jump out, despite the absurdity of such an act.

Clotilde said to him:

"Be careful, sir, there's a car behind us."

He turned round. There was indeed a car following them, a huge one, with a fierce appearance and a high bonnet, and blood-red in colour, with four men in leather jackets riding in it.

“Well, I’m being guarded. We must wait.”

He crossed his arms over his chest, with that over-proud submission of those who give in and wait for fate to turn against them. And while they were crossing the Seine, and were roaring through Suresnes, Rueil and Chatou, he sat motionless, resigned, in control of his anger and without bitterness. His only thought was to find out by what miracle Arsène Lupin had replaced the driver. He could not admit that the good fellow whom he had chosen that morning on the boulevard was an accomplice placed there in advance. Yet it must be that Arsène Lupin had been told beforehand, and he could not have been told until after that moment when he, Sholmes, had threatened Clotilde, since no one could have any suspicion about his plan beforehand. Well, since that moment Clotilde and he had not been parted from each other at all.

A memory struck him: the telephone connection which the young woman asked for, the conversation with her dressmaker. And suddenly he understood. Even before he had spoken to her, just by announcing that he wanted to discuss something with her as M. Destange’s new secretary, she had sensed the danger, guessed the name and aim of the visitor and, coldly and quite naturally, as though she was in reality carrying out the action which she seemed to be doing, she had called Lupin and asked for his help, with the pretence of his being a supplier, and using some expressions agreed on between them.

How Arsène Lupin had come, how this parked car, with its motor throbbing, had seemed suspicious to him and how he had bribed the driver, all that was unimportant. What fascinated Sholmes so much that it calmed his rage was the recollection of that moment, when an ordinary woman, a woman in love it is true, suppressing her nerves, overcoming her instincts, keeping her facial features completely still and even subduing the expression in her eyes, had pulled the wool over the eyes of old Herlock Sholmes.

What can one do against a man helped by such assistants, and who, by the sole influence of his authority, could instill in a woman such reserves of boldness and energy?

They crossed the Seine and went up the hill of Saint-Germain, but at five hundred metres beyond this town the cab slowed down. The other car drew level with it and both of them stopped. There was nobody else

around.

“Mr Sholmes,” said Lupin, “please be so kind as to change vehicles. Ours is really so slow!”

“Of course!” exclaimed Sholmes, all the more obliging, as he did not have any choice.

“Please permit me also to lend you this fur coat, for we shall be going quite fast, and to offer you these two sandwiches... Yes, yes, please accept them. Who knows when you will have dinner!”

The four men had alighted. One of them came towards them, and when they removed the goggles which were masking them, Sholmes recognized the gentleman in the frock coat at the Hungarian restaurant. Lupin said to him:

“You will take this cab back to the driver from whom I hired it. He is waiting in the first wine bar on the right on the Rue Legendre. You will pay him the second instalment of a thousand francs that I promised him. Oh, I forgot, please give your goggles to Mr Sholmes.”

He discussed something with Mlle Destange, and then he settled down at the steering wheel and drove off, with Sholmes at their side, and one of his men behind him.

Lupin had not been exaggerating when he said they would be going “quite fast”. From the start they went at breathtaking speed. The horizon came to meet them, as though attracted by a mysterious force, and it disappeared at once, as though absorbed by an abyss to which other things also immediately rushed, trees, houses, plains and forests, with the tempestuous haste of a torrent sensing the approach of a chasm.

Sholmes and Lupin did not exchange a word. Above their heads the leaves of the poplar trees made a huge noise like waves, made rhythmic by the regular spacing of the trees. And the towns just faded away: Mantes, Vernon, Gaillon. From one hill to the next, from Bon-Secours to Canteleu, and Rouen, its suburbs, its port and its many kilometres of quays. Rouen seemed to be nothing but a street in a small town. And then came Duclair, Caudebec, the Pays de Caux, touching lightly its rolling plains in their powerful flight, and Lillebonne and Quillebeuf. And then suddenly they found themselves on the banks of the Seine, at the end of a small quay, along which there was lying a plain yacht with sturdy lines, the funnel of which was sending out curls of black smoke.

The car stopped. In two hours they had covered more than forty leagues.

A man came towards them wearing a blue uniform jacket and a cap trimmed with gold braid. He saluted them.

“Perfect, Captain!” exclaimed Lupin. “You received my telegram?”

“I received it.”

“And is the *Hirondelle* ready?”

“The *Hirondelle* is ready.”

“In that case, Mr Sholmes?... ”

The Englishman looked around him, and saw a group of people on the terrace of a café, and another nearer at hand. He hesitated for a moment, and then, understanding that, before anyone could intervene, he would be grabbed, taken on board and put into the bottom of the hold, he went across the gangway and followed Lupin into the captain’s cabin.

It was huge, meticulously clean and very bright with all its varnished panelling and the sparkling of all its brass.

Lupin closed the door again and, without any preamble, almost brutally, he said to Sholmes:

“What exactly do you know?”

“Everything.”

“Everything? Be more specific.”

In the intonation of his voice there was no longer that slightly ironical politeness that he affected towards the Englishman. It was the imperious accent of the master who is in the habit of giving orders and having everyone yield to him, even if that person is Herlock Sholmes.

They looked at each other, weighing each other up. Now they were enemies, declared and trembling enemies. A little agitated, Lupin continued:

“Several times, sir, I have encountered you crossing my path. That’s one time too many, and I’m fed up with wasting my time avoiding the traps that you have set for me. I warn you therefore that my behaviour towards you will depend on your response. What exactly do you know?”

“Everything, Monsieur, I tell you again.”

Arsène Lupin controlled himself and said in a clipped voice:

“I am going to tell you what it is that you know. You know that, under the name of Maxime Bermond, I... *made alterations* to fifteen houses constructed by M. Destange.”

“Yes.”

“And of these fifteen houses you know four of them.”

“Yes.”

“And you have the list of the eleven others.”

“Yes.”

“You made this list at Monsieur Destange’s house last night, no doubt.”

“Yes.”

“And as you assume that, among these eleven buildings, there is inevitably one which I have kept for my own use, for my needs and those of my friends, you have entrusted Ganimard with the task of joining battle and of discovering my retreat.”

“No.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean that I’m acting alone, and that I was going to join battle by myself.”

“So, I have nothing to fear, *since* you are in my hands.”

“You have nothing to fear *as long as* I’m in your hands.”

“That means that you won’t be staying there?”

“No.”

Arsène Lupin moved towards the Englishman again and, putting one hand very gently on his shoulder, he said:

“Listen to me, sir: I am not in the mood for discussion, and you are not, unhappily for you, in a situation to thwart me. So, let’s get it over with.”

“Let’s get it over with.”

“You must give me your word of honour that you will not try to escape from this boat before you are in English territorial waters.”

“I give you my word of honour that I shall try to escape by all means possible,” replied Sholmes, indomitably.

“But, damn it, you know, however, that I only have to say the word to render you powerless. All these men obey me blindly. On a sign from me they will put a chain round your neck—”

“Chains break.”

“—and throw you overboard ten miles away from either coast.”

“I can swim.”

“A good answer,” exclaimed Lupin, laughing. “God forgive me, I was angry. Excuse me, Maestro... Let’s settle this. Do you accept the fact that I

should take all necessary measures to ensure my security and that of my friends?”

“All necessary measures. But they are useless.”

“All right. But you don’t hold it against me for having taken them?”

“You are obliged to.”

“Then let’s go.”

Lupin opened the door and called the captain and two sailors. These seized the Englishman and, after having searched him, they tied up his legs and attached him to the captain’s bunk.

“Enough!” ordered Lupin. “To tell the truth, it is due to your obstinacy, sir, and the exceptional seriousness of the circumstances, that I dare to allow myself to...”

The sailors withdrew and Lupin said to the captain:

“Captain, a crew member will stay here at Mr Sholmes’s disposal, and you yourself will keep him company as much as possible. You should show him every respect. He is not a prisoner, but a guest. What time is it by your watch, Captain?”

“Five past two.”

Lupin checked his watch, and then a clock attached to the bulkhead in the cabin.

“Five past two... we agree. How long do you need to get to Southampton?”

“Nine hours, without hurrying.”

“Make it eleven. You must not reach land before the departure of the ship which leaves Southampton at midnight and arrives at Le Havre at eight o’clock in the morning. You understand, don’t you, Captain? I repeat: as it would be extremely dangerous for us all if the gentleman should return to France by that boat, you must not arrive at Southampton before one o’clock in the morning.”

“Understood.”

“Goodbye then, Maestro. Till next year, in this world or the next.”

“Till tomorrow.”

A few minutes later, Sholmes heard the car drive off, and suddenly, deep inside the *Hirondelle*, the steam puffed more violently. The boat moved off.

By getting on for three o’clock they had crossed the estuary of the Seine

and were going out into the open sea. At that moment, stretched out on the bunk to which he was bound, Herlock Sholmes was sleeping deeply.

The following morning, on the tenth and last day of the battle undertaken by the two great rivals, *L'Écho de France* published this exquisite brief article:

Yesterday a deportation order was served by Arsène Lupin to Herlock Sholmes, the English detective. Served at midday, the order was carried out the same day. At one o'clock in the morning Sholmes disembarked at Southampton.

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The Second Arrest of Arsène Lupin

FROM EIGHT O'CLOCK, a dozen removal vehicles were obstructing the Rue Crevaux, between the Avenue du Bois-de-Boulogne and the Avenue Bugeaud. M. Félix Davey left the apartment which he occupied on the fourth floor of number 8. And M. Dubreuil, an expert, who had joined together into one apartment the fifth floor of the same house and the fifth floors of the two adjoining houses, dispatched on the same day – a pure coincidence, as the two gentlemen did not know each other – the collection of furniture, concerning which so many foreign correspondents visited him daily.

A detail which was noticed in that area, but which was only talked about much later, was that not one of the dozen vehicles bore the address of the furniture remover, and not one of the men accompanying them hung around in the neighbouring bars. They worked so well that by eleven o'clock everything was finished. Nothing was left behind except those piles of papers and rags that one leaves behind in the corners of empty rooms.

M. Félix Davey was an elegant young man, dressed in the most refined fashion, but carried in his hand a training stick, of a weight which suggested that its possessor had out-of-the-ordinary biceps. M. Félix Davey went off at a leisurely pace and sat down on the bench in the side street, which cuts into the Avenue de Bois, across from the Rue Pergolèse. Near him, a woman dressed like a petite-bourgeoise, was reading a newspaper, while a child was playfully digging up a pile of sand with its spade.

After a few moments Félix Davey said to the woman, without turning his head:

“What news of Ganimard?”

“He left this morning at nine o'clock.”

“Where to?”

“To police headquarters.”

“Alone?”

“Alone.”

“No telegram last night?”

“None.”

“Do they still trust you in the house?”

“Yes they do. I do little things for Mme Ganimard, and she tells me everything her husband is doing... We spent the morning together.”

“Fine. Until further notice continue to come here every day at eleven o’clock.”

He got up and went off to the Chinese pavilion, near the Porte Dauphine, where he had a frugal breakfast: two eggs, some vegetables and fruit. Then he returned to Rue Crevaux and said to the concierge:

“I’ll just take a look round upstairs, and then I’ll give you the keys.”

He finished his inspection in the room which served as his office. There he grasped the end of a gas pipe, which had an articulated joint and hung down from the mantelpiece. He lifted the brass cap which closed it, fitted a small device in the shape of a cone and blew into it.

He received a light whistle in reply. Putting the pipe to his mouth he murmured:

“Anyone there, Dubreuil?”

“No one.”

“Can I come up?”

“Yes.”

He put the pipe back in its place, saying to himself:

“How far will progress go? Our century abounds in little inventions which make life truly charming and colourful. And so amusing!... Above all when you know how to treat life as a game, like me.”

He made one of the mouldings on the mantelpiece swivel. The marble slab itself moved, and the mirror which was mounted on top of it slid back on invisible grooves, revealing a gaping hole in which there were the first steps of a staircase built into the very body of the fireplace. It was all very neat, and made of carefully polished cast iron and white porcelain tiles.

He went upstairs. On the fifth floor there was a similar opening over the fireplace, where M. Dubreuil was waiting for him.

“Have you finished in your place?”

“It’s finished.”

“Everything’s been cleared out?”

“Completely.”

“And the staff?”

“The only ones left are the three guards.”

“Then let’s go.”

One behind the other, they went up by the same staircase to the servants’ floor, and came out into an attic in which there were three individuals, one of them looking out the window.

“Nothing new?”

“Nothing, boss.”

“The street is quiet?”

“Absolutely.”

“Another ten minutes and I’ll be leaving for good. You will leave also. Until then, if there’s the slightest suspicious movement in the street, warn me.”

“I’ve got my finger constantly on the alarm bell, boss.”

“Dubreuil, did you advise the removal men not to touch the wires of this bell?”

“Certainly. It’s working perfectly.”

“Fine, that reassures me.”

The two men went down to Félix Davey’s apartment. And the latter, after having pushed back the moulding on the marble, exclaimed cheerfully:

“Dubreuil, I would like to see the faces of those who will discover these admirable contraptions: warning sounds, a network of electric wires and acoustic pipes, invisible passages, strips and parquet flooring that slide along, concealed staircases... it’s really all machinery suitable for a magic show!”

“What publicity for Arsène Lupin!”

“An advertisement which one could well do without. It’s a pity to leave such a setup. We must start all over again, Dubreuil... and obviously with a new concept, for one must never repeat oneself. A plague on Herlock Sholmes.”

“Sholmes has still not come back?”

“How could he? From Southampton there’s only one ship, the midnight one. And from Le Havre there’s only one train, the one at eight o’clock in the morning, which arrives at eleven past eleven. From the moment when

he missed the midnight ship – and he did not take it, as the instructions given to the captain were categorical – then he cannot be in Paris until this evening, via Newhaven and Dieppe.”

“If he does come back.”

“Sholmes never gives up in any game. He will return, but too late. We’ll be far away.”

“And Mlle Destange?”

“I am to meet her again in an hour.”

“At her home?”

“Oh, no. She will only go back home in a few days, after the storm... and when I have nothing more to concern myself about but her. But you, Dubreuil, must hurry. Loading all our packages on board will take a long time, and your presence is necessary at the quayside.”

“You’re sure that we have not been watched?”

“By whom? I am afraid of no one but Herlock Sholmes.”

Dubreuil withdrew. Félix Davey took a last look round, picked up two or three torn letters, and then, noticing a piece of chalk, he picked it up, and drew a large square box on the dark paper in the dining room, and wrote on it, in the style of a commemorative plaque:

For five years, at the beginning of the twentieth century, Arsène Lupin, gentleman burglar, lived here.

This little joke seemed to give him keen satisfaction. He looked at it, whistling a joyful tune, and exclaimed:

“Now that I’ve got myself properly identified for historians of future generations, let’s leave. Hurry up, Maestro Herlock Sholmes. Within three minutes I will have left my hideout, and your defeat will be complete... What, another ten minutes! You want to make me wait, Maestro!... Just one more minute! You’re not coming? Well, then I proclaim your fall and my apotheosis. After which I’m slipping away. Farewell, the realm of Arsène Lupin! I shall never see you again. Farewell to the fifty-five rooms and six apartments over which I reigned! Farewell, my little room, my austere little room.”

The sound of a bell cut off sharply his bout of lyricism, a harsh, rapid and strident ringing, which broke off twice, was repeated twice and then stopped. It was the alarm bell.

What was it? What unforeseen danger? Ganimard? No, it couldn't be...

He was about to go back to his office and escape. But first he went to the side of the window. There was nobody in the street. Could the enemy already be inside the house? He listened and thought he could discern some confused murmurs. Without hesitating further, he ran to his office and, as he was passing through the doorway, he was able to make out the noise of someone trying to insert a key into the door of the hallway.

"Damn it," he murmured, "it's high time I... The house is probably surrounded... there's the backstairs, no, impossible! Luckily the fireplace..."

He pushed the moulding firmly: it wouldn't move. He made a more violent effort: it still wouldn't move.

At the same moment he had the impression that the door was opening downstairs and that there was the sound of footsteps.

"Good God!" he swore. "I'm lost, if this damned mechanism..."

He twisted his fingers around the moulding. He pressed on it with all his might. Nothing moved. Nothing! Through incredible bad luck, by a truly malicious turn of fate, the mechanism, which had still been working a moment before, was no longer working now.

He persevered and became tense. The block of marble remained inert, unmoveable. Curses! Was it possible that this stupid obstacle was blocking his way? He hit the marble, he hit it using angry blows with his fist, he hammered at it, he swore at it...

"So, what's wrong, Monsieur Lupin, is there really something which doesn't work as you want it to?"

Lupin turned round, shaking with terror. Before him stood Herlock Sholmes.

Herlock Sholmes! He looked at him and blinked, as though disturbed by a cruel vision. Herlock Sholmes in Paris! The same Herlock Sholmes he had dispatched to England the previous day like some dangerous parcel, and who was now standing before him, victorious and free. Oh, for this impossible miracle to be realized against his will, the laws of nature would have to be overturned. It was a triumph of everything that is illogical and abnormal! Herlock Sholmes standing there in front of him!

Now it was the Englishman's turn to speak ironically, full of that

scornful politeness with which his opponent had so often lashed out at him:

“Monsieur Lupin, I have to inform you that, from this moment on, I shall never think again of the night you made me spend in the house of Baron d’Hautrec, of the unfortunate experiences of my friend Wilson, of my abduction in a car and certainly not of the journey that I have just completed, tied up on your orders on a not very comfortable bunk. This present moment erases everything. I no longer remember anything else. I have been rewarded. I have been handsomely rewarded.”

Lupin kept silent. The Englishman continued:

“Are you not of the same opinion?”

He had an insistent manner, as though he were asking for the other’s agreement, as though calling it quits with regard to the past.

After a few moments’ thought, during which the Englishman felt that the other was looking right through him, that he was being examined to the very depths of his soul, Lupin declared:

“I assume, sir, that you have serious grounds in support of your present behaviour?”

“Extremely serious.”

“The fact of your having escaped my captain and sailors is only a secondary incident in our battle. But the fact of your being here, in front of me, *alone*, you understand, alone face to face with Arsène Lupin, leads me to believe that your revenge is as complete as possible.”

“As complete as possible.”

“And what about this house?”

“Surrounded.”

“And the two neighbouring houses?”

“Surrounded.”

“And the apartment above this one?”

“The *three* apartments on the fifth floor, which were occupied by M. Dubreuil, are also surrounded.”

“With the result that...”

“With the result that you are caught, Monsieur Lupin, well and truly caught.”

The same feelings that had disturbed Sholmes during the course of his trip in the car were felt now by Lupin, the same concentrated rage, the

same sense of revolt – but also, at the end of the day, the same honesty made him yield to the forces against him. Both were equally strong, and willing to accept defeat as a temporary difficulty to which it was necessary to resign oneself.

“We are quits, sir,” he said simply.

The Englishman seemed to be delighted with this admission. They were silent. Then Lupin continued, already in control of himself again and smiling:

“And I’m not angry about it! It would be tedious to win every time. I only had to stretch out my arm to hit you full in the chest. So now, it’s my turn. Touché, Maestro!”

And he laughed heartily.

“At least this is going to be amusing! Lupin is caught in a mouse trap. How’s he going to get out of it? In a mouse trap!... What an adventure!... Oh, Maestro, you’ve given me a terrible fright. But that’s life!”

He pressed his temples with two closed fists, as though trying to compress the muddled joy bubbling up inside him, and he was making gestures like a child who is playing with something which is definitely beyond its capabilities.

Finally he went up to the Englishman.

“And now, what are you waiting for?”

“What I’m waiting for?”

“Yes, Ganimard is there, with his men. Why doesn’t he come in?”

“I asked him not to.”

“And he agreed?”

“I asked for his services only on the formal condition that he would allow himself to be led by me. What is more, he believes that Monsieur Félix Davey is only an accomplice of Lupin!”

“Then I’ll repeat my question in another form. Why did you come in alone?”

“I wanted to talk to you first.”

“Ah! Ah! You want to talk to me about something.”

This idea seemed to give special pleasure to Lupin. There are certain circumstances in which one prefers by far words to actions.

“Mr Sholmes, I am sorry that I don’t have any chair to offer you. Will this old, half-broken crate be acceptable to you? Or perhaps this window

ledge? I'm sure that a glass of beer would be welcome... Dark or light?... But do sit down, please..."

"There's no point. Let's talk."

"I'm listening."

"I will be brief. The purpose of my visit to Paris is not to arrest you. If I was drawn into pursuing you, it is because no other means presented itself of attaining my real goal."

"Which was?"

"To recover the blue diamond!"

"The blue diamond!"

"That's right, because the one found in Consul Bleichen's small bottle was not the real one."

"Indeed. The real one was dispatched by the Blonde Woman. I had it copied exactly, and so, as I had some plans concerning other jewels belonging to the countess, and Consul Bleichen was already a suspect, the aforementioned Blonde Woman, so as not to come under suspicion herself, slipped the false diamond into the luggage of the aforesaid consul."

"While you kept the real one."

"Of course."

"And that's the diamond I'm after."

"That's impossible. I'm awfully sorry."

"I promised it to the Countess de Crozon. And I shall get it."

"How will you be able to, since it's in my possession?"

"I shall get it precisely *because* it is in your possession."

"I'll just give it to you then?"

"Yes."

"Willingly?"

"I shall buy it off you."

Lupin had a fit of mirth.

"You are really typical of your country. You treat it as business deal."

"It is a business deal."

"And what are you offering me?"

"Mlle Destange's freedom."

"Her freedom? But I am not aware that she has been arrested."

"I shall provide Monsieur Ganimard with the necessary information."

Deprived of your protection, she will also be caught.”

Lupin guffawed again.

“My dear sir, you offer me that which you do not possess. Mademoiselle Destange is in a safe place and has nothing to fear. I must ask for something else.”

The Englishman hesitated, visibly embarrassed, and a little red around the cheeks. Then, quickly, he put his hand on his opponent’s shoulder.

“And if I offered...”

“My freedom?”

“No... but I could just go out of this room, and consult with Monsieur Ganimard.”

“And leave me to think things over?”

“Yes.”

“Oh God, and how would that help me? This damned mechanism doesn’t work any more,” said Lupin, pushing irritably the moulding of the fireplace.

He stifled a cry of amazement: this time, as chance would have it, by an unhopd-for twist of fate, the block of marble had moved at the touch of his fingers.

It meant salvation, and possible escape. In this case, why should he submit to Sholmes’s conditions?

He walked to and fro, as if mulling over his response. Now it was his turn to put his hand on the Englishman’s shoulder.

“All things considered, Mr Sholmes, I prefer to deal with my little business affairs alone.”

“Yet—”

“No, I don’t need anyone else.”

“When Ganimard catches you, it’ll all be over. They won’t let you go.”

“Who knows!”

“Look, it’s madness. All the exits are covered.”

“There’s one other.”

“Which?”

“*The one that I shall choose.*”

“Mere words! Your arrest is as good as done.”

“It isn’t.”

“And so?”

“So I’ll keep the blue diamond.”

Sholmes pulled out his watch.

“It’s ten to three. At three o’clock I’ll call Ganimard.”

“So we have ten minutes ahead of us to have a chat. Let’s take advantage of it, Mr Sholmes, and to satisfy the curiosity which consumes me, tell me how you acquired my address and my name Félix Davey.”

While observing Lupin attentively, whose good mood worried him, Sholmes willingly took part in such a little explanation which contributed something to his self-esteem, and he continued:

“Your address? I got it from the Blonde Woman.”

“Clotilde!”

“The very person. Do you recall... yesterday morning... when I wanted to take her away in a car, and she telephoned her dressmaker?”

“Indeed.”

“Well, I understood later that the dressmaker was you. And on the boat, that night, by an effort of memory, which is perhaps one of the things which I can permit myself to be vain about, I managed to reconstruct the two last numbers of your telephone number... 73. So that, as I was in possession of the list of houses ‘modified’ by you, it was easy, after my arrival in Paris this morning, at eleven o’clock, to look for and find the name and address of Monsieur Félix Davey in the telephone directory. Once I knew this name and this address, I sought the help of Monsieur Ganimard.”

“Admirable! First rate! I can only bow in respect to you. But what I don’t grasp is how you took the train from Le Havre. How did you manage to escape from the *Hirondelle*?”

“I didn’t escape.”

“But...”

“You ordered the captain not to arrive at Southampton until one o’clock in the morning. They put me ashore at midnight. So that I was able to catch the ship to Le Havre.”

“So the captain betrayed me? That’s intolerable.”

“He didn’t betray you.”

“Then what?”

“It was his watch.”

“His watch?”

“Yes, his watch, which was going fast by one hour.”

“How?”

“The way you make a watch go forward, by turning the winder. We were chatting, sitting next to each other, and I was telling some stories which he found interesting... God, he didn’t notice a thing.”

“Well done, well done, that’s a good trick! I’ll remember it. But what about the clock which was hanging on the bulkhead of the cabin?”

“Oh, the clock! That was more difficult, because my legs were tied, but the sailor who was guarding me when the captain wasn’t there gave a shove to the hands.”

“He did? Come on... He just agreed to do it?”

“Oh, he didn’t understand the importance of his action! I told him that at all costs I had to get the first train to London, and... he let himself be persuaded.”

“In return for what?”

“In return for a little gift... which, moreover, the excellent fellow intends to loyally pass on to you.”

“Which gift?”

“Nothing special.”

“But what then?”

“The blue diamond.”

“The blue diamond!”

“Yes, the false one, the one you substituted for the countess’s diamond, and which she entrusted to me.”

There was a sudden outburst of laughter, like a storm bursting. Lupin went into raptures, his eyes moist with tears.

“God, that’s funny! My false diamond handed over to the sailor! And the captain’s watch! And the hands on the clock!...”

Never before had Sholmes felt the conflict between them to be so intense. With his remarkable instinct, he could guess that beneath this excessive cheerfulness, there was tremendous concentration of thought, as though gathering together all his faculties.

Gradually Lupin had moved towards him. The Englishman moved back and, absent-mindedly, slipped his fingers into his fob-watch pocket.

“It’s three o’clock, Monsieur Lupin.”

“Three o’clock already? What a pity!... We were enjoying ourselves so

much!”

“I’m waiting for your reply.”

“My reply? God, how demanding you are! Very well then, the little game we’re playing is over. And what’s at stake is my freedom.”

“Or the blue diamond.”

“Right... You play first. What are you putting down?”

“I’ll show the king,” said Sholmes, firing a shot with his revolver.

“And I score one *point*,” retorted Arsène, shooting his fist out at the Englishman.

Sholmes had shot into the air, to give a signal to Ganimard, whose intervention he now felt to be urgently needed. But Arsène’s fist had struck him right in the stomach, and Sholmes went pale and staggered. With one bound Lupin reached the fireplace, and the marble plate was already moving... but it was too late! The door opened.

Ganimard, who was no doubt stationed nearer than Lupin thought, was there, with ten or twenty men jostling each other, sturdy strapping men without scruples, who would have struck him down as if he were a dog at the least sign of resistance.

He made a gesture, very calmly.

“Lower your hands! I give up.”

And he crossed his hands over his chest.

They were all dumbfounded. In the room stripped of its furniture and its draperies, Arsène Lupin’s words resounded like an echo: “I give up”. Unbelievable words! They expected that he would suddenly vanish through a trap door, or that a panel in the wall would collapse before him and that once more he would hide himself away from his attackers. But he gave himself up!

Ganimard moved forward and, very touched, and with all the gravity that such an act entailed, he stretched out his hand towards his opponent, and he had the infinite pleasure of saying:

“I arrest you, Lupin.”

“Brr!” Lupin shuddered. “You impress me, Ganimard, old chap. What a mournful expression! One would think you were speaking over a friend’s grave. Don’t look so gloomy.”

“I arrest you.”

“And that amazes you? In the name of the law, of which he is the faithful executor, Ganimard, the chief inspector, arrests the nasty Lupin. A historic moment, the extreme importance of which you have grasped... and it is the second time that such an event has occurred. Well done, Ganimard, you will go far in your career!”

And he presented his wrists to be handcuffed.

It was an event which was conducted in a rather solemn manner. The officers, in spite of their usual brusqueness and the fierceness of their resentment against Lupin, acted in a reserved manner, surprised at being allowed to touch this inviolable being.

“My poor Lupin,” he sighed, “what would your friends in the elegant suburbs say if they saw you humiliated in this way?”

He parted his wrists with a continuous and increasing effort of all his muscles. The veins on his forehead swelled up. The links in the chain penetrated into his skin.

“Let’s go,” he said.

The chain came off: it was broken.

“Another one please, my friend. This one’s no good.”

He was given two pairs. He approved of them.

“Well done! You cannot be too careful.”

Then, counting the officers, he said:

“How many of you are there, my friends? Twenty-five? Thirty? That’s a lot... Well, nothing we can do about it. Oh, if there had only been fifteen of you!”

He really has style, the style of the great actor who plays his role from instinct and with eloquence, with impertinence and lightness. Sholmes looked at him as one watches a good show, appreciating all the flourishes and nuances. And he really had the strange impression that the struggle was an equal one between these thirty men, on the one side, supported by the formidable apparatus of justice, and, on the other side, this single person, unarmed and in chains. The two sides were equal.

“Well, Maestro,” Lupin said to him, “this is your work. Thanks to you, Lupin is going to rot on damp straw in a dungeon. Won’t you admit that your conscience is not completely clear, and that remorse is gnawing at you?”

In spite of himself, the Englishman shrugged his shoulders, as if to say:

“It’s up to you.”

“Never! Never!” exclaimed Lupin. “Hand over the blue diamond? Oh no, it has cost me too much trouble already. I insist. At the time of the first visit I shall have the honour of making to you in London, probably next month, I shall tell you the reasons why... But will you be in London next month? Do you prefer Vienna? St Petersburg?”

He started. Suddenly there was a sound coming from the ceiling. And it was not the alarm bell, but the ringing of the telephone, the leads of which ended up in his office, between the two windows, from where the receiver had not yet been removed.

The telephone! Oh, who was going to fall into the trap provided by this horrible coincidence? Arsène Lupin reacted with rage against the instrument, as if he would have broken it, smashed it to bits, and by this means have smothered the mysterious voice which asked to speak to him. But Ganimard picked up the receiver and bent over it.

“Hello... hello... this is 64873... yes, this is it.”

Swiftly, and authoritatively, Sholmes pushed him aside, seized the two receivers and placed his handkerchief on the cap to make the sound of his voice more indistinct.

At the same moment he raised his eyes to Lupin. And the look they exchanged revealed to them that the same thought had struck them both, and that both of them could foretell what would be the ultimate consequences of this possible, probable and indeed almost certain hypothesis: that it was the Blonde Woman who was calling. She thought she was calling Félix Davey, or rather Maxime Bermond, and it was Sholmes that she was going to confide in.

The Englishman chanted:

“Hello... Hello!...”

There was a silence, and Sholmes said:

“Yes, it’s me, Maxime.”

Suddenly the drama was taking shape, with a tragic precision. Lupin, the indomitable and mocking Lupin, did not even think of hiding his anxiety and, his face pale with anguish, he forced himself to listen, and to guess what was being said. Sholmes continued, in reply to the mysterious voice:

“Hello... Hello... Yes of course, everything is finished, and I’m getting ready at the moment to join you, as agreed... Where?... But at the place

where you are. Don't you think that it's..."

He hesitated, trying find the right words, and then he stopped. It was clear that he was trying to question the young woman without giving away too much himself, and that he had absolutely no idea where she was. What is more, Ganimard's presence seemed to embarrass... Oh, if only some miracle had been able to cut the line of the devilish conversation! Lupin was appealing with all his strength and his nerves tense.

And Sholmes said:

"Hello! Hello!... Can't you hear me?... No I can't either... very bad... I can hardly make out... Are you listening?... Fine, all right... When I think about it... it would be better if you went back to your house... What danger? None... But he's in England! I got a telegram from Southampton, confirming his arrival."

The irony of these words! Sholmes uttered them with an inexpressible sense of well-being. And he added:

"And so, don't waste time, my dear. I'll join you soon."

He hung up the receiver.

"Monsieur Ganimard, I want you to let me have three of your men."

"It's for the Blonde Woman, isn't it?"

"Yes."

"You know who it is, and where she is?"

"Yes."

"My God! What a great catch! With Lupin... What a great day! Folenfant, take two men and accompany this gentleman."

The Englishman went away, followed by the three officers.

It was over. The Blonde Woman was also going to succumb to the power of Sholmes. Thanks to his admirable stubbornness, thanks to the coming-together of fortunate circumstances, the fight was ending in victory for him, and for Lupin in irreparable disaster.

"Mr Sholmes!"

The Englishman stopped.

"Monsieur Lupin?"

Lupin seemed to be deeply shaken by this last blow. Wrinkles furrowed his brow. He was weary and grim. However, he recovered with a sudden burst of energy. And in spite of everything, in a light-hearted and casual way, he exclaimed:

“You will admit that fate hounds me down. Just now it prevented me from escaping through this fireplace and handed me over to you. This time it has used the telephone to make you a gift of the Blonde Woman. I yield to its orders.”

“Which means?”

“Which means that I am ready to reopen negotiations.”

Sholmes took the inspector aside and sought, in a tone moreover which did not permit any rejoinder, the authority to exchange a few words with Lupin. Then he came back to Lupin. It was a remarkable discussion! He began in a curt and nervous tone.

“What do you want?”

“The freedom of Mademoiselle Destange.”

“You know the price?”

“Yes.”

“And you accept?”

“I accept all your conditions.”

“Ah!...” said the Englishman, surprised. “But... you refused... for you...”

“It concerned me, Mr Sholmes, but now it concerns a woman... and a woman I love. In France, you see, we have special ideas about such things. And because a man is called Lupin, it does not mean that he will behave any differently... on the contrary!”

He said this very calmly. Sholmes inclined his head imperceptibly and murmured:

“So, what about the blue diamond?”

“Please fetch my cane, there, at the corner of the fireplace. Grip the pommel with one hand, and, with the other, turn the iron ferrule at the opposite end of the stick.”

Sholmes fetched the cane and turned the ferrule, and as he was turning it, he noticed that the pommel unscrewed. Inside the pommel was a ball of putty. And inside this ball was the diamond.

He examined it. It was the blue diamond.

“Mademoiselle Destange is free, Monsieur Lupin.”

“Free in the future as well as in the present? She has nothing to fear from you?”

“Nor from anyone else.”

“Whatever happens?”

“Whatever happens. I no longer know her name nor her address.”

“Thank you. And *au revoir*. For we shall meet again, shan’t we, Mr Sholmes?”

“I’ve no doubt about it.”

Between the Englishman and Ganimard there was quite an agitated discussion, which Sholmes cut short rather abruptly.

“I regret very much, Monsieur Ganimard, that I do not share your opinion. But I do not have time to convince you. I am leaving for England in an hour.”

“But... what of the Blonde Woman?”

“I do not know such a person.”

“We only have a moment...”

“Take it or leave it... I have already handed over Lupin to you. Here’s the blue diamond... which you will have the pleasure of returning yourself to the Countess de Crozon. It seems to me that you have nothing to complain about.”

“But what about the Blonde Woman?”

“Go and find her.”

He stuck his hat on his head and went off quickly, like a gentleman who is not accustomed to linger when his business is done.

“*Bon voyage*, Maestro,” Lupin shouted. “And please believe me when I say that I’ll never forget the cordial relations which we enjoyed together. Kindest regards to Mr Wilson.”

He did not get a reply, and he chuckled:

“That’s what’s called taking your leave the English way.¹ Oh, that dignified insular race does not possess that bloom of courtesy by which we are distinguished. Just think, Ganimard, of the departure which a Frenchman would have performed in similar circumstances! Behind what refinements of politeness he would have concealed his triumph!... But, God forgive me, Ganimard, what are you doing? Oh very well, a search. But there’s nothing left, old chap, not a piece of paper. My archives are in a safe place.”

“Who knows? Who knows?”

Lupin became resigned. Held by two inspectors and surrounded by all

the others, he observed patiently the various activities. But after twenty minutes he sighed:

“Quickly, Ganimard, you’ll never finish.”

“Are you in a hurry?”

“Yes, I’m in a hurry! I have an urgent appointment!”

“In the police cells?”

“No, in the city.”

“Huh! At what time?”

“Two o’clock.”

“It’s three o’clock.”

“Exactly. I shall be late, and there’s nothing I detest so much as being late.”

“Will you give me just five minutes?”

“Not one minute longer.”

“You’re too kind... I’ll do my best.”

“Don’t talk so much... What, that cupboard again?... But it’s empty.”

“Yet, here’s some letters.”

“Just old bills.”

“No, here’s a package tied up with a ribbon.”

“Pink ribbon? Oh, Ganimard, don’t undo it, for Heaven’s sake!”

“It’s from a woman!”

“Yes.”

“A society woman?”

“Of the best society.”

“And her name?”

“Madame Ganimard.”

“Very amusing! Very amusing!” exclaimed the inspector, tight-lipped.

At that moment, two men sent to look in the other rooms announced that their searches had produced no results. Lupin started to laugh.

“For God’s sake! Did you expect to discover a list of my friends or proof of my relations with the German Kaiser? What you should be looking for, Ganimard, are the little mysteries of this apartment. Such as this gas pipe, which is an acoustic pipe. This fireplace contains a staircase. This wall is hollow. And the labyrinth of bells! Here, Ganimard, press this button.”

Ganimard obeyed.

“Can’t you hear anything?” asked Lupin.

“No.”

“Neither can I. But you have just alerted the commander of my aerostatic fleet to prepare the dirigible which will carry us off soon up into the air.”

“Come on,” said Ganimard, who had finished his inspection, “enough of such nonsense. Let’s go!”

He went a few steps and his men followed him.

Lupin did not move an inch.

His guards pushed him, but it was in vain.

“So,” said Ganimard, “you refuse to come?”

“Not at all.”

“In that case...”

“But it depends...”

“On what?”

“On where you are taking me?”

“To the police cells, for Heaven’s sake.”

“In that case I’m not going. I’ve got no business to deal with in the prison cells.”

“Are you mad?”

“Didn’t I respectfully inform you that that I have an urgent appointment?”

“Lupin!”

“What, Ganimard? The Blonde Woman is expecting me to call on her, and you assume that I am rude enough to leave her in a state of anxiety? That would be unworthy of a gallant gentleman.”

“Listen, Lupin,” said the inspector, who was beginning to be irritated by this mocking behaviour, “up till now I have had excessive consideration for you. But there are limits. Follow me.”

“Impossible. I have an appointment, and I shall keep that appointment.”

“One last time?”

“Im-pos-sible.”

Ganimard gave a sign. Two men lifted Lupin under his arms. But they let him go immediately with groans of pain: with both hands Arsène Lupin thrust two long needles into their flesh.

Mad with rage, the others pounced on him, their hatred finally roused, longing to avenge their colleagues and to take revenge for so many insults to themselves. They hit him and beat him up over and over again. One

more violent blow hit him on the temple.

"If you injure him," Ganimard growled furiously, "you'll have to answer to me."

He bent over, ready to tend to him. But having confirmed that he was still breathing freely, he ordered him to be taken by the feet and head, while he himself would support him by holding the small of his back.

"Above all, go gently! Don't jolt him... Oh, those brutes, they could have killed him. Hey, Lupin, how are you?"

Lupin opened his eyes. He mumbled:

"Not great, Ganimard... You let them really beat me up."

"It's your own fault, for goodness' sake... due to your stubbornness!" replied Ganimard, feeling sorry for him. "But you're not in any pain are you?"

They reached the landing. Lupin moaned:

"Ganimard... the lift... they'll break my bones..."

"A good idea, a great idea," said Ganimard approvingly. Besides, the staircase is so narrow... There would be no way to..."

They had the lift come up, and placed Lupin on the seat, taking all sorts of precautions. Ganimard sat down next to him and said to his men:

"Go down as we go down. And wait by the concierge's lodge. Agreed?"

He pulled the door to. But before it was closed some cries rang out. With a sudden jerk, the lift had gone up like a balloon from which the cable has been cut. A burst of sardonic laughter rang out.

"Good G..." yelled Ganimard, searching frantically in the darkness for the button to make it go down.

And as he could not find it, he shouted out:

"Go to the fifth floor! Watch by the door on the fifth floor!"

The officers climbed the stairs four at a time. But something strange happened: the lift seemed to burst through the ceiling on the top floor, and disappeared from the officers' sight, emerging suddenly one floor higher, where the servants lived, and then it stopped. Three men were watching to see who would open the door. Two of them overcame Ganimard, who, restricted in his movements, and stunned, scarcely gave any thought to defending himself. The third brought out Lupin.

"I warned you about it, Ganimard... being carried off in a balloon... and thanks to you! Another time be more compassionate. And, above all,

remember that Arsène Lupin does not let himself be beaten and thwarted without very good reasons. Farewell..."

The cabin had already been closed again and the lift, with Ganimard in it, was sent back down to the lower floors. And all this was carried out so quickly that the old detective caught up with the officers next to the concierge's lodge.

Without even having to be told to, they hurried across the yard and went up the backstairs, which was the only way to reach the servants' floor from where the escape had been effected.

A long corridor with many turns and lined with small numbered rooms led to a door, which they had simply pushed back. Beyond this door, and therefore in another house, there ran another corridor, also with many turns and lined with similar rooms. At the far end were the backstairs. Ganimard went down it and across a yard, through a hallway and dashed out into a street, the Rue Picot. Now he understood: the two houses, set deeply in the ground, were connected, and their façades looked out on two streets, not at all at right angles, but parallel to each other, more than sixty metres apart.

He went into the concierge's lodge and, showing his card, said:

"Did four men come past here?"

"Yes, the two servants for the fourth and fifth floors, with two friends."

"Who lives in the fourth and fifth floors?"

"The Fauvel gentlemen and their cousins, the Provosts... They moved out this morning. Only the two servants are left... and they've just gone out."

"Ah!" thought Ganimard, who collapsed on a sofa in the lodge. "What a failure! The whole gang was living in this block of houses."

Forty minutes later, two gentlemen arrived by car at the Gare du Nord, and hurried towards the Calais express, followed by a porter who was carrying their cases.

One of them had his arm in a sling, and from his pale face he did not seem to be in good health. The other seemed to be cheerful.

"Hurry up, Wilson. There's no way we should let ourselves miss the train... Ah, Wilson, I shall never forget these ten days."

"Neither will I."

"Oh, such great battles!"

“Superb ones!”

“Barely a few small problems, here and there.”

“Really small ones.”

“And finally, triumph across the board. Lupin arrested! And the blue diamond recovered.”

“And my arm broken.”

“When it’s a question of such rewards, what does one broken arm matter?”

“Especially mine.”

“Oh, yes! Do you remember, Wilson, that moment when you were in the chemist’s, while you were suffering like a hero, I discovered the thread which led me through the darkness.”

“What good luck it was!”

The doors were closing.

“All aboard, please. Hurry up, gentlemen.”

The porter climbed the steps to an empty compartment and arranged the cases in the rack, while Sholmes hoisted up the unfortunate Wilson.

“But what’s wrong with you, Wilson? You’ll never manage it! Have courage, my old friend!”

“It’s not courage that I lack.”

“Then what is it?”

“I’ve only got the use of one hand.”

“So what?” exclaimed Sholmes cheerfully. “What a fuss! You’d think you were the only person in such a condition! What about one-armed men? Real one-armed men. Come on, is that all that’s wrong? It’s no great harm!”

He gave the porter a fifty-centimes coin.

“Well done, my friend. This is for you.”

“Thank you, Mr Sholmes.”

The Englishman raised his eyes: it was Arsène Lupin.

“You!... You!...” he mumbled in amazement.

And Wilson stammered, making gestures with his one free hand, as though confirming the fact:

“You! You! But you were arrested! Sholmes told me. When he left you, Ganimard and his twenty officers surrounded you...”

Lupin crossed his arms and, with an indignant air, said:

“So you assumed that I would let you depart without saying goodbye? After the excellent friendly relations we have never ceased to have with each other! That would be the final act of impropriety. What do you take me for?”

The train’s whistle blew.

“Still, I forgive you... But have you got everything you need? Tobacco, matches... oh yes and the evening papers? You’ll find details in them of my arrest, your latest exploit, Maestro. And now, *au revoir*, and I’m delighted to have made your acquaintance... really delighted... And if you ever have need of me, I would be more than happy...”

He jumped down onto the platform and closed the door.

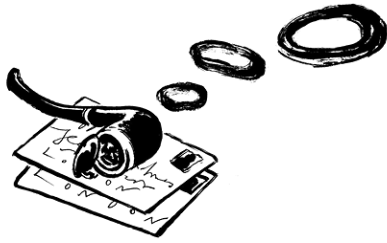
“Farewell,” he said again, waving his handkerchief. Farewell... I’ll write... And you will too, won’t you? And you will let me know how your broken arm is, Mr Wilson? I expect to hear news from both of you... a postcard from time to time... My address: Lupin, Paris... that’s enough... No need to put a stamp on it... Farewell... See you soon!”

1 taking your leave the English way: A translation of *filer à l’anglaise*, the French equivalent of the English expression “French leave” – meaning to leave without saying goodbye.

Episode Two

THE JEWISH LAMP

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HERLOCK SHOLMES AND WILSON were sitting either side of the great fireplace, with their legs stretched out towards a comfortable coke fire.

Sholmes's pipe, a short briar with a silver ferrule, went out. He emptied the ashes, and filled it again, lit it, gathered up on his knees the tails of his dressing gown and emitted from his pipe long puffs, which he endeavoured to launch at the ceiling in small rings of smoke.

Wilson was watching him. He watched him as a dog curled up on the hearthrug watches its master, without batting its eyelids, and with its big round eyes hoping only to reflect an expected gesture. Would the master break the silence? Would he reveal the secret of his present rumination and allow him into the realm of his meditation, entry into which seemed to be forbidden to Wilson.

Sholmes remained silent.

Wilson took a chance.

"These are very quiet times. No case to get our teeth into."

Sholmes was becoming more and more determined to keep silent, but the smoke rings were becoming more and more successful, and any other person than Wilson would have noticed that he was drawing from them that profound satisfaction which such small successes of self-esteem give us, at times when our brains are completely void of thought.

Discouraged, Wilson got up and went to the window.

The dreary street stretched away between the gloomy fronts of the houses, under a black sky from which nasty rain beat down furiously. A cab went by, and then another one. Wilson wrote down the numbers in his notebook. One never knows.

"Look!" he exclaimed. "The postman."

The man came in, led by the servant.

"Two registered letters, sir... if you wouldn't mind signing?"

Sholmes signed the register, and accompanied the man to the door. He came back, unsealing one of the letters.

"You look very happy," commented Wilson after a few moments.

"This letter contains an extremely interesting proposal. You were crying

out for a case, well, here is one. Read it.”

Wilson read it:

“Sir,

“I’m turning to you to ask for your help based on your experience. I have been the victim of a serious crime, and the investigations carried out so far do not seem to be leading anywhere.

“I am sending to you with this post a certain number of newspapers which will inform you about the case, and, if it is agreeable to you to pursue the matter, I put my house at your disposal and request you to inscribe on the enclosed cheque, which I have signed, the sum which you consider suitable to cover your travel expenses.

“Please be so kind as to telegraph your response, and please be assured, sir, of my highest esteem.

“Baron Victor d’Imblevalle, 18 Rue Murillo.”

“Aha!” cried Sholmes. “This looks like something really promising! A little trip to Paris. My God, why not? Since my famous duel with Arsène Lupin, I haven’t had a chance to go back there. I wouldn’t be averse to seeing the capital of the world in conditions which are a little more peaceful.”

He tore up the cheque into four pieces, and while Wilson, whose arm had not recovered its former flexibility, was expressing a few bitter words about Paris, he opened the second envelope.

Suddenly a reaction of irritation escaped him, a crease appeared across his brow throughout his reading and, crumpling up the piece of paper, he made into a ball and threw it violently onto the parquet floor.

“What is it? What’s wrong?” exclaimed Wilson in alarm.

He picked up the ball of paper, unfolded it and read it with growing astonishment:

“Dear Maestro,

“You know the admiration I have for you and the interest I take in your reputation. Well, please believe me that you should not concern yourself about the case in which your collaboration is being sought. Your intervention would cause a lot of trouble, and all your efforts would lead to a pathetic result. You would be obliged to make a public admission of your failure.

“Being profoundly anxious to save you such humiliation, I beg you, in

the name of the friendship which unites us, to stay calmly by your fireside.

"Please remember me to Mr Wilson, and please accept, dear Maestro, the respectful homage of your devoted

"Arsène Lupin."

"Arsène Lupin," repeated Wilson, staggered.

Sholmes started striking the table with his fists.

"Oh, that creature is really starting to annoy me! He makes fun of me as if I were a child! Public admission of my failure! Didn't I compel him to return the blue diamond?"

"He's afraid," put in Wilson.

"You're talking rubbish! Arsène Lupin never feels afraid, and the proof of it is that he's provoking me."

"But how does he know about the letter that was sent to us by Baron d'Imblevalle?"

"How do I know? You're asking me stupid questions, my dear friend."

"I thought... I imagined..."

"What? That I'm a wizard?"

"No, but I've seen you work such wonders!"

"Nobody can work wonders... I no more than others. I think about things, I deduce, and I draw conclusions, but I'm not psychic! Only idiots think they can divine things!"

Wilson adopted the humble manner of defeated dog, and tried hard, so as not to be an idiot, not to guess why Sholmes was pacing up and down the room in big irritated strides. But as Sholmes had rung for the servant and ordered him to bring his case, Wilson thought he was entitled, as this constituted tangible evidence, to reflect, deduce and conclude that the master was going on a voyage.

The same mental process permitted him to assert, without any fear of being wrong:

"Herlock, you are going to Paris."

"Possibly."

"Herlock, I'm coming with you."

"Oh, my old friend," exclaimed Sholmes, interrupting his walk, "aren't you afraid that your left arm will suffer the same fate as your right arm?"

“What could possibly happen to me? You will be there.”

“Splendid, you’re a good chap! And we’ll show this gentleman that it’s probably wrong for him to throw down the gauntlet with such cheek. Quick, Wilson, let’s get the first train.”

“Without waiting for the newspapers which the baron said he’s sent to you?”

“What’s the point?”

“Shall I send a telegram?”

“That would be useless, and Arsène Lupin would learn of my arrival. No, I don’t think we should. This time, Wilson, we can’t take any chances.”

In the afternoon the two friends embarked at Dover. The crossing was excellent. In the express from Calais to Paris, Sholmes allowed himself to sleep very deeply for three hours, while Wilson kept a good watch on the compartment door and pondered things over, with a faraway look in his eyes.

Sholmes woke up happy and fresh. The prospect of a new duel with Arsène Lupin delighted him, and he rubbed his hands with the satisfied air of a man who is preparing to enjoy numerous pleasures.

“At last,” exclaimed Wilson, “we’ll be able to unwind.”

And he rubbed his hands together with the same air of satisfaction.

At the station, Sholmes took their tartan rugs and, followed by Wilson, who was carrying the cases – each to his own burden – he handed over the tickets and went out joyfully.

“What good weather, Wilson!... Look at the sun!... Paris is in a festive mood for our arrival.”

“What a crowd!”

“So much the better, Wilson! There’s no chance of us being recognized. Nobody will recognize us in the middle of such a multitude!”

“It’s Mr Sholmes, isn’t it?”

He stopped, a little bit taken aback. Who the devil could identify him by name like that?”

A woman was standing next to them, a young woman, whose very simple mode of dress emphasized her distinguished figure, and whose pretty face bore a worried and sorrowful expression.

She repeated:

“You are Mr Sholmes, aren’t you?”

As he remained silent, as much out of confusion as his customary prudence, she repeated her question a third time:

“It is Mr Sholmes with whom I have the honour of speaking, isn’t it?”

“What do you want of me?” he said, quite gruffly, considering this to be a dubious encounter.

She stood in front of him.

“I know... I know... Rue Murillo... number 18. Well, you shouldn’t... no, you mustn’t go there... I can assure you that you will regret it. And when I say this, please don’t think that I have some sort of interest in the matter. I do it for a reason and in good conscience.”

He tried to push her aside, but she insisted:

“Oh, I beg you, do not persist... Oh, if only I knew how to convince you! Look deep within me, deep into my eyes... they are sincere... they tell the truth.”

She looked at him in a frantic way, with beautiful, serious and clear eyes, in which her very soul seemed to be reflected. Wilson nodded his head:

“The young lady seems to be quite sincere.”

“Yes indeed,” she implored, “and you must trust me...”

“I trust you, Mademoiselle,” replied Wilson.

“Oh, how happy that makes me. And your friend as well, also trusts me, doesn’t he? I sense it... I feel sure of it! Oh I’m so happy! Everything will be all right!... What a good idea it was of mine!... Well, there’s a train for Calais in twenty minutes... so you can catch it... Quickly, follow me... the track is on this side, and you only just have time...”

She tried to drag him away. Sholmes grasped her by the arm and, in a voice which he tried to make as gentle as possible, he said:

“Excuse me, Mademoiselle, for not being able to accede to your wish, but I never give up a task once I’ve undertaken to do it.”

“I beg you... I beg you... oh, if only you would understand!”

He took no notice and moved away quickly.

Wilson said to the young woman:

“You should have high hopes. He will pursue the case to the very end... He’s never failed on any occasion.”

And he ran after Sholmes to catch up with him.

The following words, which stood out in big black letters, struck them forcibly as soon as they set off:

HERLOCK SHOLMES – ARSÈNE LUPIN

They went towards them: a procession of sandwich-board men were wandering along, one behind the other, carrying heavy iron-tipped canes in their hands, with which they struck the pavement rhythmically, and on their backs there were enormous placards on which the following could be read:

THE MATCH BETWEEN HERLOCK SHOLMES – ARSÈNE LUPIN.
THE ARRIVAL OF THE ENGLISH CHAMPION. THE GREAT
DETECTIVE TACKLES THE MYSTERY OF RUE MURILLO. READ
THE DETAILS IN *L'ÉCHO DE FRANCE*.

Wilson shook his head:

“I say, Herlock, we were priding ourselves on travelling incognito! I wouldn’t be surprised if the Republican Guard were waiting for us at Rue Murillo, and there was an official reception with toasts and champagne.”

“When you start to be witty, Wilson, you are worth twice as much,” said Sholmes with a cringe.

He went towards one of the men with the clear intention of grabbing him with his powerful hands and smashing both him and his placard to bits. But a crowd was gathering round the notices, making jokes and laughing.

Suppressing a terrible fit of rage, he said to the man:

“When were you hired?”

“This morning.”

“And when did you start your procession?”

“An hour ago.”

“And the placards were already prepared?”

“Good Heavens, yes... When we came to the agency this morning, they were already there.”

And so, Arsène Lupin, had foreseen that he, Sholmes would agree to the fight. What is more, the letter written by Lupin proved that he wanted this fight, and that he was making plans to pit his strength against his rival one more time. Why? What motive drove him to take up the conflict again?

Herlock hesitated for a second. It must mean that Lupin was very sure of victory for him to show such insolence, and wouldn’t it mean that he was

falling into a trap by rushing off like this at the first summons?

“Let’s go, Wilson. Cabbie! 18 Rue Murillo,” he shouted with a resurgence of energy.

And with his veins swollen, his fists tight as if he was going to engage in a boxing match, he leapt into the car.

The Rue Murillo is lined with luxurious town houses, the rear façades of which look onto the Parc Monceau. One of the most beautiful of them stands at number 18, and Baron d’Imbleville, who lives there with his wife and children, furnished it in the most sumptuous style, becoming to an artist and millionaire. There is a main courtyard in front of the house, and outbuildings line it on the right and on the left. At the rear there is a garden that mingles its branches with those of the park.

After having rung the bell, the two Englishmen went across the courtyard and were received by a footman who led them into a small drawing room situated on the other side.

They sat down and took a quick look round, to examine the valuable objects which cluttered up the boudoir.

“Pretty things,” murmured Wilson, “tasteful and imaginative. One can conclude that the people who have the leisure to acquire these objects are of a certain age... fifty years old perhaps...”

He did not finish. The door had opened, and M. d’Imbleville came in, followed by his wife.

Contrary to the deductions made by Wilson, they were both young, elegantly turned out and very lively, both in their appearance and in their way of speaking. They both thanked their guests profusely.

“It’s really too good of you! To go to such inconvenience! We are almost glad of the trouble we have had, since it has given us the pleasure...”

“What charming people these French are!” thought Wilson, who was not averse to a profound observation.

“But time is money,” exclaimed the baron, “yours above all, Mr Sholmes. So, straight to the point. What do you think of this case? Do you think you can bring it to a successful conclusion?”

“To bring it to a successful conclusion, it would be necessary first to be familiar with it.”

“You’re not familiar with it?”

“No, and I must ask you to explain matters to me in detail, without omitting anything. What does it concern?”

“It concerns a theft.”

“What day did it take place?”

“Last Saturday,” replied the baron, “during the night of Saturday to Sunday.”

“That was six days ago. Now I’m listening to you.”

“I should tell you first, sir, that my wife and I, while we live in accordance with the lifestyle that our position requires of us, go out very little. The education of our children, a few receptions, improvements to our home – these are the things which make up our life, and all our evenings, or almost all, are passed here, in this room, which is my wife’s boudoir and where we have gathered together a few objets d’art. Last Saturday, at about eleven o’clock, I switched off the lights, and my wife and I withdrew as usual to our bedroom.”

“Which is situated where?”

“Next to this room, the door which you see there. The following day – that is to say on Sunday – I rose early. As Suzanne – my wife – was still sleeping, I went into this boudoir as quietly as possible so as not to wake her. What was my surprise when I noticed that this window was open, though the previous evening we had had it closed.”

“A servant...”

“Nobody comes in here in the morning until we have rung. Besides, I always take the precaution of pushing the bolt on this second door, which connects with the antechamber. So the window must have been opened from outside. What is more, I have proof of this: the second pane of the right-hand window – next to the catch – had been cut out.”

“And that window?...”

“That window, as you can see, looks out onto a small terrace surrounded by a stone balcony. Here we are on the first floor, and you can see the garden which stretches out behind the house, and the railings which separate it from the Parc Monceau. So that the man must certainly have come from the Parc Monceau, climbed over the railings with the aid of a ladder, and climbed up onto the terrace.”

“Certainly, you said?”

“On either side of the railings, in the soft earth of the flower beds, some

holes were found, which had been left by the two uprights of the ladder, and the same two holes were found below the terrace. Finally there are two light scratches on the balcony, clearly caused by contact with the uprights.”

“Isn’t the Parc Monceau closed at night?”

“It’s not closed but, in any case, at number 14 there’s a house being built. It would have been easy to get in through there.”

Herlock Sholmes thought things over for a few moments and then continued:

“Let us come to the theft. It must have been committed in the room we are in now?”

“Yes. Between that twelfth-century virgin and the chased-silver tabernacle, there was a small Jewish lamp. It has disappeared.”

“And that is all?”

“That’s all.”

“Ah!... And what is this thing you call a Jewish lamp?”

“They’re brass lamps which were used in the past, consisting of a stem and a receptacle in which the oil was put. From this receptacle two or more spouts ran out ending in wicks.”

“All in all, not objects of great value.”

“Indeed of no great value. But this one contained a hiding place where we used to keep a magnificent antique piece of jewellery, a fantastic piece made of gold, and set with rubies and emeralds, and which is of very great value.”

“Why did you use to do that?”

“Well now, I couldn’t rightly say. Perhaps for the simple pleasure of making use of such a hiding place.”

“And nobody else knew about it?”

“Nobody.”

“Except obviously the thief of this fantastic piece,” Sholmes objected, “for without knowing that he wouldn’t have taken the trouble to steal the Jewish lamp.”

“Obviously. But how could he have known about it, since it was only by chance that the secret mechanism of the lamp was revealed to us?”

“It could also have been by chance that it was revealed to someone else... a servant, someone familiar with the house... But let’s continue: have the

authorities been informed?”

“Of course. The examining magistrate has conducted an investigation. The investigative journalists of all the major newspapers have made theirs. But, as I wrote to you, it doesn’t seem that the problem has the least chance of being solved.”

Sholmes stood up, went towards the window, examined the window, the terrace, the balcony, used his magnifying glass to study the two light scratches on the stonework and asked M. d’Imblevalle to take him into the garden.

Outside, Sholmes simply sat down on a wicker chair and looked at the roof of the house in a dreamy way. Then he suddenly walked towards two little wooden boxes, with which, in order to preserve intact the marks, they had covered the holes left at the bottom of the terrace by the uprights of the ladder. He lifted up the boxes, knelt down on the earth and, bent over, with his nose twenty centimetres from the ground, he examined the marks and made some measurements. He conducted the same operations along the railings, but did not take so long.

He was finished.

They returned to the boudoir together, where Mme d’Imblevalle was waiting for them.

Sholmes remained silent for a few more minutes, and then he spoke as follows:

“From the beginning of your account, Monsieur le Baron, I was struck by the very simplicity of the attack. Using a ladder, cutting a window pane, choosing an object and then leaving. No, things don’t happen as easily as that. It’s all too obvious and clear-cut.”

“Which means that?...”

“Which means that the theft of the Jewish lamp must have been committed under the direction of Arsène Lupin...”

“Arsène Lupin!” exclaimed the baron.

“But it was committed without him being there, without anyone entering the house... Perhaps it was a servant who came down from his attic room onto the terrace, down the drainpipe that I saw from the garden.”

“But what proof do you have?”

“Arsène Lupin would never have left the boudoir with empty hands.”

“With empty hands? And what about the lamp?”

“Taking the lamp would not have prevented him from taking this snuffbox set with diamonds, or this necklace of old opals. He would have needed only two extra movements. If he did not carry them out, it was because he was not there to see them.”

“But what about the traces they found?”

“Just a theatrical illusion! Staged to divert suspicion!”

“And the scratches on the parapet?”

“A trick! They were made by sandpaper. Look, here are a few bits of paper that I collected.”

“And the marks left by the uprights of the ladder?”

“A joke! Examine the two rectangular holes at the bottom of the terrace, and the two holes near the railings. Their shape is similar, but while they are parallel here, they aren’t over there. Measure the distance which separates each whole from its neighbour: the gap changes according to where it is. At the bottom of the terrace it is twenty-three centimetres. Along the railings it is twenty-eight centimetres.”

“And what do you conclude from that?”

“I conclude that, since their shapes are identical, the four holes were made by using just one piece of suitably carved wood.”

“The best proof of this would be to produce the piece of wood itself.”

“Here it is,” said Sholmes. “I found it in the garden, under a planter box containing a bay tree.”

The baron bowed. It had been forty minutes since the Englishman had crossed the threshold of the room, and nothing was left of what had been considered, up till then, to be the evidence based on the apparent facts. Now the reality, a different reality, was becoming clear, and was based on something much more solid, the reasoning of Herlock Sholmes.

“The charge you make against our staff is a very serious one, sir,” said the baroness. “Our servants are very old retainers of the family, and none of them is capable of betraying our trust.”

“If one of them did not betray it, then how do you explain the fact that a letter was able to reach me by the same post as the one you wrote to me?”

He held out to the baroness the letter that Arsène Lupin had addressed to him.

Mme d'Imblevalle was astonished.

"Arsène Lupin... How could he have known?"

"You didn't let anyone know about your letter?"

"Nobody," said the baron. "It was an idea we had the other evening at dinner."

"There were only our two children. And even then... no, Sophie and Henriette had left the table, hadn't they, Suzanne?"

Mme d'Imblevalle thought about it and confirmed the fact:

"Indeed, they had joined Mademoiselle."

"Mademoiselle?" asked Sholmes.

"The governess. Mademoiselle Alice Demun."

"This person does not take her meals with you?"

"No, she is served separately, in her room."

Wilson had an idea.

"The letter written to my friend Herlock Sholmes was taken to the post office?"

"Of course."

"And who took it there?"

"Dominique, my valet of twenty years' standing," replied the baron. "All investigations concerning him would be a waste of time."

"It's never a waste of time searching for something," said Wilson sententiously.

The first investigation had been completed. Sholmes asked for permission to withdraw.

One hour later, at dinner, he saw Sophie and Henriette, the two children of the d'Imblevalles, who were two pretty little girls of eight and six years. There was not much conversation. Sholmes replied to the courtesies of the baron and his wife in such an off-putting way that they decided to keep silent. Coffee was served. Sholmes swallowed the contents of his cup and stood up.

At that moment, a servant came in, carrying a telegram addressed to him. He opened it and read:

I send you an expression of my enthusiastic admiration. The results which you have obtained within so short a time are stunning. I am staggered.

Arsène Lupin

He displayed signs of irritation, and he showed the message to the baron:

“Now do you begin to believe that your walls have eyes and ears, Monsieur?”

“I don’t understand it at all,” murmured M. d’Imblevalle, dumbfounded.

“Neither do I. But what I do understand is that not a move is made here without it being noticed by *him*. Not a word is spoken without him hearing it.”

That evening Wilson went to bed with the light conscience of a man who had fulfilled his duty and who has no other concern than to go to sleep. Thus he fell asleep very quickly and was visited by some beautiful dreams, in which he was pursuing Lupin on his own and was about to arrest him single-handedly. The experience of this chase was so enjoyable that he woke up.

Someone was brushing against his bed. He seized his revolver.

“One more move, Lupin, and I’ll shoot.”

“What the devil! You’re really going at it, old friend!”

“What, it’s you, Sholmes! You need me?”

“I need your eyes. Get up.”

He led him towards the window.

“Look... on the other side of the railings...”

“In the park?”

“Yes. Don’t you see anything?”

“I can’t see anything.”

“Yes, you can see something.”

“Ah! Indeed. There’s a shadow... two in fact.”

“That’s right! Against the railings... Wait, they’re moving. We mustn’t waste time.”

Feeling their way along and holding the banister, they went down the stairs, and reached the room which looked out onto the flight of steps leading to the garden. Through the glass panes in the door they could see the two silhouettes in the same place.

“It’s strange,” said Sholmes. “I think I can hear a noise in the house.”

“In the house? Impossible! Everyone’s asleep.”

“But listen...”

At that moment there was the sound of a light whistle from near the railings, and they noticed a vague light coming from the house.

“The d’Imblevalles must have put the lights on,” murmured Sholmes. “It’s their room above us.”

“It must certainly be them that we heard,” said Wilson. “Perhaps they are watching the railings.”

There was a second whistle, much more subdued.

“I don’t understand, I don’t understand,” said Sholmes, annoyed.

“Neither do I,” Wilson confessed.

Sholmes turned the key in the door, pulled back the bolt and gently pushed back the panel of the door.

There was a third whistle, a little louder than the previous one, and modulated differently. And over their heads the noise became more noticeable and faster.

“It makes you think it’s on the terrace rather than in the boudoir,” whispered Sholmes.

He put his head into the gap, but immediately drew back, stifling a curse. Wilson too looked out. Quite close to them, there was a ladder standing against the wall, leaning against the terraced balcony.

“Oh, Good God!” cried Sholmes. “There’s someone in the boudoir! That’s what we heard. Quick. Let’s move the ladder away.”

But at that moment, a shape slipped all the way down, the ladder was taken away, and the man who was carrying it ran as fast as he could towards the railings, to where his accomplices were waiting for him. With one bound Sholmes and Wilson had dashed forward. They caught up with the man as he was placing the ladder against the railings. From the other side two shots rang out.

“Are you wounded?” cried Sholmes.

“No,” replied Wilson.

He grabbed the man round the body and tried to immobilize him. But the man turned round, grabbed hold of him with one hand, and with the other he plunged his knife right into his chest. Wilson breathed a sigh, swayed about and fell down.

“Damn!” yelled Sholmes. “If they’ve killed him, then I’ll kill them.”

He laid Wilson out on the lawn and leapt onto the ladder. Too late... the man had climbed up it and, together with his accomplices, was running

away among the flower beds.

“Wilson, Wilson, it isn’t serious, huh? Just a little scratch.”

The doors of the house opened suddenly. The first to appear was M. d’Imblevalle, followed by the servants armed with candles.

“What is it? What’s wrong?” exclaimed the baron. “Is Mr Wilson wounded?”

“It’s nothing, just a little scratch,” repeated Sholmes, trying to delude himself.

The blood was running down profusely, and his face was deathly pale.

Twenty minutes later, the doctor ascertained that the point of the knife had stopped just four millimetres from his heart.

“Four millimetres from his heart? Wilson is always lucky,” concluded Sholmes, in an envious tone.

“Lucky... lucky...” grumbled the doctor.

“Oh well, with his strong constitution he’ll soon get over it.”

“With six months in bed and two months’ convalescence.”

“No longer?”

“No, unless there are complications.”

“Why the devil do you think there’ll be complications?”

Completely reassured, Sholmes rejoined the baron in the boudoir. This time the mysterious visitor had not been so discreet. He had shamelessly helped himself to the snuffbox set with diamonds, the necklace of opals and, generally, everything that might be found in the pocket of an honest burglar.

The window was still open, one of the panes of glass had been neatly cut out and, as day was breaking, a summary investigation established that the ladder had come from the house under construction, which revealed the way they had come.

“In short,” said M. d’Imblevalle with a certain irony, “it’s an exact copy of the theft of the Jewish lamp.”

“Yes, if one accepts the first version that was established by the authorities.”

“So you still don’t accept it? This second theft doesn’t shake your opinion about the first one?”

“It confirms it, Monsieur.”

“How can I believe you? You have irrefutable proof that tonight’s attack

was carried out by someone from outside, and you persist in maintaining that the Jewish lamp was stolen by someone in our family circle?”

“By someone living in this house.”

“But how do you explain it?”

“I can explain nothing, Monsieur. I can confirm two facts, which have nothing but apparent connections with each other. I can assess them only in isolation, and I am trying to find a link which connects them.”

His conviction seemed to be so profound, and his method of acting was based on such strong grounds, that the baron yielded:

“Very well. We’ll inform the superintendent.”

“On no account!” exclaimed the Englishman sharply. “On no account! I intend to approach those people when I have need of them.”

“But what about the gunshots?...”

“It doesn’t matter!”

“And your friend?”

“My friend is only wounded. Ensure that the doctor keeps quiet about it. I shall take full responsibility for everything relating to the authorities.”

Two days went by, devoid of incident, but during which Sholmes pursued his task with meticulous care and a pride that was exasperated by the memory of that audacious attack, carried out before his very eyes and in spite of his presence, and without his being able to prevent it from succeeding. Tirelessly he searched the house and the garden, held discussions with the servants and spent long periods in the kitchen and the stable. And although he did not gather a single clue that could throw any light on things, he did not lose heart.

“I shall find something,” he thought, “and it’s here that I shall find it. It’s not a matter, as in the case of the Blonde Woman, of going about things in a random way, and of reaching, by ways I am ignorant of, a goal which is unknown to me. This time I am on the very battlefield itself. The enemy is no longer the elusive and invisible Lupin, it is an accomplice of flesh and blood, who lives and moves within the bounds of this house. Just the smallest detail, and I’ll get the full picture.”

This detail, from which he would draw such conclusions with such remarkable ease that the case of the Jewish lamp could be considered to be one of those cases in which his genius as a detective displayed itself

most brilliantly and successfully, was provided for him by a stroke of luck.

On the afternoon of the third day, as he was entering a room above the boudoir, which served as a study for the children, he came upon Henriette, the smallest of the sisters. She was looking for some scissors.

“You know,” she said to Sholmes, “I also made some pieces of paper like that one you received the other evening.”

“The other evening?”

“Yes, at the end of dinner. You received a piece of paper with strips on it... you know, a telegram... well, I can also make them.”

She went out. For anyone else, these words would have meant nothing but the insignificant thoughts of a child, and Sholmes himself listened to them inattentively while continuing his investigation. But suddenly he started to run after the child, whose last phrase suddenly struck him. He caught up with her at the top of the stairs and said:

“So, you also stick strips on pieces of paper?”

Very proudly Henriette announced:

“Of course, I cut words and stick them on.”

“And who showed you that little game?”

“Mademoiselle... my governess... I saw her doing the same thing. She takes words out of newspapers and sticks them...”

“And what does she make out of them?”

“Telegrams, letters, which she sends off.”

Herlock Sholmes went back into the study, oddly intrigued by what had been confided to him, and he tried hard to make some deductions about its import.

There was a bundle of newspapers on the mantelpiece. He unfolded them, and there indeed he could see that some groups of words or lines were missing, which had been removed in a regular and neat way. But he only had to read the words which preceded or succeeded them to confirm that the words which were missing had been cut out randomly with scissors, by Henriette obviously. It was possible that in this bundle of newspapers there was one that Mademoiselle had cut out herself. But how could he be sure of it?

Mechanically, Herlock leafed through the school textbooks piled up on the table, and then some others which were lying on the shelves of a cupboard. And suddenly he uttered a cry of delight. In the corner of the

cupboard, under some piled-up old notebooks, he had found a children's album, an alphabet book decorated with images and, on one of the pages, there was a blank space.

He checked. It was a word list of the names of the days of the week. Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, etc. The word for Saturday was missing. Now, the theft of the Jewish lamp had taken place on a Saturday night.

Herlock experienced that little tightening of the heart that always told him, in the nicest possible way, that he had touched upon the very nub of a mystery. The way that the truth seized hold of him, that feeling of certainty, never misled him.

Feverishly and with confidence he hastened to leaf through the album. A little further on another surprise was awaiting him.

It was a page composed of capital letters, followed by a line of numbers.

Nine of these letters and three of the numbers had been carefully removed. Sholmes wrote them down in his notebook, in the order which they had been in, and obtained the following result:

CDEHNOPRZ-237

"Blast!" he murmured. "At first sight that doesn't seem to be anything very significant."

Would it be possible, by mixing the letters up and using them all, to make one, two or three complete words?

Sholmes tried this in vain.

One single solution became obvious to him, which recurred endlessly as he played around with his pencil, and which in the end appeared to him to be the right one, as much because it corresponded with the logic of the facts as with the general circumstances.

Given that the page in the album contained each of the letters of the alphabet only once, it was likely, indeed certain, that he was faced with incomplete words and that these words had been completed by letters borrowed from other pages. In these circumstances and, if there had not been any mistake, the riddle could be resolved as follows:

REPOND.Z-CH-237

It was clear what the first word was: *répondez*: reply. An E was missing, because the letter E, which had already been used, was no longer available.

As for the second incomplete word, it doubtless made up, together with

the number 237, the address which the sender was giving to the addressee of the letter. It was being suggested at first that they should fix the day as Saturday and a reply was requested to the address: CH-237.

Or perhaps CH-237 referred to a poste-restante number, or the letters CH even formed part of an incomplete word. Sholmes leafed through the album: no other section had been cut out from the following pages. So, until anything else turned up, he would have to leave it at the explanation he had worked out.

“It’s fun, isn’t it?”

Henriette had come back. He replied:

“Yes, it’s fun! But don’t you have any other pieces of paper? Or even some words already cut out that I could stick in?”

“Other pieces of paper? No, and Mademoiselle wouldn’t like it.”

“Mademoiselle?”

“Yes, she already told me off.”

“Why?”

“Because I told you some things... and she said that you should never tell things about people you like a lot.”

“You’re absolutely right.”

Henriette seemed to be delighted with his approval, so delighted that she pulled some things out of a tiny cotton bag, pinned to her dress: a few pieces of cloth, three buttons, two pieces of sugar and, finally, a square piece of paper, which she held out to Sholmes.

“Here, I’ll give it to you anyway.”

It was the number of a cab: 8279.

“Where did you get this number?”

“It fell out of her purse.”

“When?”

“On Sunday, at the Mass, as she was taking out some sous for the collection.”

“Perfect! And now I’ll tell you how to avoid being told off. Don’t tell Mademoiselle that you have seen me.”

Sholmes went to find M. d’Imblevalle and questioned him closely about Mademoiselle.

The baron started.

“Alice Demun! Could you possibly think?... It’s impossible.”

“How long has she been in your service?”

“Only one year, but I don’t know anyone more well-behaved than her and whom I trust more.”

“How is it that I have not seen her yet?”

“She went away for a few days.”

“And at present?”

“Since her return she wanted to sit at the bedside of your friend. She has all the qualities required for a home nurse: she’s gentle and considerate. Mr Wilson seems to be enchanted with her.”

“Oh!” said Sholmes, who had completely neglected to check for news of his old friend.

He thought for a moment, and then he enquired:

“And did she go out on Sunday morning?”

“Yes.”

“The day after the robbery?”

The baron called his wife and asked her the same question. She replied:

“Mademoiselle went out as usual to go to the eleven-o’clock Mass with the children.”

“But before that?”

“Before that? No... or rather... I was deeply disturbed by the robbery!... But I do remember that she had asked me the previous day for permission to go out on Sunday morning... to see a woman, a cousin, who was visiting Paris, I think. But I cannot imagine that you would suspect her?”

“Certainly not, but I would like to see her.”

He went up to Wilson’s room. A woman, dressed like a nurse, in a long grey cotton dress, was bent over the invalid and giving him something to drink. When she turned round, Sholmes recognized the young woman who had approached him in front of the Gare du Nord.

No explanation at all was exchanged between them. Alice Demun smiled sweetly, with charming, serious eyes and not a sign of embarrassment. The Englishman tried to speak, began to utter a few syllables and then was silent. So she continued with her job, and went on calmly under the surprised eyes of Sholmes, moved some small bottles, unwound and wound up again some linen bandages and directed her bright smile at him

again.

He swivelled on his heels, went downstairs again, and in the courtyard he ordered M. d'Imblevalle's car. He then settled down in it and had himself taken to Levallois, to the car depot, the address of which had been indicated on the cab receipt given to him by the child. As the cab driver, Duprêt, who had driven number 8279 on Sunday morning was not there, he sent the car back and waited till the start of the next shift.

The cab driver Duprêt said that he had indeed "picked up" a lady in the vicinity of the Parc Monceau, a young woman dressed in black wearing a long veil and who appeared to be very disturbed.

"Was she carrying a package?"

"Yes, quite a long package."

"And where did you take her?"

"Avenue des Ternes, at the corner with the Place Saint-Ferdinand. She stayed there for a dozen or so minutes, and then we went back to the Parc Monceau."

"Would you recognize the house in the Avenue des Ternes again?"

"For God's sake! Do I have to take you there?"

"Later. Drive me first to 36 Quai des Orfèvres."

At the police headquarters he was lucky to be able see Chief Inspector Ganimard straight away.

"Monsieur Ganimard, are you free?"

"It's to do with Lupin, isn't it?"

"Yes, it's to do with Lupin."

"Then I'm not going anywhere."

"What! You give up..."

"I give up on what is impossible! I'm weary of this unequal combat, in which we are sure to be the underdog. You may consider it spineless and absurd of me, whatever you like... but I don't care! Lupin is stronger than us. Therefore the only thing to do is give up."

"I do not give up."

"He'll make you give up, you like all the others."

"Well that'll be a sight which won't fail to please you."

"Oh, well, that's true," said Ganimard artlessly. "And since you haven't had your fair share of beatings, let's go!"

They both got into the cab. On their instruction, the cab driver stopped a

little way before the house and on the other side of the avenue, in front of a small café, on the terrace of which they sat down between the bay trees and the spindle trees. The day was beginning to wane.

“Waiter!” said Sholmes. “Give me something to write with.”

He wrote something down and then summoned the waiter again:

“Take this letter to the concierge of the house opposite. You can see the man wearing a cap and smoking in the carriage entrance.”

The concierge ran across to them, and after Ganimard had announced himself as Chief Inspector, Sholmes asked if, on Sunday morning, a young woman in black had come there.

“In black? Yes, at about nine o’clock. She went up to the second floor.”

“Have you seen her often?”

“No, but for some time, she has been more often... during the last two weeks she has been almost every day.”

“And since Sunday?”

“Just once... without counting today.”

“What! She’s been there today?”

“She’s there now.”

“She’s there now!”

“She’s been there for a good ten minutes. Her car is waiting on the Place Saint-Ferdinand, as usual. Why, I just passed her in the doorway.”

“And who is the tenant on the second floor?”

“There are two of them, a milliner, Mademoiselle Langeais, and a gentleman who’s been renting two furnished rooms for the past month under the name of Bresson.”

“Why do you say ‘under the name of’?”

“I’m convinced that it’s a borrowed name. My wife does the cleaning for him: well, there aren’t two shirts with the same initials on them.”

“What sort of lifestyle does he have?”

“Oh, he’s out most of the time. For three days at a time he doesn’t come home.”

“Did he come home on the night of Saturday and Sunday?”

“On the night of Saturday and Sunday? Well now, let me see, when I come to think of it... Yes, Saturday evening, he came back and hasn’t left since.”

“And what sort of a man is he?”

“Well, I couldn’t rightly say. He’s always changing. He’s tall and he’s short, he’s big and he’s thin... brown and blond. I don’t always recognize him.”

Ganimard and Sholmes looked at each other.

“It’s him,” murmured the inspector, “it’s definitely him.”

It was a real moment of embarrassment for the old detective, which expressed itself as a yawn and a clenching of both his fists.

Sholmes also, more in control of himself, felt a tightening in his heart.

“Look,” said the concierge, “there’s the young woman.”

And indeed, Mademoiselle appeared in the doorway and went across the square.

“And there’s Monsieur Bresson.”

“Monsieur Bresson? Which one?”

“The one carrying a package under his arm.”

“But he’s not concerned about the young woman. She’s going back to her car alone.”

“Oh, well, I’ve never seen them together.”

The two detectives had stood up hurriedly. In the glow of the street lamps they could recognize the silhouette of Lupin, going away in the opposite direction to the square.

“Who do you prefer to follow?” asked Ganimard.

“Him, for God’s sake! He’s the big game.”

“Well, I’ll tail the young woman,” suggested Ganimard.

“No, no,” the Englishman said sharply, who did not want to reveal anything about the case to Ganimard, “I know where to find the young woman... Don’t leave my side.”

Keeping their distance, and making use of the temporary cover provided by the passers-by and the kiosks, they set off in pursuit of Lupin. The pursuit was easy in fact, for he did not turn round and walked quickly, with a slight limp in his right leg, so light that it needed an observer with a trained eye to notice it. Ganimard said:

“He’s pretending to limp.”

And he continued:

“Oh, if we could only get together two or three officers and pounce on our man! We risk losing him.”

But there was not an officer in sight in front of the Porte des Ternes, and having passed through the city walls they could not count on the slightest help.

“Let’s separate,” said Sholmes, “the place is deserted.”

It was the Boulevard Victor-Hugo. They each took one of the pavements and moved forward following the line of the trees.

They continued like that for twenty minutes until the moment when Lupin turned left and went along the Seine. Then they saw Lupin go down to the bank of the river. He stayed there for a few seconds without their being able to work out what he was doing. Then he came back up the riverbank and retraced his steps. They pressed themselves against the upright bars of some railings. Lupin went past them. He no longer had the package.

And as he went away, another person came out from the corner of a house and slipped between the trees.

Sholmes said in a low voice:

“He also seems to be following him.”

“Yes, I think I saw him before as we came by.”

The hunt was on again, but was complicated by the presence of this person. Lupin followed the same route, and once more went across the Place des Ternes and went back into the house on the Place Saint-Ferdinand.

The concierge was closing the door when Ganimard turned up.

“You saw him, didn’t you?”

“Yes, I was putting out the gaslight on the stairs, and he pushed back the bolt on his door.”

“And no one was with him?”

“No one, no servant... He never eats here.”

“Aren’t there any backstairs?”

“No.”

Ganimard said to Sholmes:

“The simplest thing is for me to install myself outside Lupin’s door, while you go and look for the police superintendent at the Rue Demours. I’ll send word to you.”

Sholmes objected:

“But what if he escapes during that time?”

“As I’ll be staying here...”

“One against one, that’s an unequal battle with him.”

“But I can’t force an entry into his place of abode. I don’t have the right, especially at night.”

Sholmes shrugged his shoulders.

“Once you have arrested Lupin, no one’s going to squabble about the conditions of arrest. Besides, what else can we do? The best thing we can do is ring the bell. Then we’ll see what happens.”

They went upstairs. There was a double door on the left-hand side of the landing. Ganimard rang the bell.

There was no sound. He rang again. No one.

“Let’s go in,” murmured Sholmes.

“Very well, let’s go in.”

They remained motionless however, irresolute. Like people who hesitate before carrying out a decisive action, they dreaded undertaking that action, and it seemed to them suddenly impossible that Arsène Lupin was there, so near to them, behind that fragile partition that could be knocked down with one’s fist. Both of them knew him too well, that fiendish devil, to admit that he would let himself be caught in such a stupid way. No, no, a thousand times no, he could no longer be there. He must have got away from them once more, via the adjoining houses, across the roofs, by some suitably prepared exit. They would only be able to lay hands on Lupin’s shadow.

They shuddered. There was an imperceptible noise, which came from the other side of the door, and had faintly disturbed the silence. And they had a feeling, a sense of certainty, that he was still there, separated from them by the thin wooden partition, and that he was listening to them and could understand what they were saying.

What should they do? The situation was tragic. Despite the composure of the two old detective hands, they were overcome by such strong emotion that they imagined they could feel their own hearts beating.

Ganimard exchanged glances with Sholmes. Then he beat one of the wings of the double door violently with his fist.

There now came the sound of footsteps, a noise which did not attempt to conceal what it was...

Ganimard shook the door. With an irresistible impulse, Sholmes, putting

his shoulder forward, knocked it down, and threw themselves into the fray.

They stopped dead. A gunshot resounded in the next room, and another, and there was the sound of a falling body...

When they entered they saw a man stretched out, with his face against the marble of the fireplace. He had a convulsion. His revolver slid from his hand.

Ganimard leant over the dead man and turned his head. It was covered with blood, which was spurting from two large wounds, one in his cheek and the other in his temple.

"He's unrecognizable," he murmured.

"My God!" said Sholmes. "It isn't him."

"How do you know? You haven't even examined him."

The Englishman chuckled:

"Do you think that Arsène Lupin is the kind of man who would kill himself?"

"But we really believed we recognized him outside."

"We believed it, because we wanted to believe it. We are obsessed with this man."

"So it is one of his accomplices."

"The accomplices of Arsène Lupin don't kill themselves."

"So who is it?"

He searched the corpse. In one pocket Herlock Sholmes found an empty wallet, and in another Ganimard found a few louis. There were no tags on his underwear nor on his clothes.

In the trunks – a large trunk and two cases – there were only personal effects. On the mantelpiece there was a bundle of newspapers. Ganimard unfolded them. They all reported the theft of the Jewish lamp.

One hour later, when Ganimard and Sholmes had left, they knew nothing more about the strange person who had been driven to suicide by their intervention.

Who was he? Why had he killed himself? How was he connected to the case of the Jewish lamp? Who had been tailing him during his walk? So many questions, each as complex as the other... so many mysteries...

Herlock Sholmes went to bed in a very bad mood. When he woke up he received a letter via pneumatic post, in the following terms:

Arsène Lupin has the honour of informing you of his tragic decease as the person known as M. Bresson, and requests your presence at the funeral procession, service and burial, which will take place, with expenses paid by the state, on Thursday 25th June.

OceanofPDF.com



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YOU SEE, MY OLD FRIEND,” said Sholmes to Wilson, brandishing the letter by pneumatic post from Arsène Lupin, “what infuriates me about this affair is constantly feeling the eyes of that damned *gentleman* on me. None of my most secret thoughts escape him. I behave like an actor whose every move is controlled by strict stage directions, who goes where and who says what, because a superior will want it that way. Do you understand, Wilson?”

Wilson would certainly have understood if he had not been in the profound sleep of a man whose temperature fluctuated between forty and forty-one degrees. But whether he heard it or not was of no importance to Sholmes, who continued:

“I have to call upon all my energy and implement all my resources, so as not to become disheartened. It’s fortunate that with me, these teasing little things are just so many pinpricks that stimulate me. Once the burning sensation of the sting has been eased, and the wound to my pride has been healed, I always manage to say: ‘Have fun, my good fellow. At some point you will give yourself away.’ For finally, Wilson, wasn’t it Lupin who, by his first telegram to me and by the thought which it suggested to little Henriette, wasn’t it he who provided me with the secret of his correspondence with Alice Demun? You forget that detail, old friend.”

He wandered up and down the room, his footsteps resounding, running the risk that he would wake up his old friend.

“In the end, things aren’t going too badly, and if the paths I’m following are a little obscure, I am beginning to find my way again. First of all, I’m going to find out for certain about Monsieur Bresson. Ganimard and I are going to meet on the banks of the Seine, at the spot where Bresson threw in his package, and that gentleman’s role will become clear to us. As for the rest, it’s a game that has to be played between Alice Demun and me. My opponent is of slim stature, eh Wilson? And don’t you think that I’ll soon understand the phrase in the album and know the meaning of the two isolated letters, that C and that H? For it all depends on that, Wilson.”

At that very moment Mademoiselle came in and, noticing that Sholmes

was waving his arms about, said to him quietly:

“Mr Sholmes, I shall have to tell you off if you wake my patient. It’s not nice of you to disturb him. The doctor orders utter peace and quiet.”

He looked at her without saying a word, surprised, as on the first day, by her inexplicable calmness.

“Why are you looking at me, Mr Sholmes? No reason? I think there is... you seem to have some ulterior motive... What is it? Please answer me.”

She asked him with her bright, open face and artless eyes, with her smiling mouth and with her whole manner too, her hands folded together, and her bust leaning gently forward. There was so much candour in her that it made the Englishman feel angry. He went up to her and said in low voice.

“Bresson killed himself yesterday evening.”

She repeated it without seeming to understand:

“Bresson killed himself yesterday...”

And really the expression on her face showed no signs of tenseness. There was nothing to reveal the effort of having to lie.

“You were warned,” he said to her, irritated, “otherwise you would have at least winced... Oh, you’re stronger than I thought... But why do you pretend?”

He seized the illustrated album that he had just put on a nearby table and, opening it at the page which had been cut up, he said:

“Could you tell me in what order one should arrange the letters which are missing here, so that one can understand the exact import of the note which you sent to Bresson four days before the theft of the Jewish lamp?”

“In what order?... Bresson?... the theft of the Jewish lamp?”

She repeated the words slowly, to work out their meaning.

He insisted.

“Yes. Here are the letters used... on this piece of paper. What did you say to Bresson?”

“The letters used... what I said...”

Suddenly she burst out laughing:

“So that’s it! I understand! I am an accomplice to the theft! There’s a Monsieur Bresson who took the lamp and who killed himself. And I’m the friend of this gentleman. Oh, how funny!”

“So, who did you go to see yesterday evening on the second floor of a

house in the Avenue des Ternes?”

“Who? Why it was my milliner, Mademoiselle Langeais. Are my milliner and my friend Monsieur Bresson supposed to be one and the same person?”

Despite everything, Sholmes was suspicious. To put someone off the track, one can feign terror, delight, anxiety, all possible feelings, but not in any way indifference, not happy and carefree laughter.

But he said one more thing to her:

“One last word: yesterday evening, at the Gare du Nord, why did you approach me? And why did you beg me to leave again at once without concerning myself about the theft?”

“Oh, you’re too inquisitive, Mr Sholmes,” she replied, still laughing in the most natural way. To punish you, you shall learn nothing, and in addition you must look after the patient while I go to the chemist’s... I have an urgent prescription... I must hurry.”

She went out.

“I’ve been conned,” murmured Sholmes, “not only have I got nothing out of her, but it is I who have exposed myself.”

And he remembered the case of the blue diamond and the questioning that he made Clotilde Destange endure. Wasn’t it the same kind of calmness that the Blonde Woman had confronted him with, and wasn’t he finding himself face to face again with one of those creatures who, directly affected by his influence, remained astonishingly calm even when they feared danger.

“Sholmes... Sholmes...”

He went over to Wilson, who was calling him and leant towards him.

“What is it, old friend? Does it hurt?”

Wilson moved his lips without being able to speak. Finally after great effort, he stammered:

“No... Sholmes... it’s not her... it can’t possibly be her.”

“What are you talking about? I tell you that it’s her! It’s only when I’m confronted by one of Lupin’s creatures, trained and served up by him, that I lose my head and act so stupidly. She knows all about the album. I bet that in less than an hour Lupin will be informed. In less than an hour? What am I saying? Straight away! The chemist’s and the urgent prescription! It’s all a trick!”

He slipped away quickly, went down the Avenue de Messine and caught sight of Mademoiselle going into a chemist's. She reappeared ten minutes later, with some small flasks and a bottle wrapped in white paper. But, when she was coming back up the avenue, she was accosted by a man who was following her, with his cap in his hand and an obsequious manner, as if he was asking for charity.

She stopped and gave him some money and then went on her way.

"She spoke to him," the Englishman said to himself.

Rather than a certainty, it was an intuition that he felt, but strong enough to make him change his tactics. Leaving the young woman, he set off on the track of the false beggar.

Thus they arrived, one behind the other, at the place Saint-Ferdinand, and the man wandered for a long time around Bresson's house, raising his eyes to the second floor from time to time, and watching the people who were going into the house.

After an hour he went up onto the upper deck of a tram going towards Neuilly. Sholmes followed him up and sat behind him, a little farther back, and beside a gentleman who was concealed by the open pages of a newspaper. When they reached the fortifications the newspaper was lowered, and Sholmes saw that it was Ganimard, and, pointing to the other person, Ganimard said, close to his ear:

"That's our man from last night, the one who was following Bresson. He's been roaming around the square for an hour."

"Nothing new concerning Bresson?" asked Sholmes.

"Yes, a letter arrived at his address this morning."

"This morning? Then it was posted yesterday, before the sender could know about Bresson's death."

"Exactly. It's in the examining magistrate's hands. But I remember what it said: 'He won't accept any deal. He wants everything, the first object as well as those associated with the second case. Otherwise he will take action.'" And Ganimard added: "There's no signature. As you can see, these few lines will hardly help us."

"I don't share your opinion at all, Monsieur Ganimard. On the contrary, those few lines seem to me to be extremely interesting."

"And why, for Heaven's sake?"

"For reasons which are quite personal to me," replied Sholmes, with the

lack of consideration which he usually adopted towards his colleague.

The tram stopped on the Rue du Château, its last stop. The other man got off and went away calmly.

Sholmes followed him so closely that Ganimard became alarmed:

“If he turns round, we’re done for.”

“He won’t turn round now.”

“How do you know?”

“He’s an accomplice of Arsène Lupin’s, and the fact that an accomplice of Lupin goes off like that, with his hands in his pockets, proves in the first place that he knows he is being followed, and secondly that he’s not afraid.”

“But why are we following so close behind him?”

“We’re not so close that he still can’t slip from our grasp in less than a minute. He’s too sure of himself.”

“Come on! That’s going too far! There are two officers with bikes over there, by the door of that café. If I seek their help in tackling that man, I don’t see how he can slip from my grasp.”

“That man does not seem to be concerned very much about that possibility. He’s seeking their help himself!”

“For goodness’ sake,” said Ganimard, “he’s got a nerve!”

The man had indeed gone towards the two officers just as they were about to mount their bicycles. He said a few words to them, then, suddenly, he jumped on a third bicycle, which was leaning against the wall of the café, and rode off quickly with the two officers.

The Englishman guffawed.

“Huh! Didn’t I tell you? One, two, three, and he’s off! And with whose help? With the help of two of your colleagues, Monsieur Ganimard. Oh, he’s got it all worked out, has Arsène Lupin! Officers on bikes in his pay! Didn’t I say to you that our man was much too calm!”

“So, what’s to be done?” exclaimed Ganimard, annoyed. “What should we do? It’s easy enough to laugh at it all!”

“Come on, don’t get angry. We’ll get our revenge. For the time being, we need to get some reinforcements.”

“Folenfant is waiting for me at the end of the Avenue de Neuilly.”

“Well, take that alley, and join me later.”

Ganimard went off, while Sholmes followed the bicycle tracks, made the

more visible in the dust on the road by the fact that two of the bicycles were equipped with grooved tyres. And he soon saw that the tracks were leading him to the banks of the Seine, and that the three men had turned in the same direction as Bresson had gone the previous evening. Thus he came to the railing by which he and Ganimard had hidden themselves, and, a little farther off, he noticed a tangle of groove marks which proved that they had stopped at that spot. Just opposite there was a small strip of land which stuck out into the Seine, and at the end of it an old boat was moored.

That was where Bresson had thrown the package, or rather where he had dropped it. Sholmes went down the embankment and saw that, as the bank went down in a very gentle slope and the water of the river was low, it would be easy to retrieve the package, unless the three men had been there first.

“No, no,” he said to himself, “they haven’t had time... a quarter of an hour at the very most... and yet why did they come this way?”

There was an angler sitting in the boat. Sholmes asked him:

“You didn’t see three men on bikes?”

The angler shook his head.

The Englishman persisted:

“But you must have done... Three men... They just stopped a few feet away from you...”

The angler put his rod under his arm, took a notebook out of his pocket and wrote something on one of the pages. He tore it out and gave it to Sholmes.

The Englishman shook in great excitement. He had seen, with a quick glance, that in the middle of the page he was holding in his hand was the series of letters torn from the album:

CDEHNOPRZEO-237

The sun hung heavily on the river. The man had taken up his task again, sheltered by the vast cover of his straw hat, his jacket and waistcoat folded beside him. He was fishing attentively, with the float on his line drifting with the flow of the water.

A minute went by, a minute of solemn and awful silence.

“Is it him?” wondered Sholmes in almost painful anxiety.

As the truth dawned on him, he said:

“It’s him! It’s him! Only he is capable of staying there without trembling with anxiety, and having no fear of what might happen... And who else would know about the matter of the album? Alice warned him through a messenger.”

Suddenly the Englishman realized that his hand, his own hand, had seized the butt of his revolver, and that his eyes were focused on the man’s back, just below the nape of the neck. One move and the drama would be resolved, the life of this odd adventurer would have a miserable end.

The angler did not move.

Sholmes gripped his weapon nervously with a wild desire to shoot and have done with it, but at the same time with a horror at an action which was against his nature. Death was certain. It would all be over.

“Oh!” he thought to himself. “Let him get up and defend himself... otherwise so much the worse for him... just one more second... and I’ll shoot.”

But the sound of footsteps made him turn his head, and he caught sight of Ganimard, who was just arriving in the company of some inspectors.

Then, changing his plan, he took a run and in one bound leapt into the boat, the mooring rope of which broke under the excessive force. He fell on top of the man and clasped him bodily. They rolled about together at the bottom of the boat.

“Now what?” exclaimed Lupin, struggling. “What does this prove? When one of us has rendered the other powerless, that will be a great advantage! You wouldn’t know what to do with me, nor I with you. We’d be a right pair of idiots!”

The two oars slipped into the water. The boat drifted away. Cries could be heard going to and fro along the bank, and Lupin continued:

“What a carry-on, sir! Have you lost your senses? Such stupid behaviour at your age! And a big boy like you! Shame on you, you naughty boy!...”

He managed to free himself.

Exasperated, and determined to do anything, Herlock Sholmes put his hand to his pocket. He let out a curse: Lupin had taken his revolver.

So, he got down on his knees and tried to grasp one of the oars in order to reach the bank, while Lupin tried desperately to reach the other one, in order to gain open water.

“Whether you’ve got one or not,” said Lupin, “whatever the case, it’s not important. If you’ve got an oar, I’ll stop you from using it... And you’ll do the same to me. But there you are, that’s life, we try to act, without the least reason for doing so, since it’s always fate which decides. There you are, you see, it’s fate... it’s on old Lupin’s side... Victory! The current’s in my favour!”

The boat was indeed starting to drift away.

“Watch out!” cried Lupin.

Someone on the riverbank was pointing a revolver. He lowered his head. There was the sound of a detonation, and a little water shot up in the air near them. Lupin burst out laughing.

“Well, bless my soul, it’s Ganimard! But that’s a bad thing you’re doing there, Ganimard. You have no right to shoot except in the case of legitimate self-defence. Does poor old Arsène make you so violent that you forget all your obligations?... Well, here we go again! But, you poor chap, it’ll be my beloved Maestro that you’ll hit.”

He defended Sholmes with his body and, standing up in the boat, facing Ganimard, he said:

“Fine! Now I feel easy about it. Aim here, Ganimard, right in the heart!... Higher... To the left... Oh, missed!... Damned clumsy of you!... Want to try another shot?... But you’re trembling, Ganimard... On my command, alright?... Calmly now!... One, two, three, fire!... Missed! Good God, have the government issued you with children’s toys as pistols?”

He showed off a long revolver, heavy but slim, and he fired without taking aim.

The inspector put his hand to his hat: a bullet had pierced it.

“What do you think, Ganimard? Oh, it’s made by a good factory. Show your respect, gentlemen; it’s the revolver of my noble friend, Maestro Herlock Sholmes!”

And, with a twist of his arm, he threw the weapon at the very feet of Ganimard.

Sholmes could not stop himself from smiling and admiring him. What ebullience! What youthful and spontaneous delight! And how he seemed to be amusing himself! One could say that the feeling of danger gave him a physical sense of joy, and that being alive had no other purpose for this

extraordinary man than the pursuit of dangers which he then enjoyed warding off.

On each side of the river, however, people were gathering, and Ganimard and his men were following the boat which was rocking about in open water, and being gently drawn away by the current. Capture was certain, dead certain in fact.

“Confess, Maestro,” exclaimed Lupin, as he turned towards the Englishman, “that you wouldn’t give up your place at the moment for all the gold in the Transvaal!¹ You’ve got a seat in the front row of the stalls! But first and foremost, the prologue... after which we shall jump in one bound straight to the fifth act, the capture or escape of Arsène Lupin. So, my dear Maestro, I have a question to put to you, and I must beg you, in order to avoid any ambiguity, to reply with a yes or a no. Will you give up your involvement in this case? There’s still time for me to be able to put right the wrong you have done. Later I wouldn’t be able to do it. Agreed?”

“No.”

Lupin’s face became tense. This obstinacy obviously irritated him. He continued:

“I insist. More for your sake than mine. I insist, as I am certain that you will be the first to regret your intervention. For the last time: yes or no?”

“No.”

Lupin crouched down, removed one of the planks at the bottom of the boat and, for a few minutes, was doing something, the nature of which Sholmes could not make out. Then he got up, sat down next to the Englishman and spoke to him in the following way:

“I think, Maestro, that we came to this riverbank for the same reasons: to fish for the object that Bresson got rid of, right? For my part, I have made arrangements to meet some friends, and I was, as my rough-and-ready costume indicates, about to carry out a little exploration in the depths of the Seine, when my friends announced your approach.

“I confess moreover that I wasn’t surprised, having been informed hour by hour, dare I say, about the progress of your investigation. It’s so easy! As soon as anything the least thing likely to be of interest to me occurs on the Rue Murillo, in no time at all a telephone call is made, and I am warned about it! You will understand that in such circumstances...”

He stopped. The plank that he had moved aside was now rising up, and, all around it, little spurts of water were filtering through.

“Damn! I don’t know how I did it, but I have every reason to think that there’s a leak at the bottom of this old boat. Aren’t you afraid, Maestro?”

Sholmes shrugged his shoulders. Lupin continued:

“You will understand then that in these circumstances, and knowing in advance that you would seek a fight the more passionately I tried hard to avoid it, it was much more pleasant for me to engage with you in a game, the outcome of which is certain, since I have all the trumps in my hand. And I wanted to make our encounter as glorious as possible, so that your defeat would become universally known about, and some other Countess de Crozon or Baron d’Imbleville wouldn’t be tempted to seek your help against me. Besides, my dear Maestro, please do not consider...”

He interrupted himself again and, using his half-closed hands as though they were a spyglass, he looked at the banks.

“Damn! They have hired a superb boat, a real warship, and they are rowing hard. In less than five minutes, they’ll be boarding us, and I’ll be lost. Mr Sholmes, a word of advice: throw yourself on top of me, tie me up and hand me over to the authorities of my country... Do you like this plan?... Unless in the meantime we’ve been shipwrecked, in which case the only thing left for us to do is to prepare our wills. What do you think?”

They exchanged looks. Now Sholmes understood Lupin’s manoeuvre: he had pierced a hole in the bottom of the boat. The water was rising.

It reached the soles of their boots. Then it covered their feet: they did not move at all.

It went over their ankles: the Englishman grabbed his tobacco pouch, rolled a cigarette and lit it.

Lupin continued:

“Please do not consider this to be, my dear Maestro, anything more than the humble admission of my impotence in face of you. It means that I yield to you, except only for those battles in which my victory must be granted, so that I can avoid including those in which I did not choose the terrain. It means that I recognize that Sholmes is the one enemy that I fear, and that I acknowledge my anxiety until such times as Sholmes is diverted from my path. That, my dear Maestro, is what I wanted to say to you,

since fate has accorded me the honour of holding a conversation with you. I regret only one thing, that this conversation has taken place while we are taking a footbath!... a situation which lacks a certain solemnity, I confess... What am I saying?... a footbath!... It's more like a hip bath!"

The water had indeed reached the level of the bench where they were sitting, and the boat was sinking more and more.

Unruffled, Sholmes, with his cigarette between his lips, seemed to be absorbed in contemplating the sky. Not for all the world, facing this man surrounded by dangers, encircled by a mob, hounded by a pack of officers and yet still maintaining his good mood – no, not for all the world would he allow himself to show the slightest sign of restlessness.

"What!" they both seemed to be saying. "Should they be bothered by such trifles? Wasn't it an everyday occurrence to drown in a river? Are they the sort of events worth paying attention to?" The one was talking away, and the other was daydreaming, both hiding under a similar mask of indifference the enormous clash of two proud minds.

One minute more and they would sink.

"The main thing," as Lupin formulated it, "is to know if we will sink before or after the arrival of the champions of justice. It all depends on that. For it's not a question of whether we're sinking any more. Maestro, it is now the solemn time for us to make our wills. I leave all my fortune to Herlock Sholmes, English citizen, with the responsibility of... But, my God, how fast they are advancing, those champions of justice! Oh, the brave lads! It's a pleasure to watch them. What precision in their oar strokes! What, is that you, Sergeant Folenfant? Bravo! The idea of using a warship is excellent. I shall recommend you to your superiors, Sergeant Folenfant... Is it a medal that you're after? The matter's settled... it's a done deal. And what about your comrade Dieuzy, where is he? He's on the left bank, isn't he, in the middle of a hundred or so local people? So that, if I escape the shipwreck, I'll be picked up on the left side by Dieuzy and his band of locals, or on the right side by Ganimard and the population of Neuilly. An unfortunate dilemma..."

There was a sudden eddy. The boat turned round on itself, and Sholmes had to hang on to the rowlocks.

"Maestro," said Lupin, "I beg you to take off your jacket. It'll be easier

for you to swim. No? You refuse? Oh well, I'll put mine on then."

He slipped on his jacket, buttoned it up so that it was watertight like that of Sholmes, and sighed:

"What a tough man you are! And what a pity it is that you persist with this case, in which you certainly show the extent of your abilities, but all in vain! It's true, you are wasting your genius..."

"Monsieur Lupin," said Sholmes, emerging from his silence, "you talk much too much, and are often overconfident and thoughtless."

"That's a severe reproach."

"In that way you have, without realizing it, provided me a moment ago with the information that I was looking for."

"What! You were looking for some information and you didn't tell me!"

"I don't need anyone's help. Three hours from now, I shall present Monsieur and Madame d'Imbleville with the key to the mystery. The only response..."

He could not finish what he was saying. The boat had suddenly sunk, dragging the two of them down with it. It immediately emerged again, turned upside down, with its hull up in the air. There were loud cries on both banks, then an anxious silence, and suddenly new exclamations: one of the victims had reappeared.

It was Herlock Sholmes.

He was an excellent swimmer, and made his way with large arm strokes towards Folenfant's boat.

"Have no fear, Mr Sholmes," yelled the sergeant. "We'll get you... Don't flag... We'll worry about him afterwards... We'll get him. Come on... Just a little bit more, Mr Sholmes... Grab the rope..."

The Englishman seized the rope which they held out to him. But, as he was heaving himself on board, a voice behind him called out to him:

"The key to the mystery, my dear Maestro, by God yes, you'll get it. I'm only surprised that you haven't got it already. But then? What use will it be to you? Just when the battle will be lost for you..."

Sitting astride the hull, the sides of which he had just climbed up while holding forth, Arsène Lupin, now comfortably installed, continued his speech with solemn gestures, as if he hoped to convince the person he was talking to.

“You must understand, my dear Maestro, that there’s nothing you can do, absolutely nothing... You find yourself in the regrettable position of a gentleman...”

Folenfant took aim:

“Give yourself up, Lupin.”

“You are a boor, Sergeant Folenfant. You cut me off in the middle of what I was saying. As I was saying...”

“Give yourself up, Lupin.”

“Good God, Sergeant Folenfant, one only gives oneself up when one is danger. Well, you can’t claim to believe that I am in the least danger!”

“For the last time, Lupin, I command you to give yourself up.”

“Sergeant Folenfant, you have no intention whatsoever of killing me. At the most you mean to wound me, because you’re so afraid that I’ll escape. And what if by chance the wound were fatal? No, just think of the remorse you would feel, you poor old chap! It would make your old age a misery!”

A shot was fired.

Lupin wobbled, clung to the wreck for a moment, and then lost his grip and disappeared.

It was at exactly three o’clock when these events took place. At six o’clock precisely, just as he had announced, Herlock Sholmes, dressed in trousers that were too short and a jacket that was too tight, which he had borrowed from an innkeeper in Neuilly, and wearing also a cap and adorned with a flannel shirt with a silk cord, went into the boudoir on the Rue Murillo, after having informed Monsieur and Madame d’Imbleville that he wanted to discuss some matters with them.

He found them walking to and fro. And he looked so comical in his odd clothes that they had to repress a strong desire to laugh. With a pensive air, and stooping down, he walked about like an automaton, from the window to the door, from the door to the window, making the same number of paces each time, and turning each time in the same direction.

He stopped, grasped an ornament, examined it mechanically, and then continued his walk.

Finally, placing himself in front of them, he asked:

“Is Mademoiselle here?”

“Yes, in the garden, with the children.”

“Monsieur le Baron, as the discussion we shall have will be a definitive one, I would like Mademoiselle Demun to be present.”

“Is it really...”

“Please be a little patient, Monsieur. The truth will emerge clearly from the facts that I am going to put before you as accurately as possible.”

“Very well, Suzanne, would you?...”

Mme d’Imblevalle stood up and returned almost at once, accompanied by Alice Demun. Mademoiselle, a little paler than usual, remained standing, leaning against a table and not even asking why she had been summoned.

Sholmes did not appear to have seen her, and turning abruptly towards M. d’Imblevalle, he spoke in a tone which admitted no rejoinder:

“After several days of investigation, sir, and although certain events changed for a moment my way of viewing things, I must repeat to you what I told you from the very first: the Jewish lamp was stolen by someone living in this house.”

“And the name of the guilty party?”

“I know it.”

“And you have proof?”

“What I have will be sufficient to expose that person.”

“It is not sufficient that he be exposed. He must also return to us...”

“The Jewish lamp? It is in my possession.”

“And the opal necklace? And the snuffbox?”

“The opal necklace, the snuffbox, in short, everything which was stolen from you on the second occasion, is in my possession.”

Sholmes loved such *coups de théâtre* and this rather curt way of announcing his victories.

In fact, the baron and his wife seemed to be amazed, and regarded him with a silent curiosity which was the best form of praise.

He then continued his detailed recital of what he had done during the last three days. He talked about the discovery of the album, wrote on a sheet of paper the phrase formed by the cut-out letters, then told them about Bresson’s expedition to the banks of the Seine and about the adventurer’s suicide, and finally about the fight that he, Sholmes, had just undertaken with Lupin, the sinking of the boat and the disappearance of

Lupin.

When he had finished, the baron said in a low voice:

“The only thing left for you to do is to reveal to us the name of the guilty party. So whom do you accuse?”

“I accuse the person who cut out the letters from this alphabet, and communicated with Arsène Lupin by means of these letters.”

“How do you know that this person’s correspondent is Arsène Lupin?”

“From Lupin himself.”

He held out a piece of wet, crumpled paper. It was the page that Lupin had torn from his notebook, in the boat, and on which he had written the phrase.

“And note,” Sholmes pointed out, with satisfaction, “that nothing obliged him to give me this page, and, consequently, let himself be recognized. It was simple mischievousness on his part which provided me with information.”

“Which provided you with information...” said the baron, “but I don’t see...”

Sholmes went over the letters and numbers again with a pencil:

CDEHNOPRZEO-237

“Well?” said M. d’Imblevalle, it’s the formula which you just showed us yourself.

“No. If you had mulled over this formula in all its possible senses, you would have seen at first glance, as I did, that it is not exactly like the first one.”

“In what way then?”

“It contains two extra letters, an E and an O.”

“Indeed, I hadn’t noticed.”

“Put these two letters together with the C and the H which were left after identifying the word *répondez*, and you will notice that the only possible word is ‘ECHO’.”

“And what does that mean?”

“It means *L’Écho de France*, Lupin’s newspaper, his official mouthpiece, the one for which he reserves his special ‘communiqués’. ‘Reply to *L’Écho de France*, the small ads section, number 237.’ This was the key to the mystery that I was searching for so hard, and which Lupin supplied me

with with such good grace. I've just come from the offices of *L'Écho de France*."

"And what did you find out?"

"I discovered the whole detailed account of Arsène Lupin's relationship with... his accomplice."

Sholmes spread out seven copies of the newspaper open at the fourth page in each case, and from them he removed the following seven lines:

ARS. LUP. Lady impl. protect. 540.

540. Awaiting explanations. A.L.

A.L. Under control enemy. Lost.

540. Write address. Will make enquiries.

A.L. Murillo.

540. Park three o'clock. Violets.

237. Agreed Sat. Will be Sun. morn. park.

"And you call that a detailed account!" exclaimed M. d'Imbleville.

"My God yes, and if you had paid a little attention, you would share my opinion. In the first place, a lady who signs herself 540 implores Arsène to protect her, to which Lupin responds with a demand for explanations. The lady replies that she is under the control of an enemy, no doubt Bresson, and that she is lost if someone does not come to her aid. Lupin, who is wary, and does not want to become involved in a discussion with this unknown woman, demands an address and offers to investigate. The lady hesitates for four days – you can check the dates – and finally, pressurized by events and influenced by Bresson's threats, she provides the name of her street, Murillo. The next day, Arsène Lupin announces that he will be in the Parc Monceau at three o'clock, and asks his unknown correspondent to wear a bouquet of violets as a way identifying herself at the meeting point. Then there's an eight-day gap in the correspondence. Arsène Lupin and the lady don't need to write to each other via the newspaper: they are meeting each other or writing to each other directly. The plan is hatched: to satisfy the demands of Bresson, the lady will remove the Jewish lamp. It remains only to fix the day. The lady, who corresponds prudently by using cut and pasted words, decides on Sunday and adds: *Reply Echo* 237. Lupin replies that he agrees to this and will also be in the park Sunday morning. On Sunday morning the robbery took place."

“Indeed, it all follows,” said the baron approvingly, “and we have the whole story.”

Sholmes continued:

“So, the robbery took place. The lady goes out on Sunday morning, gives an account to Lupin of what she has done, and takes the Jewish lamp to Bresson. It all happens just as Lupin had predicted. The authorities, taken in by an open window, four holes in the ground and two scratches on a balcony, immediately accept the hypothesis of a theft by breaking and entering. The lady feels easy in her mind.”

“Fine,” said the baron, “I admit that this explanation is very logical. But what about the second robbery?”

“The second robbery was provoked by the first. As the newspapers had reported how the Jewish lamp had disappeared, someone had the idea of repeating the attack and getting hold of what had not already been taken. And this time it was not a simulated robbery, but a real one, by real breaking and entering, and climbing up, etc.”

“It was Lupin, of course.”

“No, Lupin does not act so stupidly. Lupin doesn’t shoot at people for no apparent reason.”

“So, who was it?”

“Bresson, without a doubt, without the knowledge of the woman he had been blackmailing. It was Bresson who came in here, it was he I followed, and it was he who wounded my poor old friend Wilson.”

“Are you sure of this?”

“Absolutely. One of Bresson’s accomplices wrote a letter to him yesterday, before his suicide, which proves that talks were undertaken between this accomplice and Lupin to arrange for the return of all the objects stolen from your house. Lupin demanded all of them: *‘the first one’* (that means the Jewish lamp) *‘as well as those from the second job’*. What is more, he kept a watch on Bresson. When he went to the banks of the Seine yesterday evening, one of Lupin’s companions was tailing him at the same time as we were.”

“What was Bresson going to do on banks of the Seine?”

“Warned of the progress of my investigation—”

“Warned by whom?”

“By the same woman, who was afraid quite rightly that the discovery of

the Jewish lamp would lead to the discovery of her little adventure... So, Bresson, when he was warned, puts everything that could compromise him together into one package, and he throws it away at a spot where it is possible to find it again, once the danger is past. When he came back, hounded by Ganimard and by me, and having no doubt other infamous deeds on his conscience, he loses his head and kills himself.”

“But what did the package contain?”

“The Jewish lamp and your other ornaments.”

“So they’re not in your possession?”

“Immediately after the disappearance of Lupin, I took advantage of the bath that he forced me to take and had myself taken to the spot chosen by Bresson, and I found, wrapped in linen and oilcloth, the items stolen from you. Here they are on this table.”

Without saying a word, the baron cut the pieces of string, tore open in one go the wet linen and took out the lamp. He turned a nut on the base, and with both hands he put pressure on the receptacle, unscrewed it and opened it in two equal sections to reveal the fantastic gold object, set with rubies and emeralds.

It was intact.

Throughout this whole scene, which appeared to be quite natural, and consisting of a simple exposition of the facts, there was something which made it all horribly tragic. This was the categorical, direct and irrefutable accusation that Sholmes directed at Mademoiselle with every word he spoke. And there was also the disturbing silence of Alice Demun.

During this long, cruel accumulation of small pieces of evidence, one following the other, not a muscle of her face had moved. Not a spark of revolt or of fear had disturbed the calm of her clear gaze. What was she thinking? And above all, what would she say at the solemn moment when it would be necessary for her to reply, when she would have to defend herself and break that iron circle in which Herlock Sholmes had imprisoned her so easily?

The moment had come, and the young woman was silent.

“Speak! Speak!” exclaimed M. d’Imblevalle.

But she did not speak a word.

He insisted:

“One word would vindicate you... One word of protest, and I’d believe you.”

But she did not utter this word.

The baron went swiftly across the room, and came back again. He started speaking again, addressing himself to Sholmes:

“I must say no, sir. I cannot admit that it’s true! There are some crimes which are impossible, and this contradicts everything that I know, everything that I have observed over the past year.”

He placed his hand on the Englishman’s shoulder.

“And you yourself, sir, are you absolutely and definitely sure that you have not made a mistake?”

Sholmes hesitated, like a man who has been attacked unexpectedly and who cannot reply immediately. However, he smiled and said:

“Only the person whom I accuse was able, through the position which she holds in your household, to know that the Jewish lamp contained that magnificent jewel.”

“I can’t believe it,” murmured the baron.

“Then ask her about it.”

Indeed it was the only thing that he had not tried, due to the blind trust that the young girl inspired in him. However it was no longer possible to deny the evidence.

He went up to her and, looking into her eyes, he said:

“Was it you, Mademoiselle? Was it you who stole the jewel? And was it you who corresponded with Arsène Lupin and simulated the robbery?”

She answered:

“It was me, Monsieur.”

She did not lower her head. Her face revealed neither shame nor embarrassment.

“Is it possible?” murmured M.d’Imblevalle... I would never have believed it... you are the last person I would have suspected... How could you do it, you poor woman?”

“I did what Mr Sholmes said. On the night of Saturday to Sunday I came down into this boudoir, I took the lamp, and in the morning I brought it to... that man.”

“No,” objected the baron, “I cannot accept what you claim to be true.”

“Can’t accept? But why?”

“Because in the morning I found the bolt on the door to this boudoir locked.”

She blushed, lost her composure and looked at Sholmes, as if seeking his advice.

More than by the baron’s objection, Sholmes seemed to be struck by Alice Demun’s embarrassment. Didn’t she have anything to say in reply? Those confessions, which confirmed the explanation that he, Sholmes, had provided about the theft of the Jewish lamp, were they covering up a lie which an examination of the facts at once revealed?

The baron continued:

“This door was closed. I can confirm that I found the bolt just as I had left it the previous evening. If you had come in through this door, as you claim, then it would be necessary for someone to open it from the inside, that is to say from the boudoir or from our room. Well, there was no one inside these two rooms... there was no one but my wife and I.”

Sholmes bent over quickly and covered his face with both hands to mask his blushing. Something had struck him like a very sudden flash of light, and he was dazzled by it and ill at ease. Everything was revealed to him like a dark countryside from which the night suddenly withdraws.

Alice Demun was innocent.

Alice Demun was innocent. It was a blinding and certain truth, and it was at the same time an explanation of that kind of discomfort he had experienced since the first day in directing the terrible accusation against the young woman. Now he saw things clearly. He knew. One move, and straight away the irrefutable proof would present itself to him.

He raised his head again and, after a few seconds, as naturally as he could, he turned his eyes towards Mme d’Imblevalle.

She was pale, and it was that unusual paleness that comes over you at those merciless moments in life. Her hands, which she tried hard to hide, were trembling imperceptibly.

“One more second,” thought Sholmes, “and she will betray herself.”

He placed himself between her and her husband, in the urgent desire to ward off the dreadful danger that, *through his fault*, was threatening this man and woman. But when he caught sight of the baron, he shook to the depths of his being. The same revelation which had dazzled him in its clarity, now shone on M. d’Imblevalle’s face. The same process was taking

place in the husband's mind. Now he too understood! He realized!

Despairingly, Alice Demun tried to resist the inexorable truth.

"You are right, Monsieur, I was wrong. Indeed I did not enter this way. I went through the hallway and through the garden, and with the aid of a ladder..."

It was a supreme effort of devotion... but a useless one. Her words rang false. Her voice was not very assured, and the gentle creature's eyes were no longer clear, nor did she have any longer that air of complete sincerity. She lowered her head in defeat.

The silence was terrible. Mme d'Imbleville was waiting, her face deathly pale and made tense by anxiety and terror. The baron seemed to be still struggling, as if he did not want to believe in the collapse of his happiness.

Finally, he mumbled:

"Speak! Explain yourself!"

"I have nothing to say, my poor friend," she said in a very low voice, her face twisted with pain.

"Then... Mademoiselle..."

"Mademoiselle saved me... through her devotion... her affection... and she accused herself..."

"Saved from what? From whom?"

"From that man."

"Bresson."

"Yes, it was me he was controlling with his threats... I got to know him at a friend's house... and I was mad enough to listen to him... Oh, there was nothing that you cannot forgive... but I wrote two letters... letters which you will see... I bought them back from him... you know how... Oh have pity on me... I cried so much!"

"You! You! Suzanne!"

He raised his clenched fists to her, ready to strike her, ready to kill her. But he dropped his arms again, and he murmured again:

"You, Suzanne!... You!... Is it possible?"

In short disjointed phrases she related her depressing and commonplace adventure, her stunned awakening to the man's infamy, her remorse, her panic, and she talked also about the admirable behaviour of Alice, how the young woman observed the despair of her mistress, dragging a

confession out of her, and how she wrote to Lupin, and organized the story about the robbery to save her from the claws of Bresson.

"You, Suzanne, you," repeated M. d'Imblevalle, bent over, struck down.

On the evening of that same day, the steamer *Ville de Londres*, which runs between Calais and Dover, was slipping slowly over the motionless water. The night was dark and calm. Peaceful clouds could be perceived above the ship, and all around light veils of mist separated it from the infinite space in which the moon and stars were spreading their radiance.

Most of the passengers had gone back to their cabins or the lounges. Some of the more intrepid ones, however, were walking on the deck or even dozing in the depths of large rocking chairs and under thick blankets. Here and there you could see the gleams of cigars, and you could hear, mixed with the light breath of the breeze, the murmur of voices which no one dared to raise in the great solemn silence.

One of the passengers, who was wandering about at a regular pace along the ship's rail, stopped near someone lying on a bench, whom he examined, and as that person moved a little, he said to him:

"I thought you were sleeping, Mademoiselle Alice."

"No, no, Mr Sholmes, I don't want to sleep. I was just thinking."

"About what? Would it be indiscreet to ask you?"

"I was thinking about Madame d'Imblevalle. She must be very sad. Her life is ruined."

"Oh no, no," he said swiftly. "Her mistake was not one of those that cannot be pardoned. Monsieur d'Imblevalle will forget such a failing. Already, when we were leaving, he was looking at her less harshly."

"Perhaps... but it takes a long time to forget... and she will suffer."

"Do you love her very much?"

"Very much. It was that which gave me such strength to smile when I was trembling with fear, and to look you in the face when I would have preferred to avoid your eyes."

"And you're unhappy to leave her?"

"Very unhappy. I have neither relatives nor friends... I only had her."

"You will make friends," said the Englishman, who was upset by her grief. "I promise you... I have relatives... a lot of influence... I can assure you that you won't regret your situation."

“Perhaps, but Madame d’Imblevalle won’t be there any more...”

They did not exchange any more words. Herlock Sholmes took two or three more turns round the deck, and then returned to settle down next to his travelling companion.

The curtain of mist cleared away and the clouds seemed to break apart in the sky. The stars were twinkling.

Sholmes pulled out his pipe from deep inside his Inverness cape, filled it, and struck four matches successively without managing to light them. As he had no more, he got up and spoke to a gentleman who was sitting a few feet away:

“Could you give me a light, please?”

The gentleman opened a box of matches and struck one. Immediately a flame shot up. By its light, Sholmes could see that it was Arsène Lupin.

If it had not been for a very small movement on the part of the Englishman, an imperceptible movement of recoil, Lupin could have assumed that his presence on board was already known to Sholmes, so well did the latter control himself, and with such natural ease did he stretch out his hand to his opponent.

“Still in good health, Monsieur Lupin?”

“Bravo!” exclaimed Lupin, from whom such self-control drew a cry of admiration.

“Bravo! And why?”

“What do you mean, why? You see me reappear before you like a phantom, after having been present at my dive into the Seine – and through pride, through a miracle of pride which I would describe as very completely British, you don’t even react with astonishment, not a word of surprise! Well, I repeat, bravo! It’s admirable!”

“It’s not admirable. From the way you fell off the boat, I could see very well that you were falling deliberately and that you had not been hit by the sergeant’s bullet.”

“And you left without knowing what had become of me?”

“What had become of you? I knew. Five hundred people were controlling the two riverbanks for a distance of one kilometre. From the moment you escaped death your capture was certain.”

“Yet, here I am.”

“Monsieur Lupin, there are two people in the world concerning whom nothing can astonish me: the first is myself and the second is you.”

Peace was concluded.

If Sholmes had not been successful in his enterprises against Arsène Lupin, if Lupin remained the exceptional enemy he had to give up hope of catching and if in the course of their involvements with each other he always kept the upper hand, then the Englishman had nevertheless, by dint of his enormous tenacity, recovered the Jewish lamp just as he had recovered the blue diamond. Perhaps this time the result was less brilliant, especially from the public's perspective, since Sholmes was obliged to keep quiet about the circumstances in which the Jewish lamp had been discovered, and to announce that he did not know the name of the guilty party. But between man and man, between Lupin and Sholmes, between detective and burglar, there was in all fairness neither winner nor loser. Each of them could claim to be equally victorious.

So they chatted, as courteous adversaries who have laid down their weapons and who have a fair estimation of each other.

At Sholmes's request, Lupin told him how he escaped.

“Just assuming that,” he said, “it can be called an escape. It was so simple! My friends were watching, since we had arranged to meet there to recover the Jewish lamp. Also, after having stayed a good half-hour under the upturned hull of the boat, I took advantage of a moment when Folenfant and his men were looking for my corpse along the riverbanks, and I got back onto the wreck. My friends only had to pick me up on their way in their motor boat, and to get away under the amazed eyes of five hundred people, as well as Ganimard and Folenfant.”

“Very nicely done!” exclaimed Sholmes. “A complete success! And now do you have some business in England?”

“Yes, a few accounts to be settled. But I was forgetting... How is Monsieur d'Imblevalle?”

“He knows everything.”

“Oh, my dear Maestro, what did I tell you? The harm can't be put right now. Wouldn't it have been better to let me act as I wanted to? One more day or two, and I would have got back the Jewish lamp and the ornaments from Bresson, I would have sent them to the d'Imblevalles. And those two

good people would have been able to live peacefully side by side. Instead of that—”

“Instead of that,” chuckled Sholmes, “I clouded the issue and brought discord to the bosom of a family you were protecting.”

“My God, yes, I was protecting them. Is it essential to be always stealing, fooling people and doing wrong?”

“So, you do good as well?”

“When I have the time. And then it amuses me. I find it extremely funny that in this adventure with which we are concerned, I am the good genie who helps and saves, and you are the bad genie who brings despair and tears.”

“Tears! Tears!” protested the Englishman.

“Certainly! The d’Imblevalle household has been destroyed and Alice Demun is in tears.”

“She could not stay there. Ganimard would finally have found out about her, and through her they would have followed the trail back to Madame d’Imblevalle.”

“I’m completely of the same opinion as you, Maestro, but whose fault is it?”

Two men passed by in front of them. Sholmes said to Lupin, in a tone of voice which seemed to be slightly altered:

“Do you know who those two gentleman are?”

“I thought I recognized the ship’s captain.”

“And the other?”

“I don’t know.”

“It is Mr Austin Gilett. And Mr Austin Gilett has a position in England which corresponds to that of Monsieur Dudouis, your head of the Sûreté.”

“Oh what good luck! Would you be so kind as to introduce me? Monsieur Dudouis is one of my best friends, and I would be very happy to be able to say the same for Mr Austin Gilett.”

The two gentlemen came back.

“And what if I take you at your word, Monsieur Lupin?” said Sholmes getting up.

He had seized Arsène Lupin by the wrist and held him with an iron grip.

“Why are you gripping me so hard, Maestro? I’m quite ready to follow you.”

In fact, he let himself be led without the least resistance. The two gentlemen were going away.

Sholmes increased his pace. His nails dug right into Lupin’s flesh.

“Come on... come on,” he said in a muffled voice and in a frantic haste to settle everything as quickly as possible... Come on! Faster than that.”

But then he stopped dead. Alice Demun had followed them.

“What are you doing, Mademoiselle! It’s pointless... Don’t follow us!”

It was Lupin who replied:

“I beg you to notice, Maestro, that Mademoiselle is not coming willingly. I am gripping her wrist with a strength comparable to that which you are employing with respect to me.”

“And why?”

“What! But I am absolutely determined to introduce her too. Her role in the affair of the Jewish lamp is even more important than mine. An accomplice of Arsène Lupin, accomplice of Bresson, she should also tell them about the adventure of the Baronne d’Imblevalle. Something which will be extremely interesting to the authorities. And in this way you will have pursued your beneficial intervention to its utter limits, my noble Sholmes.”

The Englishman had let go the wrist of his prisoner. Lupin freed Mademoiselle.

They stayed there for a few moments motionless, facing each other. Then Sholmes went back to his bench and sat down. Lupin and the young woman also went back to their places. There was a long silence between them. Then Lupin said:

“You see, Maestro, whatever we do, we will never be on the same side. You are on one side of the gap, and I’m on the other. We can greet each other, hold out our hands to each other, talk for a while, but the gap is always there. You will always be Herlock Sholmes, detective, and I’ll be Arsène Lupin, burglar. And Herlock Sholmes will always submit, more or less spontaneously, more or less appropriately, to his instinct as a detective, which is to hound the burglar and ‘stick him inside’ if possible. And Arsène Lupin will always be consistent with the spirit of the burglar, avoiding the firm hand of the detective, and making fun of him, if it’s

possible to do so. And this time, it's possible. Ha, ha, ha!"

He burst out laughing. It was a mocking, cruel and hateful laugh.

Then suddenly, becoming serious, he leant towards the young woman.

"Be assured, Mademoiselle, that even if I were close to death, I would never betray you. Arsène Lupin never betrays anyone, especially those he loves and whom he admires. And you must permit me to tell you that I love you and admire the courageous and dear creature that you are."

"If Mr Sholmes does not succeed in the steps he takes, Mademoiselle, present yourself to Lady Strongborough (you can easily discover her present place of abode), and hand to her this half of a card, saying to her the words 'in faithful memory'. Lady Strongborough will devote herself to you like a sister."

"Thank you," said the young woman, "I shall go and visit the lady tomorrow."

"And now, Maestro," exclaimed Lupin, with the satisfied tone of a man who has fulfilled his duty, "I will wish you goodnight. We still have one hour of the crossing left. I shall make the most of it."

He stretched out full length, and crossed his hands behind his head.

The sky had become clear in front of the moon. Against the stars and at sea level, its radiant clarity shone out. It was floating in the water, and the vast space, in which the last clouds were dissolving, seemed to belong to it.

The coastline stood out from the dark horizon. Some passengers stood up. The deck became covered with people. Mr Austin Gilett passed by in the company of two persons whom Sholmes recognized as English police officers.

On his bench Lupin was asleep...

1 Transvaal: A region in modern-day South Africa famous for its gold mines.

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THE WRITER

Maurice Leblanc was born on 11th November 1864, in Rouen – a town in the region of Normandy in northern France. His father was a successful merchant, and his mother came from a high-class family, so Maurice grew up in a comfortable, cultured environment; the family even had connections with the great French writer Gustave Flaubert. Maurice himself was bright and loved to read, devouring the works of famous writers such as Maupassant and Zola. He received a good education at a prestigious Lycée Corneille, where he won prizes and showed huge promise. Perhaps all this is why he had no interest in following in his father's footsteps, or in any of the careers that his father would have liked him to pursue. He worked in a card factory for a while, but he showed so little enthusiasm for it that his parents agreed he could give it up. What he really wanted was to be a writer – like Flaubert.

Maurice had a sister named Georgette who was several years younger than him. She was also beautiful and talented, and left home at just seventeen to pursue a career as a singer in Paris. Her glamorous lifestyle was a big attraction for Maurice, and before long he went to join her. He was supposed to study law, but in reality he hoped to get one step closer to fulfilling his dream. Georgette, although young, was meeting artists and the literati – exactly the sort of people that Maurice himself wanted to meet, and who might be able to help him.

It wasn't long before Maurice abandoned his law studies and started writing. First of all, he tried journalism. It was a good way to mingle with literary people, but longer projects were what really interested him. So he worked hard and published several novels, including an autobiographical novel called *Enthusiasm*, which was published in 1901. When these works failed to sell many copies, he was bitterly disappointed. But he didn't give up; he turned to writing plays instead. Still, the big success he hoped for did not materialize.

And then, in 1905, the editor of a journal, *Je Sais Tout* (*I Know Everything*), asked Maurice if he would write a short story – something popular that would sell well. It wasn't really the sort of thing that Maurice wanted to write, but it was an opportunity all the same, so he set to work.

His character Arsène Lupin, a charming gentleman burglar, was the result. The first story was called ‘The Arrest of Arsène Lupin’, and it was an instant success.

Before long, the Arsène Lupin stories created by Maurice were being published as books as well as in the journal; both American and French film-makers began to adapt the stories too. The immense popularity of his creation made Maurice a rich man. In 1908, he was awarded the Légion d’Honneur by the French government, in recognition of his hard work and excellence. By this time, however, he was already tired of his famous character, and tried to kill him off in a story called *813*. But it was no use – the demand for Arsène Lupin stories was so strong that he soon brought him back to life again. He continued to write successfully until the First World War broke out in 1914.

During the war, Maurice turned his attention to the plight of soldiers, visiting the injured and encouraging them in his home region of Normandy. He also bought his own house there, so that he could return whenever he wished. Then, once the war was over, his writing picked up again. And while Arsène Lupin granted him a comfortable life, he still longed to become a success as a “real”, serious writer, like his heroes Flaubert and Maupassant; he tried other kinds of works, and different characters, but none of them worked very well.

Eventually, as he grew older, Maurice Leblanc began to accept that Arsène Lupin had given him a happy, successful life, even though he hadn’t achieved all he’d hoped for. So he named his house in Normandy after him, calling it Clos Lupin. And well before he died, two new Hollywood films were made featuring his charming gentleman burglar, ensuring that Lupin’s fame reached far beyond the shores of France. The first, *Arsène Lupin*, came out in 1932, and it was followed by a sequel in 1938 called *The Return of Arsène Lupin*.

By that time, however, Maurice was growing old, and his health was suffering. He died in 1941, not at home in Normandy but in Perpignan, where he had fled to in order to escape the Nazi invasion during the Second World War. He was seventy-six years old. His body was buried in the famous Montparnasse cemetery in Paris. Following his death, Arsène Lupin lived on – in adaptations, imitations, plays, films, TV series, comics and even video games. Perhaps most intriguing is the impact he has had in

Japan, where he inspired a whole series of manga comics and spin-offs.

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THE BOOK

The Arsène Lupin books, for all their success, were not the sort of works that Maurice Leblanc truly wanted to write. So where did he find the inspiration for his gentleman-thief? It seems likely that there was more than one source. In the early 1900s, there was a notorious criminal in France named Marius Jacob, a clever but principled burglar who would only steal from people he thought deserved it. Between 1900 and 1903, he and his accomplices carried out over 150 burglaries in Paris. Eventually he was caught, and put on trial in Amiens. People flocked there to see what would happen to him; it is perhaps no coincidence that this trial took place in 1905 – the year that Arsène Lupin first appeared in the journal *Je Sais Tout*. Jacob was convicted and sentenced to forced labour; but the fictional Arsène Lupin continued his antics.

There is another likely source for the character, however. Across the channel in England, author E.W. Hornung had started writing a string of short stories that featured Arthur J. Raffles. Raffles was a very British character, obsessed with playing cricket; but he was also a gentleman-thief. The success of these stories in England almost certainly spurred both Maurice Leblanc and the editor of *Je Sais Tout* to attempt something similar in France.

The first Lupin story, ‘The Arrest of Arsène Lupin’, published in *Je Sais Tout* in 1905, did not include any reference to Arthur Conan Doyle’s creation, Sherlock Holmes. But it didn’t take long for Maurice to realize that using this famous English fictional detective could increase the popularity of his own stories. The following year, in 1906, he published another short story entitled ‘Sherlock Holmes Arrives Too Late’. When Conan Doyle heard about it, he was furious, and insisted that Maurice change the name of the character. Maurice did as he requested – but not by very much. When the stories were compiled into a single book entitled *Arsène Lupin: Gentleman-Thief* (published in 1907), Sherlock Holmes had become Herlock Sholmes instead.

Conan Doyle’s anger did not stop Maurice Leblanc from stealing Sherlock Holmes again, along with his friend Watson (under the name of Wilson). The title *Arsène Lupin vs Herlock Sholmes* appeared in 1908, and

contained two stories: 'The Blonde Lady' and 'The Jewish Lamp'. In both of them, Sherlock Holmes is summoned from London to help on a mysterious case. It was clear that on one level, Leblanc had deep respect for Conan Doyle's character: Holmes manages to obtain the blue diamond in 'The Blonde Lady' and solve the mystery in 'The Jewish Lamp'. The description of Holmes in 'The Blonde Lady' is full of praise for the detective's strengths. However, it's obvious that Maurice meant Lupin to be every bit as cunning and clever. He is also more likeable. Holmes is shown to be rather cold and unfeeling, while Lupin is a gentleman, adored by women. And as for Watson... Maurice treats him with no respect at all. While in Conan Doyle's stories Watson is the narrator who is actually quite useful to Holmes, in the Arsène Lupin stories everything he says is either pompous, or a little bit stupid.

Maurice made use of Holmes in two more stories, but never to the same extent. Holmes appeared in *The Hollow Needle* and in *813*, but played a much more minor role. The novel *813* was also the one in which Maurice killed off his hero; but when he brought him back to life (saying that he had faked his own death), Sherlock Holmes had completely disappeared from the new stories.

THE CHARACTERS

Both stories

Arsène Lupin

Charming, cultured, clever and well connected, Arsène Lupin is Leblanc's "anti-hero" – even though he is a master-criminal who succeeds in stealing priceless objects and jewels, he is still likeable, and always comes out on top. Women love him and sometimes turn to him to help them out of difficult situations, as Alice Demun does in 'The Jewish Lamp'.

Herlock Sholmes

Maurice Leblanc's version of the English private detective Sherlock Holmes is brilliant, highly observant and quick-witted – just as he is in Sir Arthur Conan Doyle's stories. But he is rather cruel towards his friend Watson, and although he manages to solve the mysteries in both stories, he never manages completely to outwit Arsène Lupin.

Wilson

In Sir Arthur Conan Doyle's stories, Watson is Holmes's friend who plays an important role in helping him solve mysteries – and in fact, most of the stories are told from his perspective. In Maurice Leblanc's stories, however, Wilson is a rather foolish, dimwitted character. He adores Sholmes even when Sholmes treats him very badly and suffers injuries in both stories in this collection.

Detective Justin Ganimard

Detective Ganimard is a capable, honest, hard-working police detective – but he is always one step behind both Arsène Lupin (and Sherlock Holmes). He is rather like the character Lestrade in Arthur Conan Doyle's Sherlock Holmes stories.

Folenfant

A police officer on Ganimard's team, who crops up briefly in both stories.

'The Blonde Lady'

Monsieur Gerbois

In 'The Blonde Lady', M. Gerbois sets the story rolling with his purchase of a pretty writing desk for his daughter. He is stubborn, and will not give

up the desk even for a good price. Little does he know that Arsène Lupin wants the desk more than he does – and will steal to lay his hands on it.

Suzanne Gerbois

Suzanne is M. Gerbois's beloved daughter, who longs to get married. The story that unfolds around the writing desk is crucial for her, because in order for her to marry, her father needs to pay a dowry. But he loses his winning lottery ticket when Arsène Lupin steals the desk.

Monsieur Detinan

Arsène Lupin's lawyer, who is always ready to help the master criminal out if necessary. One of the scenes in 'The Blonde Lady' takes place in his office.

Baron d'Hautrec

The Baron is the owner of the stunning blue diamond that once formed part of the royal crown of France – that is, until he is brutally murdered.

Countess de Crozon

The Countess is a wealthy American who buys the blue diamond following Baron d'Hautrec's murder. Soon afterwards, however, the diamond is stolen – by the woman she thinks is her friend, Madame Réal.

Lucien Destange

A retired but reputable architect, who appoints Arsène Lupin (under the name of Maxime Bermond) to oversee some of his final projects. Little does he know that Lupin will take advantage of the situation to create a series of secret passages between the houses.

Clotilde Destange/Antoinette Bréhat/Madame de Réal

All these characters are none other than the "blonde lady" herself – elegant, tall, pale and refined. She is Lucien Destange's daughter, so Clotilde is her true name and the others are false ones. She adores Arsène Lupin and would do anything to please him – even steal a diamond...

'The Jewish Lamp'

Baron d'Imbleville

A young, charming Baron who adores his wife and children, but gets caught up in the story created by his wife, Monsieur Bresson and Alice Demun.

Suzanne d'Imblevalle

Baron D'Imblevalle's beloved wife, Suzanne has a secret that will end up being crucial to the story.

Sophie and Henriette d'Imblevalle

The young daughters of the Baron and Suzanne d'Imblevalle. Without realizing it, the youngest daughter Henriette gives Sherlock Holmes a vital clue.

Alice Demun

Pretty and courageous, Alice is the governess in the d'Imblevalle household. She tries to warn Sherlock Holmes not to get involved with the case, because it will lead only to unhappiness. She also nurses Wilson as he lies in bed injured.

Monsieur Bresson

Although M. Bresson appears only briefly, he is, as a blackmailing villain, the key to the whole story of 'The Jewish Lamp'.

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THE RISE OF THE DETECTIVE NOVEL

Maurice Leblanc's stories about Arsène Lupin were hugely successful, but their theme was not particularly original. Lupin was not the first fictional "gentleman-thief"; the character of Arthur Raffles had already been created in a number of short stories by E.W. Hornung. But being original wasn't really the point – for Maurice's publishers, it was more important to be popular, and to sell lots of copies.

This is probably why Maurice chose to make use of Sherlock Holmes, who was the most successful character in a new, and increasingly popular, kind of book: the detective novel. In 'The Blonde Lady', Maurice even makes a reference to this new kind of story by comparing Sherlock Holmes with two other great fictional detectives, Auguste Dupin and Monsieur Lecoq. Over time, detective novels began to have similar characteristics – for example, the villain was the character least suspected by the reader, there was usually a fairly useless police officer in charge of the case and the detective reached his conclusions logically. Here we look at where the genre first started, and where it went next.

Edgar Allan Poe

Edgar Allan Poe was a nineteenth-century American writer. His writing was varied, and included poetry, literary criticism, short stories and essays. Although he didn't write any detective *novels* (only short stories), he is generally thought of as one of the fathers of the genre. This was thanks to one particular short story, 'The Murders in the Rue Morgue' (published in 1841), which featured a character named Auguste Dupin who solves the murder of a woman and her daughter. Dupin uses reason and logic to understand and solve the crime; he is not actually a professional detective – he solves crimes simply because he wants to – but he paved the way for detectives in future stories. After creating him, Poe used Dupin in two more stories.

Émile Gaboriau

It wasn't just in English that the detective novel began to develop. In France, Émile Gaboriau wrote stories that featured a police officer called Monsieur Lecoq. The novel *Monsieur Lecoq* appeared in 1868. Lecoq himself, unlike Dupin or Sherlock Holmes, is a police officer, although he

does sometimes work with private detective Tabaret. Lecoq does have some typical features of detectives, however – he is brilliant at disguise; he is also very logical, and examines a crime scene very carefully. Gaboriau used the character of Lecoq many times in the novels that followed.

Wilkie Collins

In 1968, the same year that *Monsieur Lecoq* appeared in France, Wilkie Collins wrote the first English-language detective novel. It was called *The Moonstone*, and it is about a famous Indian diamond (the “Moonstone”) inherited by a young English girl from her uncle (who has stolen it). She wears it to her eighteenth birthday party, and it disappears. The theft of the diamond and various deaths form the heart of the mystery. The story contains several elements that were used repeatedly by detective novelists in the future: many twists and turns; a talented amateur detective; an English country house as its setting – and a villain who turns out to be someone the reader is least expecting.

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle

The world had to wait almost twenty years for the next great fictional detective to come along – but when he arrived, he proved to be perhaps the greatest of them all. Sir Arthur Conan Doyle’s first Sherlock Holmes novel, *A Study in Scarlet*, was published in 1886. Holmes, with his eccentric personality and uncanny powers of observation and logic, soon proved to be a hit with the public. Like Maurice Leblanc, Conan Doyle felt he really should be writing something better than exciting detective stories, but it was hard to resist the pressure from his publishers and fans. Just as Leblanc killed off Arsène Lupin, Doyle killed Holmes in ‘The Final Problem’ of 1893 – but was persuaded to make him reappear again. In total, he wrote fifty-six short stories and four novels with Sherlock Holmes as their hero.

Agatha Christie

The last Sherlock Holmes story appeared in 1927. By then, this kind of story had become so popular that the 1920s and 1930s are known as the “Golden Age of Detective Fiction”. Freeman Wills Crofts, Dorothy L. Sayers and Philip MacDonald were just some of the writers involved, but Agatha Christie outstripped all the others in terms of success and fame. In fact, she became one of the best-selling writers the world has ever seen.

Agatha Christie didn't stick to just one detective. Many of her stories featured the quirky Belgian Hercule Poirot, others the nosey old lady Miss Marple, and a few others had different characters altogether. Generally speaking, there is at least one murder in each story, and many suspects. English country houses are a favourite setting, along with exotic locations such as Egypt. And at the end, there is often a gathering called by the detective, in which everyone's secrets – including the murderer's – are revealed.

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TEST YOURSELF

Have you followed the details of the stories as closely as Herlock Sholmes? Or are you always one step behind the facts, like Ganimard? Test yourself here. Answers are on [page 219](#).

1. When the writing desk is stolen, Monsieur Gerbois soon realizes that it contains a valuable item. Is it:
 - A) His grandfather's watch
 - B) A winning lottery ticket
 - C) A wad of banknotes
 - D) A pearl necklace
2. Mademoiselle Antoinette is employed by Baron d'Hautrec as a:
 - A) Gardener
 - B) Cook
 - C) Nurse
 - D) Secretary
3. The famous blue diamond originally formed part of:
 - A) The royal crown of France
 - B) Wilson's shoe buckle
 - C) An earring belonging to Susanne Gerbois
 - D) The French president's tiepin
4. Herlock Sholmes gets back to France in the nick of time by:
 - A) Shooting the captain of the *Hirondelle*
 - B) Hitching a lift on a hay wagon
 - C) Pretending to be Dr Wilson
 - D) Changing the clocks on the *Hirondelle*
5. When Arsène Lupin finally gives up the blue diamond, he reveals it was hidden:
 - A) In his waistcoat pocket
 - B) Inside the knob of his cane
 - C) In a hole in a tree
 - D) Inside a loaf of bread
6. In 'The Jewish Lamp', Wilson gets injured. Is he:
 - A) Knocked off a bicycle

- B) Shot in the foot
 - C) Stabbed in the chest
 - D) Hit by a falling bag of sand
7. Herlock Sholmes and Arsène Lupin both end up in the river, because:
- A) Lupin makes a hole in the boat
 - B) They fall off a bridge
 - C) Their boat hits a rock
 - D) Sholmes chases Lupin into the water
8. At the end of the story, Alice Demun is about to begin a new life
- A) As Sholmes's assistant
 - B) In England
 - C) At the local circus
 - D) In prison

Answers

1-B

2-D

3-A

4-D

5-B

6-C

7-A

8-B

SCORES

1 to 3 correct: Arsène Lupin has stolen your marbles. **4 to 6 correct:** You're one step ahead of Ganimard... **7 to 8 correct:** Congratulations! Who needs Herlock Sholmes on the case?

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Glossary

acanthus A spiky plant often represented on column capitals.

acoustic Producing sound.

adjacent to Next to.

aerostatic Relating to hot-air ballons.

anthropometric Relating to the study of the proportions of the human body.

Arrondissement An administrative district in Paris and other large French cities.

artlessly Naively.

au revoir “Goodbye” (French).

bon voyage “(Have a) good journey” (French).

capital The top section of a pillar, usually decorated.

complicity The act of being involved in a crime.

concierge A resident caretaker in an apartment building.

convolutions Complexities.

coups de théâtre Unexpected turns of events.

Croix d’Honneur A French military decoration.

crestfallen Disappointed.

deductions Logical conclusions.

dirigible Airship.

dowry The money brought by bride’s family to the household upon marriage.

eddy A small whirlpool.

ferrule A metal cap at the end of a walking stick.

fob watch An old-fashioned pocket watch which was attached to the coat or trousers with a chain.

frugal Thrifty.

funnel The metal chimney on a steamship.

examining magistrate A judge who carries out criminal investigations.

hindquarters The back legs of an animal.

horsepower A unit of measurement of power.

hypothesis An initial explanation or assumption that is the starting point

of an investigation.

import Significance.

ineffable Unutterable.

inexorable Unstoppable.

Kaiser Emperor.

labyrinth Maze.

leagues A unit of measurement, often equivalent to three miles.

Légion d'Honneur A French order of merit.

letter of A letter written by someone of high social

introduction standing in order to introduce someone to a specific high-ranking person or social circle.

louis d'or A French gold coin.

lyricism A particular beautiful, poetic or melodramatic expression of emotion.

Maestro Master (from the Italian).

Maître Master (the formal French way to address a lawyer).

maître d'hôtel The manager of a restaurant's waiting staff.

modulated Varied in pitch or tone.

negligible Close to nothing.

objets d'art Decorative objects.

omniscience The state of knowing or being aware of everything.

organ A newspaper which acts as a mouthpiece for a particular person or organization.

paradoxical Said of something which appears to be self-contradictory.

petite-bourgeoise A lower-middle-class woman, typically conservative and conventional in her taste and outlook.

pneumatic post A former method of delivering post in cylinders, which are shot through pipes using compressed air.

pommel The rounded handle of a cane.

poste restante Post kept aside for an agreed period at the post office for collection by the addressee.

post-mortem After death.

receptacle Container.

rendezvous A meeting arranged at a specific time and place.

Republican Guard A military division in France which gives protection to important state buildings.

rowlocks The braces on a boat that keep the oars in place.
salon Reception room.
sententiously In a self-righteous, moralizing tone.
sine qua non A condition that is essential for something to happen.
sou A French coin of small value.
stiletto A small, thin dagger.
stratagems Schemes.
Sûreté The former name for the investigative arm of the French police.
tabernacle A container for the sacrament in a church.
touché An exclamation which acknowledges a clever remark made by one's opponent.
valet de chambre A personal attendant.
vindicate To prove something or somebody to be right.
visiting card A card with one's name and address.

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Thomas Müller is one of Germany's best-known illustrators. He has produced posters for the theatre, picture books for children (such as *Magoosy* and *Mr Jack* for Macmillan) and illustrated books by iconic authors such as Raymond Chandler and Charles Bukowski. Thomas is Professor of Illustration at Leipzig Art University. He lives in Leipzig and has a growing collection of old cars.

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